ALIEN: Dark Whispers

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Chapter 1.

"Wake up pretty boy!" laughs a marine with a gentle slap to my face.

The cold air hits my bare legs like a wall. This is always the worst part of waking out of hyper sleep. Tugs and pulls rouse me out of my slumber as various needles, probes and sensors are pulled out. I crack my eyes to blazing light.

"Jesus, could you turn the lights up even more?" I grunt back.

"Oh, now you're awake," laughs a voice.

I know that voice. My brain is starting to come back online. Corpsman something or other, it'll come to me. Dickenson is the corpsman. And as they go, at least not a total asshole to me.

"Chow in twenty, muster in an hour," replies Dickenson.

Apparently she's looked me over and decided to move on. As my vision adjusts, I lift my head to a satisfying crack as my spine decides it wants to stretch. I look down the line of hyper sleep chambers. This half open, the other half closed. I mentally count, even. No hyper sleep casualties. The USN DeBrasco is the third ship of the modular *Gladiator* class of starships and has the latest generation everything, including the next generation hyper sleep modules. I stagger over to my locker, my muscles protesting with every step.

The black Basic Dress Uniform is yet another way I'm a bit different from your standard Colonial Space Marine. The collar manages to perfectly rub against my neck right where my neural shunt and the skin meet. I'm convinced the BDU designers designed it this way. Yet another annoyance my brain registers.

"Waking up is always the worst," mumbles a voice next to me. I look over and see Janice. A fellow cyber tech. The BDU is are even more ill fitting on her. Her petite size in stark contrast to everything designed for large, muscle bound marines. I notice she's donned a scarf around her neck to deal with the collar chaffing issue. Janice and I have a complicated thing going. She comes over and gives me a hug. I hug back. Ah, no kiss, still complicated. We wander down the line of lockers collecting the other four members of our rag tag cybertech gang. All together we head into the chow hall.

The chow hall of this ship is the usual. Polished metal, food you'd rather not eat, created out of who knows what. With it comes the usual derisive sneers, outright jeers and the occasional head shake from the marines. As usual, they have left a table just for us. We get in line with the rest.

"Why the fuck did they send six of you?" I hear from behind me, exacerbated with a poke.

I turn, and looking down at me is a marine easily a foot taller and about twice as wide.

"Fuck if I know. Why did they send so many marines?" I ask back.

At this the marines snickers, "Fuck if I know," he laughs back.

The eggs are in a cube, the bacon is fake, something is clearly wrong with the food printer, my bread has actual layer shift lines, I shake my head in disgust. Despite all the improvements in star ships and hyper sleep chambers, apparently the auto cook was low on their priorities.

I take my place in the center of the table, a spot left for me by Janice.

"Five to one," Marco mumbles, "They send thirty marines and six cybertechs."

"More than that," replies Janice, "They only opened half the pods. It's ten to one."

"Not quite. I looked at the roster, those are a bunch of scientists and technicians. Marco is right, they did bring quite a few marines," I reply.

"Why so many?" Marco asks. He's asking me because I'm technically considered the senior officer of us cyber-techs. Technically, because the Colonial Marines, in their disdain, exclude the cybernetics technicians out of their usual chain of command. Cybernetics Technician First Class is all the rank I'll ever get, unless I want to head off to *real* boot camp. The fact we even get to call ourselves marines pisses off the regular marines. All the rigor, all the physical training, all the crawling in mud, zero g combat stuff they do, we don't. Instead it's lots of invasive surgery for neural shunts, brain augmentation devices and lots and lots of studying.

"Are they planning on going down?" asks Ruvi, yet another long standing member of our cyber-tech squad. All these questions I don't have answers to.

"I know only a tiny bit more than you guys do. I got roughly the same orders you got, showed up to the same packaging facility and found myself here."

They know I know more, but realizing that I'm not going to divulge more details in present company, everybody gets back to the business of eating their slop. The other three members of the squad having asked no questions, were still in the shell shock phase of this whole thing. Reaching across the table I pat Jeremy on the shoulder.

"How you handling your first trip as a cyber so far?" I ask.

"Better than I thought. Damn neural shunt is itching like hell though."

I get up and look at his neck. It's red as hell. He was the only member of our team who was a former Colonial Marine. In some ways it pisses the other marines off even more.

"After muster, go find Dickinson and have her look at that." He nods. I know he won't, he'll suffer in silence.

Chapter 2.

We line up on our spot on the muster line. The marines line up ramrod straight.

"Company at attention!" yells a sergeant.

"Attend hut!" the marines yell back, echoing through the cavernous chamber. Our group manages to bellow out an "Attend hut" with the rest of them. The sergeant walks the line. Stopping at Janice.

"Is that scarf regulation Ms. Allman?" snaps the sergeant.

"No sir," she replies.

"Lose it!" he replies, shaking his head and moving down the line. At this a couple of marines snort. A loose button, a couple BDU's not cuffed properly. He's a real stickler for detail.

"Ready Room one, on the double!" yells the sergeant, now happy that in the case of sudden depressurization of the hull, or fire, at least the forty odd people's corpses will look good. Being last in line, the room has exactly thirty seats. We all know our spot on the line and the number of seats is without accident. We dutifully stand in the back. The usual mild hazing, the norm.
Seeing this, the sergeant snaps, "Get our techs some seats!"

At this a marine out loud jokes, "Why, all they do is sit anyway?"

"Stow it Wikowsky and now you're getting them seats!" the sergeant barks back. From a recess on the wall, additional flat pack desk chairs are unpacked and handed out. Satisfied everybody now has seats, the CO strides in. We all stand extra straight. Looking everybody over, he nods.

"At ease, let's get started." We all take our seats. Robinson is as classic a commanding officer of the Colonial Marines as one could make. Crisp uniform, polished boots, name tag centered perfectly.

A wall screen starts up showing a planet of swirl of muddled oranges, browns and whites. Below it are bold letters that read "LV426 (Acheron)". Head nods and fist bumps ripple through the Marines.

"Welcome back to the shit hole known as LV426. Also know as Acheron, Hadley's Hope and a few other wilder and more colorful names. We all know this is also the first planet where we encountered what is now known as the Xenomorph." A murmur moves through the room. A couple marines shake their fists in the ar, a Xenomorph head tattooed on the back of their hands. Robinson gives them the *are we done now look.*

"Our job here is to recon the planet to evaluate it for habitability and additional threats. Even though the primary atmospheric processor that was installed near the settlement was destroyed, the four additional automated atmospheric processors have continued to function. Wayland has spent considerable money on this planet and they've hired this outfit to ensure that there is nothing left of the previous tenants."

So, this is a corporate gig, it makes sense. Why abandon a perfectly serviceable planet just because it had had a few pesky inhabitants? At this a marines hand shot up.

"Yes Corporal?" Robinson asks.

"What if we find more hostiles?" the corporal asks.

"Recon first, hostile elimination if needed." replies the CO. I knew this was coming. I'd been given a prior briefing explaining some of the mission parameters. The moment we came out of hyperspace, we began mapping the surface. The screen changes to show the planet without the clouds. A quick zoom in shows the crater where the primary atmospheric processor and the settlement had been. The other atmospheric processors are highlighted on the map, as well as a red zone.

"This is the location of the derelict alien ship. It is known to contain Xenomorph eggs. It is considered a no-go zone. Our objectives are the processors. In particular processors two and three that have gone off the grid." The screen turns off.

"Cyber will be landing Rockies first, then if needed, marines," Robinson finishes.

Hands slapped desks, general groans, more than a couple marines looked back and gave us looks I'm sure their grandmothers would have disapproved of. Since the original events on LV426, the Xenomorph had become a cultural boogie man for the Colonial Marines. More than a few marines in this group sport Xenomorph tattoos and talk righteously of avenging their fallen brothers. Here they are, at the place it had first gone down and the prospect of unleashing hell on their enemies is being snatched from them. Jeremy had told me that a big part of their training now consisted of simulated combat with Xenomorphs. Guys build tiny shrines depicting their eventual victories over this foe. Xenomorph heads as trophies are a popular thing to come out of the various printers. I wasn't unsympathetic to their feelings or cause. Though to me, going nose to nose with a predator that could at best kill me or at worst use me as a womb for another Xenomorph doesn't sound appealing at all. As far as I am concerned, I'm more than happy to merely orbit the planet. Landing in ankle deep mud and fighting monsters is a job for robots and these guys.

The events on LV426 had lead to me being here. After the debacle, the military realized that threats like the Xenomorphs weren't going to be easily tackled by men and women in body armor. Two major innovations happened that changed things in a big way. The first was the subspace radio. This allowed for far faster comms across stellar distances and near instantaneous communications within a single solar system, taking control and sensing to the next level. The second innovation was the creation of neural shunt technology that allowed for the true blending of man and machine. Suddenly the military was presented with the reality of having robots they could control at great distances. You might be asking why even come on this ship then? As the Astro techs have tried to explain some of the math, the farther you are away, the lower the amount of bandwidth. Communicating with Earth is now so slow it can be measured in bits per minute.

As this session drags on and various training and maintenance tasks are handed out, a few marines grouse more and more about not getting down to the planet, I wonder why they'd even been thawed. A thought a couple marines express as well. Others take it in stride. Fine if they not going to get down to the planet, they are going to be riding our asses and looking at every pixel we fed back. This whole thing was going to be hot garbage anyway you cut it. With the dog and pony show concluded, Robinson strides out the ready room, ramrod straight with his admin in tow.

"Deployment will be at 0700 tomorrow. Cybers prep for drop. Dismissed!" barks the Sargent. Walking back to our module the grumbles in the halls get louder.

Wikowsky pushes his way up to our group, stabbing a finger in my chest, "All this bullshit so you weenies can shuffle around in your tin cans?"

I've been to this rodeo plenty of times. The trick was to show the guy think you're in the same boat as him and then give him a carrot.

"Look man, I'm just following orders like the rest of you. If we find something, you'll see it as well. The feeds will be going to everybody."

"The Mark I eyeball is all I need." he replies which brings out a couple *yeas* from the group that has formed around us. I could sense the tension in the air, this guy had a Xenomorph tattoo on his forearm.

"We have chain of command for a reason. Talk to your CO, I've got orders." I shrug at Wikowsky. The trick is not to get ruffled. Please the ignorant guy just taking orders. Jeremy's hand catches Wikowsky's fist millimeters from my face, he then spins into a jujitsu move that has Wikowsky

pinned to the wall. Nose to nose, Jeremy growls, "Stow it. We've got enough going on without your bullshit as well." At this, Jeremy drops the lock and gave the guy a good shove. We turn and walk away.

"Keep walking," Wikowsky yells at me. After a couple more paces he finishes with, "He's a traitor to the Corps and you're not even fucking marines. Why they let you chicken shits on this mission I'll never know."

Sadly, this isn't the first time I've dealt with this. Turning, I point to camera in the the corner of the halway and say, "Tsk tsk."

Realizing that like every part of the ship, this is being recorded, he finally gets the hint, turns heel and stomps off.

"What a fucking hot head," quips Janice.

"Seriously. How did he get through the damn pysch eval?" jokes Marco.

Jeremy snickers, "You have no idea what they look for in an marine, by their standards, he's perfect." Marco and Ruvi just shake their heads.

Chapter 3.

0700 from now gives us nearly ten hours to do final load out on our Rockies. The real name is some word salad of "Remotely Operational Cyber Kinetic Enabled Recon Systems" or some shit. Everybody just called them *Rocky's* in an homage to the old film about a boxer and the rock'em sockem robots game that someone had dutifully printed out and affixed to the wall of the prep room. The other funnier name that went around was "killer mushrooms" due to the large sensor dome that affords the operator a 360 degree view of their surroundings. On four articulated legs and with two powerful arms and two smaller manipulator arms, they could damn near climb anything, cut through anything and come home to talk about it. Covered in high tech ceramic armor and bristling with weapon hard points they could take a beating and also bring a substantial amount of firepower to a situation. For this mission we'd also been issued "SLEDs." The full name was Surface Long Endurance Vehicles, but like everything in the military it needed a nickname. They are surface vehicles that contain their own power supplies and can carry a pair of Rockies great distances, as well as carry spares and additional ammo. Cradled in their storage units, we looked at the load out manifests for the six Rockies.

"What the fuck is this shit?" quips Jeremy. I come over to look at his tablet.

"Glue dispensers?" pointing to the tablet. I take a deep breath, time for the rest of the briefing.

"Everybody take a seat." I say.

"The marines got told what they needed, we have secondary orders to capture a Xenomorph if possible. Hence the aforementioned glue dispensers."

"Then do what? Bring it on this ship? No fucking way," replies Janice.

"According to the brass they've got some magic resin to encase and rendered them inert," I explain.

"Jesus have mercy on us." mumbles Marco and he kisses the pendant around his neck.
The last member of our group is a petite woman named Roberta, who goes by the Roxie.

"Roxie, You've been quiet through all this. Feel free to speak up."

At this, she let out a sigh. "A missions a mission, but this seems like a really bad one. I've read the files on what those things are capable of. Acid for blood, super strong, immune to vacuum. Has one even been captured to test this containment on?"

We all know the answer to that. Even if one had been, we'd have been the last to be told about it.

"I know saying trust the system is cliché here, but in this case, we're going to have to roll with it."

Everybody nods. We all know the score. There are bigger things afoot here, we just aren't entirely privy to all the details.

"Look on the bright side, we've got latitude on our load outs. Pack for a party!" Like kids in a candy store, everybody gets to work. Ammo drums are hosted into place, bolts tightened, connectors checked. Over the next three hours drop details are fed to my tablet.

Ruvi pings me. "Do we even know the drop point?" he asks. In response, I forward the entire intel packet to everybody on the team.

"Sir, you just gave me everything." replies Ruvi.

"Yes. I've got that power and I'm using it. Let's not go in with eyes half open. Two teams. Team One is Myself, Marco and Janice. Team Two is Ruvi, Roxie and Jeremy."

I want to make sure there is someone senior on each team. Roxie has a cool head and is a solid, respected leader in the group. More data flows in. Team one is going to investigate why atmospheric processor two isn't calling home. Team two is going to investigate the third processor plants power output is down. Everybody nods happily with this arrangement.

"Let's get some rest, at up at 0400 and by 0500, I expect everybody ready to enter their cradles and jack in."

Chapter 4.

Dinner is somewhat nicer than our wake up meal. Apparently a tech had tinkered with the auto cook because I get something that resembles an actual hamburger. Not ones to complain, we eat our soy protein burgers, head back and hit the sack. We get the usual side eye and head shakes but we're left unmolested otherwise.

0400 is damn early, anyway you cut it. The marines make you get used to it, but it's still rough. I get up, knock on doors and got sundry mumbles. Roxie and Ruvi appear to be rooming together, honestly, I not surprised and I'm happy for them.

Janice strides out of her quarters, haptic suit on and ready to roll. The two of us exchange knowing glances as Janice glances at Roxie's door and raises her eyebrows, I shrug back. I'd been hoping for a late night knock myself that never came.

In a special area in our module called "The Pit", the six cradles are sunk into the floor arraigned in a semi circle. As Janice and I are warm up our cradles, the other members stroll in, hot coffees in hand and climb down into the pit to start their warm up procedures. For cybernetics technicians, jacking in has a number of serious dangers. The most common one for newer users is known as transition shock. Your brain is quite happy with all the usual sensory inputs and then you pull the rug out and give it a whole new and different set of additional inputs. Our group at this point has been jacking in at the low end for two years, and at the high end, like myself, for nearly a decade. I slide my head back into the cradle and feel the click of the interface to my neural shunt. My head now locked in place, the visor slides down and I feel the various cinch points as the haptic suit pins me down.

"Initiate transition," I say and immediately I'm dropped into darkness.

"Commander, unit number one is ready," a voice whispers in my mind.

"Thank you Alice," I say, but my lips don't move. I'm fully shunted in. Alice is the system AI for our team. We're encouraged to give them a name and interact with them as full team member. With so much data flowing in, without an AI to help collate it, you'd quickly be overwhelmed.

"Team One ready," I say into the comms channel.

"Team Two ready," Roxie replies.

Bringing up the diagnostics for all six units, I see all six techs are fully shunted in. Good, everybody has jacked in without issue. I switch over to the command channel.

"Cybertech teams One and Two ready," I say into the channel.

"Roger that. Hold tight, we are adjusting our orbit for optimal insertion," a voice says back. In the channel I'm designated "Team One Lead". Roxie is designated as “Team Two Lead”. The Ops CO speaks up.

"Team One, prepare for touchdown in forty minutes, thirty seconds. Team Two, touchdown in 50 minutes, 45 seconds."

This part is a bit of a nothing burger for us, just the usual hurry up and wait. The SLEDs and our Rockies will either make it to the ground in one piece, or they drop more. We have six units, plus an additional six ready to go and as many in spares so that another six can be assembled if needed. Plus a plethora of raw materials and our module has an advanced manufacturing node that can print nearly any spare we might need. We use this time we access the various optical systems on the nadir side of the ship and do recon on the surface of the planet.

While our module has it’s own optical systems, the ship has it’s own separate module with several multimeter sized optics packages as well as powerful lidar and radar systems.

Janice pings me. "Glad we've got subspace on the rocky’s, it looks like one hell of storm in the north."

I change my perspective and she is right. While always harsh, the detonation of the primary processor had thrown gigatons of dust into the atmosphere, helping to trap more heat and ironically speeding up the terraforming process. A wet and rainy planet, now with extra heat pumped into it, meant big storms. I shift between the optics on our module and the one on the DeBe. For being a relatively small planetoid it’s got interesting terrain because of weathering.

“Unit One deployed.” says the Ops CO.

I acknowledge I’ve seen the message.

“Unit two deployed” and I acknowledge again.

Timers start in all our displays. I feel the knots of tension building. The joys of having a neural shunt. Some of my team members feelings leak in.

Breaking the tension, Marco cuts in. "I wonder if the issue with unit three was water intrusion or a bolt of lightning?" Privately I hope, though these atmo processors are built to be dropped from orbit and "just work."

Bringing up the schematics of the ‘Wayland Yutani SCFAP’ facility I study the layout one last time.

The timers tick to zero and I watch as the telemetry flows back. Bingo, five by five, confirmation of soft landing. The petals of the drop capsule unfold. I see The mobile sleds petals fall away and its treads lock down. All green. Already the sensors on my rocky are registering a gust of 50km/h. I unlimber my rocky from it’s drop landing configuration and hop off the descent platform, my robots articulated feet sink into the mud.

“Wow, this place is pleasant” laughs Janice. Everybody acknowledges, more out of sense of wry humor than much else.

Alice shifts through the spectrum's, nothing. Without needing any urging, we proceed towards the processing plant. The plant looks like a pyramid. Thirty meters tall and fifty meters on a side, clad in black durasteel, It’s sunk a story into the ground it sticks out in the barren wasteland. Around the top are vents. Steam is rising from the central vent. Scanning the around the unit I see the entrance sticking out in contrast the processors sloped sides. Fuck. The blast doors are ajar, at least a couple centimeters.

"I was really hoping to find nobody home," Janice whispers into the chat.

"Me too," I whisper back.

I notice that Alice had already brought all our weapons online. Alice and I had been paired more than five years ago, it had gotten some intuition about it and I appreciate it.

"No damage to the doors," Alice notes.

“Maybe just a mechanical screw up?” Marco wonders out loud.

Marco creeps forward, deploying the smaller set of dexterous hands on the Rocky, he manipulates the door controls. It grinds open a couple more centimeters. Still too small to deploy a drone.

"That's all I'm going to get, the mechanism is seized or jammed, I can't tell from here," he notes. Not surprising, water and mud have likely gotten into the track. I move forward and look closer. I unlimber my big arms and attempt to pry the doors, but they only start to deform.

Time to ask to break stuff. "Permission to cut into the blast doors?" I inquire.

"Granted. Breach the doors and enter," Robinson orders.

My plasma torch makes quick work of the blast doors. Plates of durasteel fall to the mud with a sizzle. All three rocky's stalk through the steaming opening into the lower entry bay of atmospheric processor number three.

"Fuck me," whispers Marco. Behind me I can see that the door mechanism is gummed up with Alien excretion. Every wall and the ceiling are caked with it. Frozen into the slime are various shapes, their chests burst open, but so coated in slime and decayed as to make them unrecognizable.

"Confirmed evidence of hostiles," I share into the channel.

"Roger that. Team Two confirms evidence of hostiles as well," comes through on the command channel.

"I don't understand, there's nothing on this rock for them to eat or use as wombs?" Marco gestures at the wall.

"Eh, please don't say womb." replies Janice. I can feel her disgust in the channel. One of the dangers of being jacked in; bits of emotion travel across the link between team members.

"Sorry." replies Marco.

"Get samples," comes through the channel.

"Roger Wilco," I bark back. A compartment in the front of my Rocky opens, I dutifully scrape some of the alien excretions/slime into the container, loading the container, the compartment snaps shut. Through my haptic suit and neural link I can feel the building shuddering from the storm. I can feel the hum of the fusion reactor through the feet of my rocky. I see caked alien resin in the small stairwell that provides access to the atmo's three floors.

"Deploy recon drones" I order. Triangular drones lift off from the top of each of our sensor stacks.

"Marco, Up, Janice down, I'll take straight ahead."

"Alice, can you identify any of the biologics that were encased in the wall?" I ask.

"Scanning them I see nothing that indicates they are human. However the remains are too decayed for positive idenification of base lifeform."

This is for the benefit of the marines I know are watching the feed. Alice helps controls the drones as they fly through the facility. Doppler radar pulses, wide band IR and optical scanners feed information back to Alice and into my mind, mapping out the facility and comparing it to schematics. I locate the nearest network interface and patch in after scraping slime off the port. The fusion reactor is

functioning but at near initial start up power. Its heat exchangers have been compromised. Enough power to keep things barely operational. Comms report as non operational. This smells exactly like the reports from the other facility. Why would they go after comms? I file it away to think about later.

"Contact," Janice announces into the channel, "Lower level, My drone got swatted out of the air. I have four distinct entities moving towards us."

"Xenomorphs?" I ask.

"It happened fast sir, the drone was nailed from above." A quick sensor replay shows the drone being swatted by the dark, vaguely biomechancial hand of a Xeno.

"Deploy another?" she asks.

"Save them. They know we're here." I bring the base's internal camera feeds up over the network Interface. Dozens of cameras and only 7 are operational? The operational ones have been encased in slime, their feeds useless. It seems the Xenomorphs intentionally covered them or destroyed them, but why would they know or care? Yet another question to file away. My drone returns. Nobody home on the ground level. At once all our trackers start pinging.

"Movement, upper and lower levels." Marco calls out.

I heard the tromping of feet on steel treads from above. These remote processor plants aren't that elaborate. A fusion reactor, large vents to draw in air, machinery to split out the bad stuff, add in the good stuff and shoot the atmosphere out. No control room, just a single console, spare parts storage and miles and miles of ducts, pipes and cables. A dozen xeno's spill out of the stairway. Some are full sized we've all seen in the archive footage, others are slightly smaller, thinner, paler Xenomorphs with weirdly curved heads. Training fully kicks in as I instinctively track and fired a three round burst through the closest Xeno. Configured to burst in the chest cavity, the first Xenomorph blows in half throwing green acidic blood and guts in every direction. Immediately a stripe of optics goes out on my sensor turret, automatically the turret rotates to put the blanked section at the back. Janice nails one of the smaller pale Xenomorphs with the glue canister. A thick mesh of adhesive entangles the creature. Milky white, it's identical to it's larger cousin, it struggles and snarls as the glue sets.

"Not sure how it would work against a big one, but we bagged ourselves a mini."

Marco, our resident nerd about all things Xenomorph chimes in, "None of the intel I've ever seen has shown one this small, or skinny, or this pale."

Small is relative. This creature is still near two meters tall, just very thin and pale, with an oddly shaped head that curls down. Xeno’s keep stalking forward now unsure what to do with these new foes. I order our team to back out of the processor. Acid eating through some critical part of the cooling system of the fusion reactor is definitely a "bad thing." I'm also keenly aware a 10mm caseless HE round in the wrong spot will quickly end this mission too. The xenos surge through the gap we'd cut in the door, only to be shredded three strides out. The assault ends quickly. Alice has kept a running count, eleven xeno’s in total. Janice creeps back inside and retrieves our prize, the glued down pale Xenomorph.

Marco is busy sampling the various fluids leaking from the xenos.

"This ain't good," he grumbles over the channel, "I've got a jar made out of our new super material, it held the Xeno blood for about five minutes."

Looking over I see his rocky holding up the jar, the bottom of it gone.

"Team One, return to dust off point with the specimen," I order.

At this Janice opens a Private channel. "This is bullshit. Marco just showed them that their magic test jar couldn't stop their blood. Do you want to be on the ship with that thing?"

The honest answer was no. I speak up, "Command, this is Team One leader. Reporting that our containment vessel failed. Requesting re-eval on return of specimen to DeBraso?"

"We are aware of the situation," comes the reply. It’s easy to forget that all our video is being distributed across the ship into various war rooms. Minutes go by as we wait. Privately in our channel we muse about conversations being had on the bridge.

"Orders are as follows, Restrain specimen to Marco's transport. Investigate transmitted grid location."

Marco immediately goes to his sled and unloads additional ammo canisters and a spare portable reactor.

Janice pipes up in our side channel, "What the fuck is the plan?"

"Dunno. Follow orders, go to the grid location," I said flatly.

We secure the Xeno to Marco's sled as it hisses and snaps at us. As soon as the last tie down is cinched, it promptly trundles off over the horizon, running on autopilot. We stow ourselves and the supplies onto the remaining sleds.

"That little one was weird, what was up with its head?" asks Marco.

Both Janice and I say nothing. This whole thing is weird and getting weirder. The sleds grind through the mud leaving deep furrows as they chug towards our next objective.

"Alice, please eject me," I said to the AI.

Immediately my senses revert back and I hit the release button. My visor slides back and I feel the neural shunt disengage. Janice and Marco step up out of the pit as well. I see both Janice and Marco at the med dispenser. The joys of long term cybernetic interfacing.

"Estimated travel time for the sleds to return is two hours," I say.

They nod. There are long term effects of the neural shunts. Headaches being the most common one. I could feel one brewing and in more than one way. I jogged slowly down one of the two central habitual spars that run the length of the ship. The job serves to get the blood flowing and to get some answers. Soon I find myself at the Combat Information Center door.

"Permission to Enter?" I asked at the intercom.

The door slides open. "Permission granted." Comes a gruff voice back. On the walls I can see the six views from the rocky's as the sled transport rumbles over the terrain. A tech turns and says over her shoulder,

"Team Three drop ship is nominal. ETA nine minutes."

Wait what, I reeled a bit. Another team? We are the only cyber-techs on the ship? This can only mean one thing.

Commander Robinson clears his throat, "As you are well aware PFC Hurgs, we are the middle of a mission. Other than stretching your legs, why are you in my CIC?"

"Sir, I'm concerned about the failure of Marco's Xeno containment vessel."

At this he shakes his head. "Son, you are well above your pay grade here. That's not the only vessel we brought with us. We've got the situation handled. Get back in your pit and get back to the mission. Dismissed."

This whole thing stinks. I deeply dislike being used as a cog in a machine I didn't know what direction it is traveling in. I walk back to our module. It’s full name is “Cybernetics Remote Operations Module.” However, the corps has an allergy to anything more than a three letter designation, so CRM it is. The marines jokingly call it “Candy Land.” This is in part out of jealousy because our quarters are nicer and partly because the module has red accents so it looks like a candy cane. As I walk back, it hits me who I might ask. I climb back into the pit, but I don't fully jack in. Instead I write up a quick note to

one of the techs I knew back on Earth. If anybody had been involved in the creation of the storage vessels, it is Dr. Stacey Jaggo. Normally our paths wouldn't have crossed except for the fact that she'd been pulled into a project to outfit our Rocky's with composite armor to make them more resistant to the creatures wildly acidic blood. She’s the foremost expert when it comes to the Xeno’s acidic blood.

The message sits in the send queue. Weird, I check the logs. Subspace link offline? Yet another weird thing. Janice and Marco are already jacked back in, I follow suit.

What a rainy nasty planet. The storm we'd seen from orbit had spun off a series of smaller storms and we are enjoying the benefits of one of them. Wind lashes our SLEDs. We tumble through the various bands looking for anything alive. Around us the ground is glowing with lichen mats, the puddles teem with microbial life.

"Weird wildlife" Marco said into the channel to no one in particular.

"I don't understand how there were xeno’s. There's supposed to be no large life forms on this planet." replies Janice. It's true. This was something that had bothered us and had become hotly debated while our robots traversed the planet.

"What was encased on the walls then?" I ask. To that question, there's silence. We turn our attention back to the planet.

The landscape is windswept and desolate. The vista is beautiful in a primordial way. I can see how eventually with decades of terra-forming, it will eventually be nice place to visit, maybe even live. Get some very hardy GMO grasses going, calm down the atmosphere. Carefully introduce lifeforms and build an ecology. I let the sensor data wash over me as I muse about this possible future. This place could be a paradise one day, but that was far, far in the future. It’s Marco who sees it first.

"What the fuck is that?" he asks.

I snap out of my daydream about possible futures. Marco's Rocky springs from the SLED and lands agile like a cat on the muddy ground.

"Is that a pig?" wonders Janice.

Alice answers into the chat, "Based on image analysis, yes."

The three Rocky's scan around the pig’s corpse. It's chest blown open in classic Xenomorph form.

"It's not decayed much if not at all." I notice.

"CIC, you seeing this shit?" I say into the command channel.

I heard commander Robinson's exhale.

"We see it. This might change the number of possible hostiles," he replies.

In our private channel Marco mutters, "Ya think!" Climbing back aboard, we trundle on, however now all three of us fully extend our sensor bulbs despite it increasing our profile to the buffeting wind. Without prompting Marco launches an additional drone to provide a larger overview around us, yet again showing initiative and prudent paranoia.

Chapter 5.

"What an ugly hole in the ground." laughs Marco.

Both Janice and I acknowledge it in the channel, it was. Three meters high and seven meters wide, it descends down at a steep angle.

"Permission to launch a drone into Hadley's asshole?" asks Marco.

We both snicker, I hear someone on the command channel snicker as well.

"Permission granted. Let's get idea what might be down there," I state.

Answering the open question Janice pipes up, "Shit loads of xenos, who knows what else. I'm still boggling about that skinny pale one."

"We came to get intel, launch the drone." I order.

You have give the to Xenos credit, they're at least consistent. Their architecture, if you could call it that, is very bio mechanical. Down the center of the ceiling is a long spinal protrusion, ribs a meter deep extend off this spine down the walls to the floor. Weird spiny crenelations protrude from the walls all over the place. Deep alcoves and blind corners fill this cave. The entrance descends fifty meters and then opens into a low cavern, the air is so humid and hot that the down wash from the drone is easily visible. Tunnels go off in eight different directions.

"I bet it stinks," Marco says.

“Can it. I'm liking this less and less,” I say, “Pick a tunnel.”

Marco flies the drone down the third tunnel. Seventy five meters and another twenty meters deeper into the tunnel system we found our first breeding room.

"Oh shit," is all Marco says.

"Oh god," Janice whispers. Humans, or what was left of them, are pinned to walls. Some dead, some alive their abdomens swollen.

“How?” whispered Janice.

"Free Booters," Marco says flatly into the channel.

Wayland could try to kill it whenever it came out on the nets, but the knowledge was out there. You can't build five building size atmo processors, modular buildings, train and recruit families and launch them without people talking. The people who got left behind tell stories of a paradise, of clean land and water, blue skies. People want off the increasingly crowded, polluted Earth. There are stories

of groups going off and landing on charted planets without a charter and claiming them, I'd never seen proof, until now.

"Pull the drone out, pick another tunnel." I say flatly.

"We're just going to leave them?" snarls Janice. I feel her disgust.

I don't like it either. "I promise we'll make sure they don't suffer," I say into the channel.

The next tunnel we find another birthing chamber, but here we find pigs encased instead. It makes sense. Pigs, humans, dogs, livestock, the Xenos didn't really give a shit. The fourth chamber is weirder though. Pig pens. Dozens of them. Sows squeal at the drone. The sows had been glued down by the alien resin. Something that looked like an adapted facehugger grips each sows face. Only it’s desperate eyes are visible. I can feel both Marco's and Janice's disgust through the neural link.

"They're breeding fucking pigs?" someone says into the various additional channels that had linked into the common channel.

"They're stupid animals, how could they be breeding pigs?" some unnamed marine asks in the channel.

I let out a breath. "Easy. They’re not stupid, they've been watching us," I say. At this, all the channels go quiet.

"We can't just leave those people," says Janice.

She is right. Marco has been busy going down additional tunnels. In the sixth tunnel we found something weird, a pulsing mass from ceiling to floor, with the weird pale Xenos crawling all over it.

"What the fuck is that?!?" Marco says into the channel.

"Permission to engage?" asks Janice. "Permission granted," I say. Janice unlimbers her rocky and prepares to step off the transport sled, but the aerial drone has done it's work.

“Stay on the SLED,” I say in our personal comm channel.

Finally the doorman has noticed someone knocking around in the lobby and raised the alarm. The response is staggering. Dozens of xenos spill out of tunnels letting out ethereal screams.

Marco's drone gets knocked out of the air, swatted effectively by a long Xeno hand. They seem pretty good at it actually. This was going to get out of hand quick.

"Destroy the entrance!" I order.

Over the Ops comm channel I heard orders being issued for evac.

I load and fire a trio of forty millimeter grenades at the roof of the tunnel. Large divots are knocked from roof but it holds. Janice's rocky rips into the roof with grenades and gun fire.

"Damn, that's tough shit!" I growl.

More grenades rain into Hadley's asshole. Finally the roof gives out and bows more than collapses, the entrance now resembles a pinched tube, with two small exits. Xenos squirm out only to be cut down by a fusillade of gunfire. The pile of shattered Xeno's grow.

"Prepare for dust off in thirty seconds," a voice from the CIC comes through the command channel. The SLEDs extend up hard points. The pair of carry alls latch on, lifting away our SLEDs. Marco launch's a parting trio of grenades into the left opening of the collapsed tunnel. The shock wave blows Xeno guts and body parts out the other side.

"Eat shit motherfuckers!" laughed Marco.

In the channel we heard a hardy "Yeah!"

"Standby for shock wave" the same person from the CIC calls out. We watch the feeds as a shock wave emanates out from the site.

I ping Janice on the private channel. "I promised they wouldn't suffer."

The DeBe launches another rail gun round into the site. Another shock wave ripples out. Accessing the optics on the DeBe, a large depression has formed in that spot. We've pulverized the whole site from orbit. The carry-all can only carry our sleds a couple kilometers before it indicates it needs to set us down. We watch as the carry-alls fly off to return to orbit to refuel. Around us lightning arcs across the sky. Free Booters. Coming to this forsaken place? It boggles my mind.

Chapter 6.

The briefing room is crowded. Any pretense about sitting or desks has faded away. The marines nod at us and let us move to the front. Apparently we'd shown some metal down there. Commander Robinson is standing at the wall screen.

"As it stands now, we have an unknown number of civvies on the planet to account for."

A marine speaks up, "Sir, they don't have a charter, we're not obligated."

The commander shakes his head.

"Obligated no, but our mission is to secure this planet. We've got evidence of Xeno activity and of them doing weird shit down there. Teams one and two splatted no less than sixty of the damn things and bagged a live one."

A tech walks to the front of the room. "Knowing we have Free Booters on the planet, we've changed the parameters of our surface scans looking for anomalies."

The screen changes to a view of the southern hemisphere.

"In this case, ground penetrating radar seems to be unable to penetrate this small area. The map zooms in and an area of irregular triangles highlighted.

"Stealth mats?" I ask out loud.

"We think so. The computer had to wash the image a bunch of times. They did a really good job breaking up regular shapes. We only found it because we had to change the computers filters."

"Any chance you nerds could find more of those nests?" asked a Marine.

"Yes in fact." with that the screen changes to show dozens and dozens of similar openings on the surface. The screen is a mix of Thermography and synthetic ground penetrating radar. Each nest shows the classic eight legged tunnel system.

"Face huggers?" one of the marines asks.

The thermals indeed made it look like a face hugger.

The tech speaks up, "Sir, that puts an entrance within five clicks of Team three."

"Have they been made aware?" asked the commander.

"Yes. They've deployed sentries, they've contained the specimen and will be blasting off within the hour." replies the tech. *Contained the specimen*. That sounded like they were going to be bringing the damn thing on board.

"Permission to speak freely?" I asked.

"Granted." replies the commander, though I did see him roll his eyes.

I take a deep breath, "We've just witnessed that the Xenos' are smarter than we thought. We should abandon our assumptions about them. Fine, you want to dissect that one, I'm more than willing to task my rocky to a science tech, on the surface, but not onboard."

Other marines nod their heads in agreement.

The commander nods his head, "Once again your concerns have been noted."

To this he points at me, "Cyber teams one and two are to be on standby prep until further notice, dismissed."

While I knew this was somewhat of a punishment for speaking up, I was glad we were going to be just chilling in the pit ready to drop in a moments notice. Our cradles are also far better and accessing and consuming the petabytes of data that are flowing through the systems. Team two had been as lucky as we had been. Their processing station was also filled with xenos, including the small pale ones. The glue had been ineffective at stopping regular xenos and it had turned into a turkey shoot. Roxie's rocky had been damaged beyond repair or retrieval. Roxie and Ruvi were in the prep area working on her backup rocky. Janice and Marco were looking at the drone footage. I peek in and they are looking at the footage of the weird column. I checked the message queue, still pending.

"Alice, what's the current state of our subspace transmitters?"

"All Cyber command subspace transmitters are online." it replies. Alice is fire walled into our systems. It doesn't know much more than we do. Edgar is the AI that runs the ship. Unlike Alice, it generally lacks personality. More of a glorified central operator, all the ships data flows through it. I connect to Edgar.

Query: Status of subspace transmission link with Earth?

Result: Link currently offline due to hardware malfunction.

Query: Estimate of time to repair?

Result: Unknown hardware fault, time to repair unknown.

So we're cut off from Earth.

Query: Current mission parameters?

Result:

1. Assess habitability of LV426.

2. Capture and analyze any lifeforms found.
3. Eliminate any hostile lifeforms.

I knew better than to assume there were just three mission parameters. This was a military AI and therefore very cagey. It was telling me the mission parameters I was authorized to see.

Query: How much food are we currently carrying?
Result: Based on current crew size, 645 days of regular rations.

We have literally tons of food on board. They expect us to possibly be out here for a long time.

Query: What is our current compliment of scientists on board?
Result: 14 scientific specialists are on board.
Query: How many are currently out of hyper sleep?
Result: 14.

Okay, so we have nearly as many scientists as we have soldiers. As a Cybertech, I was trained on a number of systems, including the maintenance of subspace radios. I decided to take a different tact.

Query: Nature of the hardware malfunction of subspace radio?
Result: Communications module is unable to create subspace tunnel.
Query: Do I have clearance to inspect the hardware?

I knew based on the pause I knew someone in the CIC was likely having a "WTF?" moment as the ships AI asked them if some cyber tech could go fishing around in the comms space. At this my ear buzzes.

"Cybertech first class Hurgs. Why is Edgar asking me if it's okay for you to go poking around in the comms room?" comes a voice I don’t recognize over the comm link.

"Sir, I'm a qualified subspace tech, I noticed our link to Earth is offline." I reply.

"We've got people working on it, if we need help, we'll let you know. Request denied," the voice replies and disconnects. “I'm really making friends on this cruise,” I laugh to myself.

Alarms go off pit.

"Team 1 deploy in 30 seconds. Bio Science teams is in trouble."

Chapter 7.

Once we are out of the blinding plasma of the atmosphere we turn on the external optical sensors. It is a proper shit show. The Cheyenne drop ship is covered in xenos. I check the drop pods trajectory, and adjust it to get us closer to the ship and put it into a steep ballistic dive. I can see gun fire rippling out from the drop ship. Of the five sentries deployed, only two remain. Alice brings up the ammo counters, they were ripping through ammo and will be out in moments.

Wham, the retros fire, at least three Xenos are boiled alive, good. The petals drop from the drop pod and they’re on us from all directions. The chin mounted gun fires near its cyclic rate. The driving rain helps to cool the barrel, but only slightly. We've landed in a triangular formation front of and aft of each wing of the drop ship creating 120 degree overlapping fields of fire.

Marco sweeps the Xenos off the drop ship, it's engines cycling up.

"Dust off in ten seconds, thanks for backing us up!" The pilots voice comes through the comms. As the ship rockets upward, a howl goes through the Xenos.

"Freaky shit," is all Marco gets out. We hold out for another ten minutes until our ammo runs out. backed against each other, molecular sharp cutting blades extended, we slash outwards catching a Xeno here and there, but they stay out of reach. They've seen us before and now know we were a dangerous foe. At last they all rushed us. The last images before the feed cuts out is of the my heavy cutting arms snipping through the head of a Xeno as it's claws dug into the sensor dome. At least I know I've killed that asshole. We knew dropping like this was a suicide mission. This is why we were in mechs anyway. Climbing out of the pit I see Marco and Janice ejecting from their pods.

"That was a shit pile." I laugh.

"We accomplished the mission at least." replies Janice.

"Yeah, we helped them bring a fucking Xeno aboard, honestly, I'd have been okay with that one failing," replies Marco.

I don’t disagree with him on that score. I check in with command. They lost three of the eight techs they'd sent down. I could only hope they'd been killed. There are fates worse than death on this forsaken rock. I task Alice with looking through the footage. Only two of the three techs are accounted for. I report my findings and make sure the team knows as well. Janice blows out a long breath, shakes her head and walks out of the pit.

Chapter 8.

The next two weeks are stark and grinding. Now that the observation techs know what to look for, we focus on nests near strategic assets. The first couple dozen we explore, we find the same horrors. Pigs and humans used as breeding stock. More of the weird pale Xenos. More of those weird columns. Occasionally a queen, who to humans would have been a real foe is merely an slightly harder Xeno to kill. Eventually we gave up even exploring any nests that didn't look interesting and hit them from orbit with rail gun rounds.

The observation techs look harder at the data and discover two weird nests. Their thermal signature is different than the others. Warmer and larger than the other nests. Word gets out that maybe we've finally found a couple live Free Booter settlements. The bored and by now cranky marines are mustered to land. This was what they'd been waiting for! They were going to save the civvies! Since finding these underground settlements all manner of comm attempts had been made. Short band, wide band, laser wide and tight beam, all to no avail.

We drop on the two nests, expecting the usual "smash and stomp" as we had taken to calling them. These nests are different. Instead breeding chambers, we find several "Bunk houses." Caverns filled with elaborate biomechanical cubbies, each with a Xeno each nestled into it's own little weird biomechanical cubby fast alseep. Our presence in the nest causes them to wake from whatever shared dream they're having and rush us. We'd become efficient in our dispatchment of the Xeno drones. Automatically the targeting software puts a round right above the top lip. One shot, one kill.

Janice finds the first weird thing. Exploring deeper, she find a a heavily reinforced blast door in the back wall of the farthest chamber of the nest. Team two reports a similar thing. Optics are above both doors, our sensors show them active. Joining her it's clear this door was made to stop xeno's.
"Someone is watching us, that's for sure." says Marco.
Alice speaks up in the channel. "I'm detecting a low power analog radio signal."
"Pipe it in," I reply.
"Whoever or whatever you are, you are trespassing. Return to your ship, do not return," a stern voice says into the channel.
I open an analog audio channel on the same frequency. "This is Roger Hurgs of the Colonial Marines Cyber corps attempting to make contact with the free booters on planet LV426."

"Cyber corps? We take offense to the term free booters. Nothing is free on this planet. We are settlers, fair and square." Here I am forty light years from Earth and I'm dealing with a pedant.
I take a different tact. "My Apologies, settler. Might hostile wildlife in these parts. We're concerned for your safety."

"We are safe and sound. Leave Acheron and return to your ship and leave this system." the voice says.

Cagey and to the point. I have to admire the type of people who were capable of battling the xenos and building themselves a fortress. It is at this point another wave of Xenos attack in force. Dozens of xenos come streaming into the chamber. We cut them down until our ammo runs low, finishing the last of them with molyblades. At this point we are knee deep in Xenos. The occasional head hissing and snapping at our robotic ankles. Even with the resistant ceramic plates, all of our machines began complaining. We retreat from this weird hive and park our units on the sleds and let the rain wash the xeno juices off our rocky's.

I jack out to find commander Robinson standing in the pit with him one of the technicians from the science part of the ship.

"This shit just keeps getting worse," he starts. This was just the way the conversations went with him. I took a deep breath. No hello's, no formalities, just right into it.

"The techs have been examining that weird pale Xeno Janice bagged. It's been altered," he continues.

"Altered?" Janice asks as she has now jacked out as well.

At this, the tech perks up.

"Yeah. It has all the hallmarks of being tinkered with by humans," he replies.

Now I am interested. "In what ways?" I ask.

"That we're still trying to figure out. Definitely smarter, not nearly as strong." the tech replies.

"Smarter? I hope we can keep it contained," I note. I knew I was poking a sore spot and Robinson frowns at me for it.

I nod towards our ready room. "I need coffee."

All the time jacked in had turned my on again off again headache into a grinding companion. We sat around our break table. I explain the weird hive and the re-enforced door and the voice.
The tech pulls out a tablet and tabs through a few screens.

"Somethings been bothering the geo guys since we got here. The planet is far more along than they expected, but they couldn't figure out the source." He connected his tablet to our wall screen and shows the projected graph of where the terra-forming should be. The graph lines are at least twenty percent better than that.

“Intel said the first atmo plant blowing up accounts for some of it,” I reply.

"Yeah, the heating, but not the gases. Nitrogen, oxygen and a bunch of other gases are much higher.” he replies.

"Any chance you guys are collecting data on gas plums?" I ask.

The tech tinkers with the pad.

“Can you overlay that with the nest locations?" I ask. Janice and Marco get up and walk over to the wall screen as the two maps line up.

"Holy fuck." Marco says. Commander Robinson gets up and looks at the screen.

"So the Xeno's have gotten into the terra-forming business?" he quips.

Janice snapped her fingers, "Those weird columns we keep finding. They've got to their version of atmospheric processors."

“We just found someone living in a hive right beside xeno’s.” I note.

This brings up so many questions. The xeno’s are perfectly happy with the planet the way it was. I had more questions to ask. I jack in and wade down back into the tunnel. I open up the analog comm channel and just ask the question,

"You modified the Xenos and got them processing the atmosphere?"

A moment goes by. "Yes, we modified them. Consider it an in-situ use of resources. Fully sanctioned by Wayland I might add. Hence why we aren't free booters, we've got a charter, albeit a classified one.”

This explained some things and posed more questions.

"Check with your higher ups, the project is known as X1243." he replies.

This tidbit of knowledge is good to know.

"We'd appreciate if you'd stop rail gunning the installations and let the controllers rebuild and create additional nests." the voice says.

"I'm not in command, but now that we have a fuller understanding of the situation, I can talk to those in command." I reply.

"Good luck with that," the voice laughs over the comms.

"I never asked who I was speaking with," I ask.

"No you didn't and I won't be saying my name on this open line in any case," the voice replies.

"Well, you'd best clear out. I've sent a message to the controller Xenos to clean up this mess."

"How do you communicate with them?" I ask.

But at that, I’m asking it to dead air. The last question left unanswered. I leave the tunnel and return to the sled.

"Heads up, there's a contingent of xenos and what are now known as controller xenos converging on this location." I say into the command channel.

"Acknowledged. We listened in, carry-all incoming." comes the reply.

Over the horizon I saw two odd things. A mass of xenos and above them the carry all. A spindly contraption designed by Wayland to be compact and simple. A pod, a couple thrusters, nothing more. The sled extends it's carry lugs and the carry all latches on and carries me way from the aliens. A half dozen of the controller Xenos look up as their simpler cousins streamed into the tunnel. I'm not going to say I saw intelligence, but for a moment I swear I saw the classic head shake of disgust

Chapter 9.

"!External Ejection Triggered!" pops up and fades as I found myself nose to nose with commander Robinson in my cradle.

"We have a serious fucking problem now," his conversation starting in the usual manner.

"How so?" I ask.

Hands on hips, "EDGAR heard that transmission and it's triggered some type of fail safe. We're locked out of all the major systems," he growls.

I thank my lucky stars our systems were fire walled off from the rest of the ship.

"Alice, are you still online?" I ask tentatively.

"Affirmative. However, I have lost access to all ship systems," the AI replies.

"I take it you haven't heard of Project X1243?" I ask Robinson.

"I have, but it was thought a failure," he replies.

Janice, Roxie and Ruvi pop their heads up for their corner of the pit.

"Sir, now might be time to put our cards on the table," I point out.

He climbs out of the pit and pours himself a cup of coffee and sits down with a huff and waves us all over.

"Everybody raise your right hands and solely swear that the information you're about to told is to be kept strictly confidential. You will take this information to your graves. Speaking of it to anybody outside of this room will hasten your path to said graves."

In unison we all said, "We solely swear."

"Sit down," he says, and we do.

"It's not widely know, but we've found the damn Xenos on lots of planets. Our grasp of bioengineering is good enough to know they were engineered by some other species. Used as a type of forward force to prep a planet. On many planets we've found eggs, just sitting there waiting dormant, on other planets entire civilizations destroyed, only swarms of xenos left," he starts.

We all take this in. We'd all been exposed to the "Brighter futures! Become a settler today!" propaganda. Colonizing the stars kept looking grimmer by the second.

He continues, "Wayland Yutani bio-engineers started tinkering with the xeno's. The XNA that the Xenos possess is remarkably malleable. Various research teams came up with proposals to harness

this malleability. We figured if we can't out right destroy them, we'd co-op them. Once such project was X1243. The idea was to turn the Xenos into a controllable labor force. Given wide latitude, the usual ethical standards were applied."

This brings a snicker from everybody. Wayland is well known to place the success of a project over the lives of people, especially low level specialists.

"It would appear this project has had some limited success," he finishes.

"I wonder what Edgar's orders were?" asks Roxie.

Robinson rugs his chin, "That I know. Upon entering orbit, it was to try to make contact with the scientists involved with the project. However, at last check they weren't even listening on subspace. Our take from that was when they made planet fall they'd been swarmed and destroyed."

I thought about the three simpler orders that Edgar had shown me. I wondered what the "simple" orders the commander had been shown and what the fuller set of orders actually were. This is the dangers of a cagey military AIs that had their agendas set by who knows who and given authority to accomplish those agendas. Robinson goes to the door but the access light stays red. He waved his hand a couple more times growing more frustrated. Finally he turns to us.

"Can somebody run a bypass on this god damn door so I can get back to the CIC?" he stammers.

Marco steps up and puts the back of his hand against the door.

"Sir, I believe opening this door would be a bad idea," he replies.

"Why do you think that?" the commander asks.

"Sir, the door is ice cold. I believe this habitat spar has been vented," he replies.

It makes sense from a tactical point of view. The last thing as a tactically minded computer you need is humans running around mucking with stuff.

"Marco, isolate the door controls," I reply.

He nods, opens the panel next to the door and starts tinkering.

"Alice, what data are you currently receiving from the DeBe?" I ask.

"Only data from automated systems," Alice replies.

The DeBe, despite it's impressive bulk is just a series of stacked modules connected to four redundant load bearing spars that run the length of the ship with an engine module at the back end. Two

kilometers long with hard points every fifty meters to attach modules. Modules can be isolated, disconnected or jettisoned. Most modules contain some level of internal redundancy.

"Alice, are any of our external sensors effected?" I asked.

"No. All sensors and comms systems in and on our module are operational." The AI replies.

“Alice, are still getting consumables?” I ask.

“Yes. I’m reading nominal voltages on all power busses. Valves to water and oxygen are still open.”

Edgar has us on basic rations.

“Alice, what is the state of this modules consumables?” I ask.

“We are a full capacity.” the AI replies.

“Keep it that way and don’t allow any outflow.” I reply back.

“Parameters reset,” the AI replies.

At this the commander nods.

"Alice, using our sensors, can you assess the state of the ship?" I ask. A couple moments pass as Alice processes the data.

"At present, as viewable from our position on the DeBraso, the ship is configured as designated in the initial manifest." My fears was that Edgar had dumped the modules overboard, I'm glad that it hadn't.

"What do you think your marines are up to?" asks Ruvi.

"Regaining access to the ship I would imagine," replies the commander.

Like our module, the Marine Combat Modules MCM's are very robust ships in their own right, They can be detach and be left in orbit if needed. I envision them donning vac suits and using the airlocks to escape their module.

"Sir, do they know where your current location is?" I ask.

"Likely no. They'll head for the CIC first." he replies.

Alice interjects, "I haven't picked up any transmissions on tactical channels." At this the commander nods, "I doubt you would. They're following SOP. I suspect when the doors slammed shut they assumed Edgar went bug nuts and they're talking on a tether or tight beam."

Jeremy adds to the conversation. He was the only member of our team who'd started as a traditional marine and moved over to the Cyber team.

"It's only been twenty minutes. I figure a couple minutes for them to figure what's going on, five to don vac suits, five to get to the edge of their module, the modules are in the same spare segment port and starboard side and there are five hundred meters of storage between us and the air locks. I can shuffle pretty good with mag boots, they're probably better, I figure they'll be by our airlock in another fifteen or so minutes."

The commander nods along to this, "Probably fifteen or less. These guys just got done doing zero-g drills the other day."

Jeremy nods back. "I'll grab a light and head to the airlock and keep an eye out." At this he trots off at double speed.

The commander snickers, "Real shame he decided to become a geek." To this the team all look at each other and then back at the commander, it was clear he'd hit a nerve and he realizes it. To this he blows his cheeks out in his classic fashion, "He was a good marine, it just seemed an odd choice."

Ruvi cleared his throat, "Sir, he is a marine, as are we." To this the commander nods.

"I appreciate the training and hard work you people put in, it's just outside of our standards." he replies. I could see this entire conversation going off the rails.

"I definitely think this conversation is important, but right now let's focus on the problems at hand," I note.

Robinson could see I’m saving his bacon a bit and picks up on the theme.

"What are your current capabilities?" he asks.

We detail our current load out and equipment on the ground as well as options for deploying our additional rockies ship side.

As we discuss our current capabilities, Jeremy comes jogging into the room with six marines in tow, helmets under arms.

"Sir, I found these guys on our doorstep," replies Jeremy.

The commander turns to the marines. "Status report."

The lead marine starts in, "Both habitable spars are vented to space. Three guys are MIA, presumed lost. The CIC was also vented, you were assumed lost with the other people in the CIC. Glad to see you're alive. Both marine combat modules are intact. We've disabled the door controls to Edgar won't try to vent us."

"Status of the other MCM module?" the commander asks.

"Locked down as well. We knocked on the door and they knocked back. Our first priority was the CIC until we saw Jeremy flashing out SOS with a light at us. Another weird thing you should know, one of the modules as extended large diamond shaped antennae. We didn't get near them. None of us knew what they were for."

More secret squirrel bullshit was what it sounded like to me.

"Roxie, please investigate those antennas," I say.

She nods and heads towards the pit.

“Alice, please put Roxie's feeds up on the main wall.”

"Roger that," replies Alice. I smile as the Marines look around momentarily before realizing that our modules has it's own AI. In short order we got a view of Roxie crabbing her rocky across the surface of the ship. Sure enough from one of the modules long spindly antenna had extended out several hundred meters.

"Alice, please identify those," I ask aloud.

"Unknown, does not fit any known antenna configuration in my data banks," replies the AI.

Janice speaks up at this, "More project X1243 stuff I'd bet."

I turn to Robinson who shrugs. “That module was installed by Wayland. I was told it was a new a deep space antenna.”

“I don’t see any external access ports on the module,” Roxie notes.

I agreed on this part, there were more moving parts to this and I've now found myself with five cyber jockies, a handful of marines, a commanding officer and a bio nerd.

The commander speaks up at this point to the marines.

"Establish contact with the other MCM. Use tethers, who knows what those those antenna can pick up. See if you can get to the CIC and reestablish control of this ship." At that Jeremy hustles them back to the airlock.

Reestablish control of the ship means crippling Edgar.

"Sir, was the subspace radio to earth ever brought back online?" I ask.

Pulling a small data card from his module he lets out a laugh, "I doubt without this, much got fixed."

He's holding a Positively Intertwined Confined Particle. There's a couple different acronyms for them. In subspace school we called them a PICL. Everybody here just calls them PIPs. I'm sure there's some other backronyms for it as well but it was why the deep space radio wasn't working.

"I pulled it when we came out of FTL transit," he answers the next question I was about to ask.

"Why?" I ask.

"Do you like having every one of your orders countermanded, debated, looked over, argued over from a forty seven light years away?" he asks.

I could see his frustration, but I also knew this was an excuse.

Janice speaks up, "Fine, we put that in one of our subspace radios and call home."

I shake my head, "It doesn't work that way. It comes down to how many hawkings you can generate to create the tunnel. Our modules systems barely create a hundredth of a hawking, the DeBe's deep space transmitter generates a field in the hundreds."

Jeremy speaks up, "Okay then, we put on vac suits and go install it." To this I laugh.

"Ironically if we tell Edgar we have this, he'll probably let us install it," I reply.

The commander then scoffs, "He'd probably then lock the doors in the engine section and cook us."

I couldn't disagree with that logic. To accent his point, the the alarms start sounding.

Chapter 10.

Klaxons echo through the module, every light changes to bright red and pulses.

Alice goes to full volume on all channels, "General breach alarm detected in science module!"

Janice throws her hands up, "How am I not surprised!"

"Alice, kill the alarm!" I snap. Immediately the alarms cut out.

"Stow it." I say to Janice.

"Roxie, can you see anything outside?" I ask.

"Yes. The marines went to the CIC module but were unable to open the door. They just returned to the port side MCM. Sir, the starboard MCM just fired it’s explosive bolts, detached and is tumbling."

"Alice, any danger to us?" I ask.

"No. Based on current trajectory, the module will enter the atmosphere in approximately two hours, eight minutes." The AI replies.

"Alice, any more alerts?" I ask. Alice pipes back in,

"No. Just the repeating breach alarm."

"Alice, Any idea what tripped it?" I ask.

"Unknown. Unable to access ship net." replies Alice.

"Roxie can you see any of the air locks?" I ask.

"Sir, the tumble is slow, on next rotation I will see if the airlocks are intact." she replies.

"That doesn't look like a very controlled detach." I point out.

"No. They would have only done that as a last resort. They’ve got plenty of firepower and training to deal with a xeno." replies the commander.

"Sir, I've got a visual on airlock number one." Roxie calls out.

On the screen we could see the airlock and what clearly is blood splattered on the inside.

"They ditched to isolate the Xeno." Jeremy says. Robinson nods in agreement.

At this the tech speaks up, "That doesn't account for the other Xeno material."

We stop and looked at the tech. He turns and looks at the commander who nods.

"After you cleared out the processing plant, we sent in atmo technicians to bring it back into full operation. During the clean up they found several intact eggs. We encased them and they were brought onboard with the Xeno."

Marco lets out a slow and exaggerated "Ffuucckk."

I don't disagree with that sentiment. "How many is several?" I ask.

"Four." the tech replies.

"Hopefully encased in something stronger that first container," Marco quips.

"Yes. A resin embedded with micro particles of a strong base capable of neutralizing the Xenos acid." the tech replies. I could see the team mulling this over.

"This material was tested?" asks Marco.

The tech shrugs, "I was told it would hold them."

"We need to get into that module and assess the situation," I order.

Robinson could see that I am starting to take charge and wants to make sure he was still the top dog. Nodding along, "This module is your show, I'm going to get over into the other MCM and see what I can do from there. Use your rockies to investigate that science module and relay the information to our MCM via the tether."

"What about the other MCM?" asks Janice.

"It's got power, while the tumble is uncontrolled once atmospheric drag starts, automatic systems will engage, it'll land of it's own accord. I need to worry about the here and now. Figure out what's going on in that science module," the commander barks.

Roxie speaks up, "Sir, I'm proceeding to the science module and breech if needed?"

I look at the commander, he nods. "Permission granted." I say. Despite the commanders talk of heading over to the other MCM, he sits down and watches Roxie's feed. In that moment I think he realizes likely the safest spot to be is here. Crawling on the nadir side of the ship, she makes her way to the science modules external hard point and airlock. Extending her smaller dexterous hands she manipulates the controls, when that fails, she overrides the controls and enters the airlock closing the external door behind her. Carefully she opens the inner door, to cavernous darkness. Immediately shifting to infrared, she launches a drone. The science module is a mess. Drawers ripped open, lab equipment strewn across counters and floor. It looks like it had been an ugly fight. The tech who I now knew as Eric quietly says, "The eggs are stored in the room to your right."

Roxie extends one of her large manipulator arms and opens the door a crack to allow the drone in. The drone does a juke and slips through the crack. Against the far wall four isolation chambers are lit by a blue lights. The four containers are smashed, the eggs open, their petal peeled back, their horrifying contents missing.

"You getting this?" asked Roxie.

"Five by five." I reply letting out a breath.

"So much for your fucking wonder material," huffs Marco.

Roxie opens the door and the drone flies out, laser and doppler mapping as it goes. Roxie moves her rocky deeper into the science module.

"How many people were in this module?" she asks.

"Nine," I reply. Across the hall the holding cell is open, the pale Xeno missing.

"No signs it forced its way out." Roxie notes.

Alice speaks up, "MCM 2 has reoriented and is firing retro rockets for re-entry. I've plotted its approximate landing site."

"Let us known when it's landed." I reply.

Deeper into the science module, the Xeno had converted a meeting room into a hatchery. Four people are cocooned against the wall. All dead, their chests burst open. Seeing this Eric let out a moan, "No." and begins to weep. The floor is littered with the remains of the other five scientists. The recognition software automatically counting bodies but unable to easily identify them. They'd been consumed.

Roxie let out a sigh, "All accounted for."

Ruvi speaks up, "Where are the Xenos then?" he asks quietly.

It is a question we are all wondering.

Chapter 11.

Immediately Robinson gets on the tether to the MCM,

"Be advised there are possibly up to five Xenos onboard. One pale and likely four standard xenos." A voice I know well, Wikowsky comes back.

"Roger that, motion trackers are deployed. We sent a fire team down the main spar half an hour ago to attempt to access the CIC and disconnect Edgar. So far, no word."

My only experience with somewhat sentient AI's was Alice. The fact that a four man fire team had been gone for half an hour and they weren't sending people out to look for them made think it wasn't going too well. Edgar had already depressurized the ship and apparently killed the crew in the CIC, I wondered idly what Alice might do if the mission parameters were more important than our lives.

Roxie speaks up, "I've got something."

We turned our attention back to the feed. Roxie's rocky is holding a bulkhead hatch with long tear marks in it.

"Looks like they decided to get into the utility spars." Janice notes.

These damn things are clever, I'd give them that. The utility spars run the length of the ship. Tubes of durasteel, full of hand holds, cables and pipes, not created for a human to stroll down but for Xenos who have a weird fetish about climbing around in tight spaces, it's perfect. Immediately my mind begins to work and worry about the ingress points to this module. I speak up, "Roxie, see if you can get to the habitat spar and aid the other marines."

"Roger that. I'll keep you posted." comes a reply.

Immediately I start taking stock of what I have for hardware I can bring to bare. I have three rockies on the ground, one in the science lab and two more currently in the maintenance bay as well as two more as assembled spares and enough parts to probably get a half dozen more up and running.

I look at Ruvi, "Jack in and get your rocky positioned in front of the panel to the utility access."

I don't even get a "yes sir" before Ruvi takes off for the pit to jack in. I can see the look on the commanders face, he'd have chewed someone out for such a lack of protocol. My module, my rules. The problem I have now is a lack access to the cameras in the habitable spars. I know they were depressurized but I didn't know what was going on. Alice breaks this train of thought.

"Sir, there's a radio call coming in on the surface directed to you."

"From who?" I asked.

"Origin unknown, triangulated to a surface transmitter six hundred and fifty meters from rocky one, the message is repeating." Alice replies.

"Play it" I say. Immediately the room is filled with the voice I'd spoken to earlier.

"This message is for Hurgs. Please contact us on this frequency, immediately, we need help!”

Alice then says, "The message just repeats."

"Alice, what is the current location of our rockies in relation to the cave we were in earlier?" I ask.

"Approximately six hundred and fifty meters." Alice replies.

I'd been ejected as the carry all had lifted off, I didn't actually know where my rocky was. I drop into my cradle and initiate a fast jack as it's called. I find myself on the sled on a low plateau, the storm in the north seems even angrier than the last time I'd jacked in. Because of the fast jack, not everything is fully synced up yet. Details are still filling in. Waves of rain lash across the sensor bulb. Ironically this rocky literally has everything, but lacks wipers, blowers or sonics to keep the rain off. I bring the radio online and boost its power to the max. I also configure the channels so that my audio will bounce into the meeting room.

"This is Hurgs responding." I watch as a timer ticks. Thirty seconds elapse.

"I repeat this is PFC cyber specialist Hurgs." Then I hear it, a faint crackle, then the power boosts up.

"Hurgs, we hear you. What have you guys done? The workers have gone crazy!" the voice says faintly.

"Sir, please explain." I say.

"After our last message, I called the controllers to clean up the the mess you made with your robots. Things went normally, then suddenly the controllers stopped responding to our commands. Workers attempted to breach our compounds. We've stayed secure but we've lost contact with the beta site and the main habitat site."

In my ear I hear Janice on a side channel, "I don't think any of this is a coincidence." I agree. The mentioning of project X1243, the sudden sprouting of the antenna, the weird behavior of Edgar, the workers as this guy was calling the xeno’s, the controllers, the opened confinement cell and the smashed eggs.

"Okay. I'm about a klick away from the entrance to your tunnel, do you need me to clean that tunnel out?" I ask.

"No currently there only a handful of xenos and a single controller. Once they were unable to breach our defenses they left." the voice replies.

"We found the location of the beta site, where is the location of your main habitat compound?" At this there is a pause, I'm sure there are others in the background likely not that excited to give away such a vital piece of intel. To me, this pause seems crazy. I open a side channel to the main room with the commander.

"Robinson, should I let him know about what's going on the DeBe?" I ask.

A pause at our end this time.

"No. We don't know these people or their capabilities. I have no reason to trust these people. This guy, who I should remind you hasn't told us his name, said a magic word that managed to fuck us up and get more than a couple marines killed." came the response.

I had to grudgingly agree with the commander. Shit truly had gone sideways once he said the project name. On the other hand it looked like his goose was getting cooked as well.

"Okay Hurgs, the main habitat is about 250km north of this current location at the base of a formation we call "Hadley's chin." Immediately Alice brings up a topo map and it was clear why they called it that. A prominence of rock, wide and square.

"I see it on the topo map. There's serious storm brewing though." I reply.

"Yes. The queens crown we call it. A product of the original detonation, the storm has been raging for a couple of decades, we're now in the season when it really ramps up. Between it and the Xeno's it's why we ended up under ground. Hurgs, you asked before, the names Zeigler." comes a reply.

"Glad to finally put a name to the voice, I'm going to investigate the beta site and we'll get people to the habitat." I say.

"Thanks. Keep me posted." he replies. At that the comm channel goes dead.

"Alice, please plot a course to the beta site, let me know when rocky one is five hundred meters out." I say.

"Roger that. Course plotted. ETA nineteen minutes. My mind registers that is a steady fifty six point eight kilometers an hour. Gotta love implants! I eject from the cradle, climb out of the pit and head back to the conference room.

"Zeigler, eh? Didn't expect to find that mother fucker on this rock." laughs the commander.

That's going to merit some explanation. I grabbed a cup of coffee, a snack packet and pain meds. Fast jacking is a sure fire way to end up in bed stunned if you do it too often. Already I could feel the tightness in my temples and I have a slight tremor in my left arm. The commander looks at my arm and then me.

I shrug, "Dangers of cybernetics." I laugh.

At that he pulls back his sleeve to show long scars, “Being a marine is dangerous.” he replies.

"So who is this Zeigler guy you seem so fond of?" I ask. To this, the commander just laughs.

"Oh Mike and I go way back, you could say we haven't seen eye to eye about the Xenomorphs since day one."

The prospect of story time brings people to the table. Seeing that he had an audience, the commander sits back and folds his hands across his broad chest and begins.

"Dr. Mike Ziegler is a brilliant scientist who falls into the category of men too consumed with the could, they never stop to ask if they should. To him, he sees the Xenomorph and their straightforward bio-engineering as an opportunity. He calls it a gift from the gods. He's convinced he can tame the damn things, use them as a labor force, communicate with them. I attended more than a half dozen proposals where he spoke of using what they'd learned to create a whole bestiary of creatures that can work in conditions we wouldn't even want to send robots. Based on what you've reported, it appears he's had some success, and based on his latest radio messages, as usual when dealing with the Xenomorph's, invariably these scientists bite off more than they can chew." at that he puts his hands on the table.

Turning to me, he says sternly, "This guy is a snake in the grass. Results driven to a level that would make a Wayland VP blush, he's shrewd and smart. To quote an old North American thing that they used to say before they'd arrest you, everything you say can and will be used against you. Think before you speak. Whatever his charter was with project X1243, the only info I had was that we were to make contact. The details were locked up until we made contact. I don't even know how many people are here or where was his charter. Hell, I didn't know he was here. To be fair my first inclination would have been to nuke the entire site from orbit on principle!"

I nod taking this in. "So this scientist is some kinda of megalomanic loon who will stop at nothing until he creates super Xenos?" I laugh.

Robinson just shakes his head, "You've already seen these commander Xeno's. He's already doing that, who knows what other horrors he's cooked up."

Janice who'd sat silent speaks up, "I'd like to know how he's communicating with them."

I just flatly respond, “The list of questions for this guy keeps growing.”

Alice breaks in, "MCM 2 has made landfall successfully."

On the screen the location is plotted. It put it nearly fifty klicks from the entry to the main habitat site.

Marco quips, "Geez, if anybody is still alive in that module, the last twenty minutes must have felt like a ride in an auto dryer."

"Any comms from the module?" I ask Alice.

"No. Emergency beacon only. However, the module may be transmitting on low power. I lack resources to evaluate that." comes the reply.

I turn to Jeremy. "Prep and drop a rocky on that module."

Jeremy replies with a crisp "Yes Sir." and makes haste to the pit. The commander nods approvingly.

"What's your plan?" asked the commander.

"That MCM is full of weapons and hopefully functional marines. Worse case we can hand out weapons to civvis, best case, we'll have functional marines and we'll hand out weapons to civvis." I laugh.

"I'm hearing a lot of hope in that plan." Robinson notes.

That is the truth. If dozens and dozens of Xenos decide to storm your position, short of a tactical nuke, your options run out quickly. But the MCM did have point defense weapons that could easily shred a Xeno. Hope is all I'm running on at this point. We watch the screen as Jeremy’s drop pod arcs towards the plotted position of the MCM.

"Sir, I've landed a fifty meters from the MCM. Landing struts deployed, it looks functional." Jeremy's voice comes over the comms.

"Any sign of marines?" asks Robinson.

"Negative." replies Jeremy. On the main screen Jeremy's rocky approaches the MCM. Wreathed in steam, audible pops and clicks as the module cools aided by the driving rain flashing to steam give

the module an ethereal look. Approaching the main airlock, it is apparent there had been a hell of a fight inside. Jeremy punches an override code into the airlock and both doors open.
Out of the airlock a lone xeno crawls out, it’s blood hissing in droplets, holding its guts. As he approaches, the drone launches itself feebly at the rocky. Bringing his heavy manipulators up, Jeremy slams the drone into the ground. He drags the dying Xeno a few yards from the module, gripping the Xeno in his pincers, he pins it to the ground and puts single ten mil AP round through its head, what little of it's green blood splashes the ground and sizzles. I had to give Jeremy credit for the brutal efficiency of it. We'd had two weeks of slogging through xenos. Dozens of times they'd leapt on the Rockies. While the commander and the tech had jumped, we hadn't. Just another horrifying day at the office.

Laughing he zooms into the shoulder of the drone, an ugly gash from below the neck to it’s stomach. “Classic marine disembowelment slash,” Jeremy notes.

"God Damn! That's the work of a vibrablade!" The commander grins slapping the table. His marines had put up a fight. Climbing into the MCM, it's a horror scene. Two dead marines lay on the module floor, one of them holding a shattered vibrablade. The other slashed across the chest, both with heavy burns from acid. Jeremy plugs into the general quarters system.

"This is private Hopkins. The Xeno has been dealt with."

"Hopkins? Jesus I'm glad to hear your voice" comes a reply. At this the armored door to the armory opens. A half dozen fully kitted marines tumbled out, see the rocky and stop.

"Ah fuck Henderson and Romero" one of them says.

"Wrestled a fucking Xeno to the ground and gutted it with a vibrablade!" The marines stood around their fallen comrades.

“He held on and used his body to absorb the aliens acid. He saved your lives in more ways then one.” Jeremy points out.

"A hero's death." says another. At once they beat their chests and say "Hu-Rah."

"What happened?" asks Jeremy. They all turn their attention back to the rocky.

"Fucking thing came out of the access panel and landed on Romero, who promptly flipped the Xeno onto the floor. When we lost contact with everybody, we all kitted up. Romero was wrestling with the thing on the floor, but he’d fucked up by then and was dying. Henderson draw his moly-blade said he was going to ‘take care of it’ and hit the armory override slamming shut the doors shut.

Looking at Henderson's body the young marine takes a breath.

“Realizing it was going badly for both of them, we hit emergency module eject button. Then we lost gravity and started tumbling. We strapped in and watched on the external monitors. The Xeno beat against the door but it was clear it had taken a mortal wound. It was getting thrown around the module and screeched and yelled about it. We waited until landfall because we knew a ten mil would pop us like a balloon. The plan was to pop the door and shredding the fucker when you showed up." Jeremy focuses on the marine whose name tag reads Fisher.

"Corporeal Fisher, Welcome to the Asheron. I'd advise you get someone on a terminal and get the point defenses up and running." Nodding another marine immediately gets to a terminal.

"Apparently there's some scientists here who had some control over the Xeno's and that's all gone to hell. They're hold up in some compound fifty clicks from here. Hurgs is heading over to their other research base or something." Fisher nods.

"Glad to have your rocky and the extra firepower."

Jeremy replies back "Roger that. With Edgar acting up, this unit won't be going anywhere soon. To this Fisher perks up, "What the fuck happened?"

"Dunno. Something to do with these scientists, it triggered some fail safe. I don't know any more than you do." replies Jeremy.

A marine comes up to Fisher, "Sir, I've got the point defenses on line, but the weather is playing hell with the system. I'm seeing movement five hundred meters out, but I can't make much of it." At this Jeremy backs his Rocky out of the unit and they close the airlocks. The two marines in body bags have been placed under the MCM. "Sir, I'm going to launch a drone to get a better vantage point."

"Sounds good. We're pretty blind up here without Edgar." I reply. Quickly Alice starts integrating the input. The MCM has landed among at least eight nests, the nearest is about a hundred and fifty meters away.

Jeremy jokes over the channel, "Picked the right side to land on!"

We all nod. He could have easily bingo’d right on a nest opening. One rocky is pretty badass, but on flat ground against an unknown number of xenos, it's at best a delaying action. Roxie joins into the channel.

"Sir, I've managed to open the door to the main habitat spar, you'll want to see this."

On the monitors, the feet of a marine are seen sticking out of a vent, frozen blood has pooled around the ankles. Another marine is on the floor his helmet and face mask a shattered ruin. Past this the entire corridor has been plastered with the alien resin. "Looks like they were ambushed." Roxie smashes her way through the resin and her rocky finds itself nose to nose with two Xenos in the hallway and behind them the controller Xeno. It's brief and bloody. Roxie obliterates all three in moments. The blood splashes against the corridor walls and begins to eat into them.

"I was afraid of that," she says.

Alice pipes up, "Structural integrity warnings from habitat spar two grid section 43." We all nod. Three Xeno’s worth of blood can do plenty of damage.

"Alice, how serious is this?" I ask.

"Full extent of damage unknown. Gladiator ships are build with a high level of redundancy." I've worked with Alice long enough to read between the lines. Shit is broken, but without direct access to the systems, Alice won’t want to speculate too much, but it’s clear that it’s pretty dire.

Alice pipes up with more info, "Rocky one is now five hundred meters from the entrance to the beta site." I head back into the pit and this time I do a clean jack in. Seeing the weather on the screen and experiencing it through the neural jack are two different things. Heat lightning crackles across the sky and rain lashes the rocky. At least I didn't have to worry about waste heat. The trash can sized nuclear reactor at the core of my rocky is pumping out serious amounts of power. Under normal circumstances cooling such a thing would be a problem. I checked the power levels and was pleased to see that even over two weeks of daily use, the reactor had only used a couple percentage of its fuel. I idly wonder what fresh hell I am descending into. I am now a hundred and seventy five meters out. I stop the sled and contemplate my options. I'm a single rocky, I need to play this smart.

"Alice, launch a drone to give me over watch and send one down the tunnel to see what I'm up against." Immediately drones takes off from the sled. I ride shotgun as Alice dives the little saucer shaped ariel vehicle down into the opening.

In the center chamber I can see a re-enforced durasteel door like at the alpha site, but peeled from the wall on one side. They couldn't go through it, so they went around it. The drone spins in the center of the chamber sending lidar pulses down the tunnels that radiated out. No movement, but we knew better. In a moments notice Xenos could can out of every damn crevice. Alice moves the drone through peeled gap of the doors. The rough surfaces gave way to the clinical gleam of a lab. On emergency power and

with smashed lights an eerie flicker of yellow emergency lights fill the lab with an eerie glow. The scene is grizzly. Blood streaks the walls. Cages are broken open, lab equipment is smashed. There’s a level of violence here that shocks me. Freezers are ripped open, their shelves and vials scattered. This was beyond the base Xeno need to find vessels to reproduce, this was hate filled. The drone flies on, the horrors grow. Robinson had been right, Ziegler has been a busy man. Alice stops in front of a stasis tube, the upper half of an armless drone floats in the water, electrodes
bristle from it's elongated head. Alice flies on.

Lying dead in a hospital bed is girl, clearly a hybrid of human and Xeno XNA/DNA. Her angelic face is contrasted against her bio mechanical head wearing a crown of electrodes. Her chest is slashed open. The gleam of bio mechanical anatomy and petite human features are intermixed in an elegant way. Despite all the horror and the gore, I have to admit that she is or was beautiful. Scattered around her are busted tablets and building block toys. I have no way of estimating her age, but my thinking is that she couldn't be more than ten. On the wall is a drawing splashed in blood, the corner reads the name “Eli.”

Janice gasps "What in the unholy christ has this madman been doing?" she whispers.

Robinson just snickers, "What he always dreamed to do. Get far away from anyone who would ask any questions and play god."

I agree with him on this. The drone flies down a couple tunnels but finds nothing. This site is a tomb.

I bring the radio up to full power. "Hurgs here, calling Zigler."

I get an immediate reply, "Zielger here. What's the status of the beta site?" he asks.

"Destroyed" I reply flatly. Over the link I hear a heavy sigh.

"In the lab there was a very special young girl." he says.

"She's dead." I reply.

"Her name was Eliana." he whispers flatly over the link. Clearly, this is a heavy blow to him.

"I didn't find any survivors. The lab had been wrecked," I reply.

At this I hear him take a deep breath and let it out.

"Any status on the main habitat?" he asks.

"We've got people fifty clicks out and we're formulating a plan." I reply.

"Well, formulate faster. If what I'm being told is correct, there's a large assault being planned." he replies.

Janice whispers in my ear in our side channel, "How can he know that?"

I reply back, "He's got more of these hybrids, it must be his link to the controller Xeno's."

"Please define large scale." I ask.. "That I don't know. But I can easily guess, hundreds? I also think the controllers have made some deal with the queens."

Just fucking wonderful.. the millipede worth of shoes kept dropping.

"Ziegler, when were you going to let us in on this?" I ask.

"I'm learning this now, I promise. Please get your troops to the main habitat."

Alice now whispers in my ear, "Based on vocal strain, this person Ziegler is under extreme stress."

Thanks Alice. I appreciate the analysis and it confirms my fears.

"Is the Alpha site still intact?" I ask. "Barely. They've been pounding and scratching around the door for an hour, but don't seem to be making much headway.

"They undermined the door in the beta facility, it sounds like they're using that tactic as well." I reply.

"Shit. I know I just sent you to the beta site, but I think I'm in trouble here." he replies. I sense the sled shifting under my feet.

"I can be there in twenty minutes." Alice points out that she can probably push it and do it in less. I agree with the Alice, now that the track has been made it's not worried about flipping the sled. Alice isn’t kidding. The AI pours on the speed. Even in the driving rain, the sled is easily doing a hundred an seventy.. I see the steam coming up from the sled, as its reactor is running at max power. I ask Alice to keep me posted and keep the drones flying.

Janice pings me to head to the conference room, I cleanly eject. I wander in to some seriously long faces. "What's up?" I ask.

Roxie is sitting at the table. "I finally found the other Xeno." she replies. "That's good?" I ask. "Yes, and no. That fucker is dead, but not before they managed to tear into the food, break a bunch of stuff in the muster module and then made its way down to the engine module and tried and thankfully failed to get the door open and do any damage.

"Any thing about Edgar?" I ask.

Ruvi shrugged. "Still doing whatever its crazy cyber brain is doing. The CIC module is still intact, and the Xeno's are all dead so we should be able to get in there and at least disconnect him if not more."

Janice laughs at this. "There's also the damage that was done to the habitat spar. I've run some calculations and the smartest thing is to jettison those sections, otherwise it's going to be real dodgy getting up to super luminal speed with that spar."

I trusted Janice in this regard, she'd started as an engineer before getting recruited into the program. I turned to Robinson,

"Think you can persuade some marines to go unplug a crazy computer?" He nods and gets on the tether and starts dishing out orders. Quickly Marines make their way to the CIC. Edgar is isolated from the DeBe. Hatches are closed, sections are re-pressurized. Finally we start to get a handle on the ship. Getting home without Edgar is going to be complicated, but that's a bridge we'll burn when we get there. Robinson makes a show of it returning to the CIC like a triumphant hero, I'm glad to have him out of my hair.

Chapter 12.

"Hurgs, Are you there? Hurry up!!" I hear over the radio.

I don't even need Alice to analyze his voice, he's freaking out. Alice has now unlocked the safeties and is running the reactor at a hundred and eighteen percent of safe power output. Janice, Marco and Ruvi are both ten minutes out dropping in an almost perfectly ballistic arcs.

"Hurgs here. We are a couple minutes out," I reply.

"They've breached the facility. We have moved to a secure room and are engaging in a holding action."

Janice speaks up, "With what?"

I agree. Looking at the last facility it didn't look like much resistance had been put up. Cresting a low hill I see the mass of drones in the distance and they see me. A howl and a ripple of turning Xenomorph heads announces my arrival. A troop of Xenos split off and start running in my direction.

"Alice, goal keep at fifty yards," I say.

"Engagement threshold set," the AI says into my ear.

In this moment I appreciated Marco loading additional ammo onto this sled.

"ETA in about two minutes." Janice calls out over the subspace comms.

Alice highlights the three streaks in the sky.

"Good. It's a shit show!" I laugh.

"Roger that, Alice is giving us great video." she laughs back.

"It looks like there are three distinct groups," notes Marco.

He's right. I can see two queens each with their own armies and I can a trio of controller Xenos surrounded by their own troop of Xenos.

"Jesus, that's a shitload of Xenos" laughs Marco.

By my automated count, there were at least forty full sized xenos per queen plus a fair number of their "attending," Xenos.

"Sir, what's the plan?" asks Janice.

"Drop right in the middle of them, fire retros as low as you can." I reply.

The plan almost works. Some of the Xenos must have seen the play before others seemed confused. The three rocky’s drop out of the sky, their retros firing fifteen meters above the ground. Dozens of Xenos caught in the rocket down wash explode as their blood flash boils. The con of being vacuum

tight. Better prepared for what is ahead their Rocky's are kitted up to kill, their sleds are covered with extra ammo canisters.

"Too bad we have to save these civvi's. Now that we've got the DeBe's guns back online this would have been an easy one." laughs Marco.

He's not wrong. A couple rail gun rounds and we'd be in the mess eating whatever the xeno on the DeBe hadn’t spoiled.

"We know the drill, let's clear a path to the entrance." to make the point I continue to maneuver my sled closer. Pinched in from four sides, the Xeno's throw themselves at our rocky's. A trio of forty millimeter grenades sends the largest of the queens to hell. Janice manages to shred the other queen. The controller xeno's spread out and make themselves scarce. I give Alice the priority to target them in particular. Alice at this point shows her true AI power. Targeting and dropping Xeno's with blinding efficiency, all four of our rocky's dump grenade and ten mil HE rounds as we move towards the entrance. Realizing it’s turning into a rout, suddenly the xenos turn tail and flee from the rocky’s.

"Save ammo. Only fire on xenos that come inside a ten meter exclusion zone." Everybody acknowledges this. It doesn't take long before battle lines are drawn.

"Ruvi, Marco, hold the entrance, Janice you're with me." I order.

Both acknowledge. We descend back down into the alpha site. We know the layout well at this point and head right for the armored door. The wall next to the door is undermined. Alice launches a drone through the gap. Together our rocky's rip the door from its hinges.

"Ziegler, we are in the facility." I radio.

"Finally! Go straight in at the tee junction, head right. Kill everything." he replies.

"Roger that." I reply.

Much like the Beta site, high tech lab equipment punctuated by macabre experiments are everywhere. More twisted hybrids. A Xeno float in tanks with six arms. Xenos, a mix of some draft animal and Xeno DNA lay dead in pens. Through the link I can feel Janice's disgust. I know that Marco would have been entirely too distracted by the experiments. We get to the junction and head right and come face to face with a controller Xeno. Janice's vibrablade cleaves the Xeno diagonally with a single slice. From there it's a wall to wall shooting gallery. The Xeno's attempt to box us in as more come from the other left hallway. Focusing ahead on the door, I ask Alice to take care of them. Targeted shots

drop the first row, the second row stop at the junction and snarl. I'm down to fifty seven ten mil rounds and three forty mil grenades.

"Hostiles in the left corridor seem to be hanging back, should we clean them out?" I ask over the radio link.

"As long as we have a path to the surface we should be fine."
comes a reply.
I hear the sound of a heavy blast door retract. Out comes an older man with salt and pepper hair and a young girl, another hybrid.

"This is Elizabeth. I've set the self destruct, I just need to trigger it." he says out loud, holding up a palm sized trigger. I realize I need to turn on the external speakers.

"Roger that. Let's move." I say. Janice's rocky moves back into the tee. The Xeno's there back away. We notice the moment our guns swivel away from them, they attempt to creep closer. We back our way out of lab and into the main tunnel. In our mission channel is explain the situation.
I can almost sense Marco's glee.

"How do you think these Xeno's are going to react when you come out of the tunnel with that hybrid girl?" asks Ruvi.
I'd been wondering this myself. I get the sense that the Xeno's aren't that keen on Ziegler's experimenting.

"Dr. Ziegler, we've got a fifty meter climb to the surface, there are a lot of drones up there."
Extending one of my smaller dexterous hands I point at Elizabeth.
"How are they going to take seeing her?" I ask.
He turns to Elizabeth. "What is the current mind state?" he asks.
"Um, I sense Confusion. Anger. Yearning command." she replies.
Ziegler scratches his chin. "You managed to kill the queens, did you get any of the controller's?" he asks.

"No. The disappeared as soon as we engaged the drones." I reply.

"Those particular controllers are wily." he replies.
Just great. So there are even smarter Xeno's.
I opened a channel to just Alice. "Since you are scanning all the feeds if any of the controller aliens show up, alert us"

"Roger that. CPU time set aside to do dedicated image analysis."
replies Alice.
Ziegler turns back to Elizabeth, "Reassure them that there is control" he says.
At this the girl puts her head down. "This is going to be harder without the harness." she replies.
"I know, but you must try."
Over the radio Marco speaks up, "Guys, the drones are being weird up here."
"Define weird." I reply.
"They're formed groups of eight and put their heads together."
he replies.

"Ziegler, my guys topside are saying that the drones are putting their heads together." I say through the speaker.

"Good. It might be working." he says.

At this she starts crying. "They're not listening to me. All they want is to listen to her."

It occurs to me at this moment, while a hybrid she's a child being put in a horrible situation.

He hugs her, "No worries, keep trying."

"I think we're going to have to run and gun," I say out loud.

I can see the look on their faces.
"To where?" asks Ziegler.
"I figure either up to the DeBe or to the Marines on the ground. In either case standing around here, eventually the drones on the ground are going to get sick of this and come for us," I reply.

"Could you take them all out?" Ziegler asks.

I see the look on Elizebeth’s face. The idea of killing drones bothers her. As I look at her closer I can see she's even a stronger mix of bio mechanical and human.

Janice whispers into the side channel, "Let's call a drop ship down and get ourselves over to the MCM module. If this poor creature finds herself on the ship she'll never touch firm ground again."
I don't disagree with her, but her odds of surviving here are pretty shitty as well.
I look at where we are in orbit and our choices suck. Doing the math, even if we dropped a ship now, it's going to be a half hour out. I open a side channel to Robinson and explain the situation.

"I have half a mind to hit the entire site from orbit and wash my hands of this whole sorry affair, but I'm not going to do that. That girl or thing seems to have some way to control the Xeno's, I think that's a worthy asset to keep."

This was Robinson for you, nothing a rail gun round can't fix.

"Sir, once we're clear of this area, I'd recommend that, but we'll need to move a considerable distance considering the biological's we'll have in tow." I reply. Returning my focus to situation at hand.

"Ruvi and Marco, When I give the signal I'm going to need you two to draw off the Xeno's. Don't hold back.

"Yes sir!" came a hardy reply.

"Each of you is going to ride one of our rockies, when we get out of the tunnel these rockies are going to head straight for our overland vehicles called a SLED. There aren't any real handholds, and we plan on going rather
fast." I say out loud.
They both nod in understanding.
"Elizabeth, this is Janice's rocky." I say.
At this Janice extends her smaller manipulator hands.
"Elisabeth, why don't you ride on my back, you can use the smaller set of hands as a seat." Janice says. She nods and climbs on board the rocky.

"Dr. Ziegler, you're with me." I say and I extend my smaller arms. He climbs onboard and situates himself.

"How big is this blast going to be?" I ask.

"Big. When I pull the trigger the fusion plant is going to go prompt critical." he says.

Janice whispers to me, "That's one way of getting rid of the evidence. That's going to be easily a five kiloton blast. We're going to need to be thirty kilometers away." I'd also done those calculations and they matched up.

"Ziegler. Don't trigger that thing until we're far away." I say.

"Don't worry. I rather like living." he replies.

"Guys it sounds like this might be a suicide mission," I say over the link.

"Yeah, we figured that going in, we packed for a fight." replies Ruvi.

"Light'em up boys!" I yell.

Alice's drone gives us a birds eye view of the action. Both their rocky's had dropped their manipulator arms in favor of additional gun and ammo hard points. Blazing arcs of fire ripple out into the Xeno's. To their credit they charged the two rocky's regardless.

"Behind us!" Janice yells. Sure enough charging out of tunnel, dozens of xenos come up behind us. Fuck, I knew this was too easy. Our two rocky's burst out of the tunnel entrance to lashing rain and a host of screaming monsters. A half dozen Xeno's come out of the tunnel and head straight for us. I can only imagine to the xeno's she must be a beacon in the dark.

Janice speaks up in the chat, "She's hissing and saying they're coming, they're coming over and over."

"Janice, see she can confuse them." I say.

Our sleds maneuver themselves so we can get on board.

Ruvi is shifts to our flank and unloads a dozen grenades down the tunnel entrance. The shockwave

emanates from the tunnel. Knocking a couple of the drones at the entrance down. A single drone crawls out of the entrance, it's body a wrecked mess. The others are now looking around confused.

"Whatever she's doing, it's working" I say to Janice.

"She's mumbling something about the devourer." she replies.

Lovely, that sounds like more fun. Crazily enough both Ruvi and Marco have managed to whittle the Xeno's down to a hissing mass that's using cover to maneuver around the rocky's. The shits are moving tactically, I honestly don't love it. They're dangerous enough when they just rush us, now they're being smart. My brain is working overtime aided by cybernetics and Alice processing all the data from the dome. The rain, the Xeno's, the squishy cargo I need to make sure I don't accidentally step on or blow their ear drums out. Finally the sled confirms we are linked and locked. Now locked securely to the sled we take off.

This change in events snaps the Xeno's out of their confusion and they give chase. The ones flanking Ruvi and Marco decide to make a run for it. Apparently with enough motivation, whatever tactical mind is controlling them can't keep them in control. Poor choice. Marco unloads into the group with a burst from his chain gun. The red tracers rip outward in a sweeping arc. Xeno's are cut down where they stand others dive for cover.

"I'm fucked!" yells Ruvi into the radio. Isolated, he's being swarmed, as a parting gift he triggers all the grenades left in the magazine. Back lit against the raging storm the shockwave throws a random assortment of rocky and Xeno parts high into the air.

"How many did I manage to take out?" asks Ruvi over the radio.

"At least ten, it was cool," laughs Marco.

Marco climbs onto his sled and links it to my sled and takes off after us. Depleted of their numbers the Xeno's stop. Where the damn controllers are they've finally got a handle on the last of the troops. Rain lashes the sleds, the churning treads throw geysers of mud into the air.

"We're getting soaked here!" Ziegler says into the mic on my rocky. I have little pity for this dip shit. We're in this mess because of this asshole. He can shiver. Finally after a couple of minutes I bring up the audio on my rocky.

"Drop ship is on the way, it doesn't seem like the Xeno's are following us, ETA in a seven or so minutes." I say.

"Thank goodness." he says.

"Our plan is to head to the marines module, I don't thinking bringing her onboard is going to be a good idea." I say.

At this I see him stroke his chin and wipe the dirt and rain from his face.

"Probably not. She's been to the settlement before, she'll feel safer there" he replies.

To punctuate the point, the storm only intensifies. Clocking hurricane force winds, the sleds are forced to slow down and extend their treads farther out.

Janice whispers to me on a side channel, "Can a drop ship even fly in this weather?"

Honestly, I wasn't sure. It seems crazy to me.

"Alice, are we even near the edge of this storm?" I ask.

"No. From your current location, the storm is active more than five hundred kilometers in all directions." it replies.

"Can a drop ship fly in this?" I ask the AI.

"These conditions are barely within it's flight envelope." it replies.

"How close to the upper end?" I ask.

"Close." Alice replies.

I'm reminded once again that Alice has been online far longer than most AI's. I've been warned several

times that I should reset Alice back to initial program parameters. I haven't because in her old age she's become somewhat cagey and wily and clever at times. Honestly, I like it.

"Who's flying the drop ship?" I ask.

"I'm piloting it." Alice replies.

"Robinson didn't want to risk a pilot?" I ask.

"Correct." Alice replies.

Honestly, it's the call I would make as well. Bad enough flying one of our drop ships into a mother of all storms losing a qualified pilot is another kick in the face.

My rocky picks up the ping from the drop ship.

"ETA thirty seconds" I say out loud.

"Thank goodness" replies Ziegler.

"Don't thank me yet. It's going to be a rough ride." I reply.

The drop ship dives down and throws its VTOL thrusters into high gear. Unfortunately the drop ship only has room for one sleds. Marco once again bitterly complains about having to ditch his sled and climbs aboard. The rocky's compact down folding in their legs.

"Who's flying this thing?" asks Ziegler.

"Cyber corps AI via subspace," I reply.

"He holds up the detonator up to my sensor bulb and presses the button. He then shakes his head and climbs up the ladder with Elizabeth.

"Note to everybody, the self destruct has been triggered." I say into the channel. Everybody acknowledges. I eject. Marco, myself and Janice grab a quick bite. Ruvi is busy watching the tactical views from the various Rocky's.

"How big is that blast going to be?" asks Marco.

"Five kilotons or so, in fact it should happen any second," I say. I'm off by thirty seconds.

"I've just detected the detonation." Alice says into the general channel.

"Got any measurements?" I ask.

"No hard ones. However, based on the power needs of the site and the presumed size of the reactor, likely close to what Dr. Ziegler has said," replies Alice.

I could only hope it took a couple of those damn clever controllers with it.

Jeremy strolls into the conference area.

"How's it going?" I ask.

"Quiet. Weirdly quiet. the MCM is surrounded by nests, but we haven't seen a peep."

Bringing up the footage from our encounter at the alpha site, everybody is shocked to see the Xeno's using cover so effectively.

"We've got drone's high up providing over watch and the point defenses turned up. If anything larger than a mouse gets with in fifty meters of the MCM it'll get slagged."

Ruvi piped up at this. "Yeah, but those point defenses don't have that much overlapping coverage, couldn't the Xeno's just sacrifice a bunch of themselves and take one of them out?"

The look on Jeremy's face worries us all. Those defenses are designed to knock missiles out of the air a list ditch effort if all else fails.

"How many rounds do each of those have?" I ask.

"Fifteen hundred, twenty millimeter case less scatter rounds," he replies.

"Thankfully the Xeno's don't know that." Janice points out.

"So in fifteen minutes when our good friends show up, how do you think the xenos are going to take that?" I ask.

"Well, if the Alpha site is any indicator, it's going to be a shit show." replies Marco.

Chapter 13.

The ride is as rough as I'd warned them it might be. Alice seriously impresses me with their piloting skills. Watching Zeigler I can tell he's starting to turn green around the gills.

"Alice, please patch me into the ships intercom system." I ask.

"Patched in." replies the AI.

"Ziegler, grab a headset." I say.

"Okay, I've got a headset on, what's up." he asks.

"We're roughly fifteen minutes from the MCM where the marines are hold up. I'm fearful that when we show up with Elizabeth, the nests around it are going to meet us with an un-welcoming party." I reply.

"That's not out of the question. Maybe we can help with that." he replies.

"Hello Sir?" I hear a voice on the comms.

"Hi Elizabeth, it's Hurgs, I'm one of the operators that controls one of the robots." I reply.

"Do you think you can keep the Xeno's from attacking us?" I ask.

"I can try. There's so many and she's so strong." she replies.

"She?" I ask. At this I can hear a sigh through the link.

"She's telling them to follow her. She's tell them shes safe. She calls me, she calls me bad names." She whimpers out. Now she's crying.

"Hurgs. She's been talking about this other 'she' for a while now, I don't know who or what it is." he says through the link.

"I know this sounds weird, but is there anyway to triangulate where this 'she' might be?" I ask Ziegler.

"Sadly, no, it doesn't work quite that way." he replies.

The way the Xeno's communicated has never well been understood. This guy claims to be the foremost expert and it's still spooky to him.

"If we can get to the main habitat, we may have more options." he says into the comms.

"More hybrids like Elizabeth?" I ask.

"Sadly, no. But equipment to make make her signal stronger." he replies.

"Right now though, we need Elizabeth to try to keep the natives quiet. Land, load up and go." I say.

"Okay, I'll see what I can get her to do." he says.

The next ten minutes the marines empty the armory and load it into modular store crates we can easily carry with the rocky's.

"Sir, should we leave the point defenses active?" asks Jeremy.

At this I laugh, it seems pretty fitting. "Yes." I reply.

I open the link backup to Ziegler.

"Change of plans. You think you can get Elizabeth to really piss them all off?" I ask.

"Hurgs, what are you playing at?" he asks.

I explain the plan and he chuckles a bit.

"She's working on keeping them calm now, but she can sense the this other she that she keeps going on about." he replies.

"Let's give it two minutes and then have her start really laying into them." I reply.

I watch has he takes the headset off and start explaining what the plan is. I see her frown at this, but Ziegler keeps talking. Robinsons words of warning about Ziegler ring in my ear, I listen as he turns it around that she's saving her new friends she's doing a good thing and that it'll make him happy. I watch her frown change into a neutral face of understanding.

At long range I can see the heap of equipment.

"Alice, open the doors, this is going to be a touch and go."

"Roger that. I can't just hover, the downwash is going to be dangerous to the marines on the ground." the AI replies. I can see through the sensors on the drop ship that the MCM has been blackened from the reentry. Alice lands the ship meters from the cargo. Doors open, we drop and start loading the crates. The poor marines are forced to carry the crates four marines to a crate. With the rockies we can carry the crates in two at a time.

"They're coming!" I hear over the link.

"How many?" I ask.

"Lots! Whatever she said to them, it got their attention!" says Jeremy.

"Eta?" I ask.

"Thirty seconds until the PD's start firing." a marine calls out.

We nearly get all the crates on, sadly two are left behind.

I ask into the general channel. "What were in those crates?"

"MREs sir." someone says.

That's marines for you. Priority weapons and ammo over food. To be fair, I'll take bullets over food. As the dropship transitions from VTOL mode to flying mode I tap into the feed from the drones left flying over the MCM to feed targeting info into the point defense systems. Effective is the word. These systems were designed to shred an incoming missile with bundles of tungsten flechettes. Against a swarm of Xeno's shoulder to shoulder, entire ranks of Xenomorph drones fall kicking and screaming. Unfortunately these weapons don't have the ammo capacity to really do much. After the third wave, the cannons fall silent. The Xeno's sensing their opportunity swarmed the MCM, wrenching the now useless cannons from their mounts. At once the MCM stops existing replaced by a fireball of expanding plasma.

"What the hell?" I said into the channel.

"I decided once we were clear to detonate the remaining fuel in the tanks." Fisher, the marine commanding the MCM says into the chat.

"I just didn't know about the plan, that's all, but you just cooked a shit ton of Xeno's so I say the kills go to you guys." I say back.

"Fuck yeah!" comes through the channel.

I listen in as the marines talk about the tattoos they will be adorning themselves with when they go back to the DeBe.

"Alice, how does our fuel levels look?" I ask.

"Unfortunately we are overloaded and will be cutting it close. Once we get to main settlement I calculate I will have approximately ten minutes of fuel at full power." replied Alice.

"Enough to get back to orbit?" I ask.

"No." the AI replied curtly.

Just another twenty minutes and then into who knows what. Elizabeth is crying, I can hear it through the channel.

"What's up?" I ask.

"She's crying about the devower, the eater of all things. whispering and hissing. Snarling and then whimpering, it's very odd." replies Ziegler.

Janice pipes up in our private chat, "We don't know anything about this link, for all we know this other entirely whatever it might be could be watching us through her eyes."

I'd wondered about this. This was all essentially magic to me at this point.

"How does this link work?" I ask Ziegler.

"We are just starting to fully understand it, but as best as we can tell the Xenos have something like a network of quantum entangled particles in their heads." he replies.

"So their telepathy is actually a low power subspace radio?" I ask.

"Yes, but the signal is far messier. It's almost like transmitted brain waves." he replies.

"Is there any danger that thing she keeps talking about, could it I don't know, read her thoughts or see through her eyes?" I ask.

"I don't think so, but you must understand she and her siblings are the first successes we've had trying to create a docile hybrid."
he replies.

"Docile?" I ask.

"I know the term is pejorative, but it fits. She comes from a long line of siblings that at best could be caged and at worst had to be immediately destroyed at birth. She on the other hand is working on her studies and currently has passed her ninth year exams," he replies.

I think back to the ghastly experiments I saw in the two labs. He'd been down here for decades messing around with XNA and human DNA experimenting. At some level I understand that this work had to be done, if as Robinson says the Xenos are damn near everywhere on every planet, having a way to direct them or control them is needed. I just wasn't enjoying seeing the sausage of that getting made.

"Arrival in five minutes." Alice says over the drop ship channel.

"Anything we should worry about, SAM systems or anything like that?" I ask Ziegler.

"Nothing like that, the settlement is nearly a half kilometer underground, please have the AI land about fifty meters from Hadley's chin." he says.

"Did you hear that Alice?" I ask.

"I did. Dr. Ziegler, please come up to the cockpit." the AI says.
"What do you need me for?" he asks.

"My sensors are picking up a number of features that do not match anything in my data banks." the AI replies. Alice feeds me the visuals from the various sensors on the front of the dropship.

"Land in front of that square. Is there anyway I can transmit a code from any of these consoles?" he asks.

"On your left is a standard colonial marines multi-band radio." Alice notes.

I watch from the optics inside the cockpit as Ziegler enters a frequency and proceeds to enter a ten digit code. He stares at the radio for a moment and enters another code. I see him then peer through the cockpit.

"Are there any nests near this location?" I ask.

"I haven't been in these parts in a couple years, but last I knew, no. I've sent the garage door code, If things are okay an elevator should be on the way up." he says.

"What if things aren't okay?" I ask.

"Then I've got a bunch of marines and robots to hopefully make it okay." he laughs.

Alice spins the aircraft around and sets it down gently, almost showing off after the hard touch and go she'd executed at the MCM. This time the marines have the crates loaded so when the doors open, a sled rolls down the ramp stacked with crates. Gotta love marine efficiency. Ziegler walks down the ramp wearily looking left and right. Getting down on his hands and knees, he digs in the dirt, finally opening a panel on the ground. Filled with water, the lights are still illuminated. Punching buttons he shuts the cover. Rain continues to ripple across the open field, the almost endless rumble of thunder gets to the point I ask Alice to filter it out of audio stream. What seems like an eternity goes by and finally a square shaft lifts out of the ground.

"Where's the welcome party?" a marine asks.

"There are numerous entrances, this is one of the minor ones less likely to draw attention to us." Ziegler replies.

I can see that he's got a headset on. I open a channel just to him.

"What's the fucking story here." I say.

"Let's get inside and out of the rain and I'll fully explain." he says.

"Can we leave the drop ship here?" I ask.

"Yeah, nothing should get near it." he replies.

"Alice, anything that looks like a Xeno gets near it, use deadly force."

"Roger that. I will defend this asset and destroy it if needed." the AI replies. The cargo elevator is a tight fit, between the us, marines and cargo boxes, we can't all fit.

Fisher and I have a quick conversation and decide to divide the group. Each group has two rockies half the marines and roughly half the gear. I watch has he turns to one of the marines, in fact the

one who had joked at me in the chowline and gives him an instant field promotion to lead the other group.

Group one desends and we leave group two topside.

"Marines, Jeremy and Marco, fall back to the drop ship, you'll be on the second elevator down.” Fisher says.

"Roger that." I hear over the comms. Dutifully the marines left topside slog back to the drop ship.

The doors shut and the elevator descends.

"Where did you get an elevator from?" I ask.

"With good printers and plans you can build nearly anything," he replies.

As the elevator descends I decide to pick at the scab.

"Why the back door, why the weirdness?" I ask.

"To be frank, I didn't leave on good terms. The colonists were unhappy with the direction my experiments were going. Closed minded, the lot of them, they think the right answer is to destroy the Xenomorphs."

"What about the nests that are doing terraforming?" I ask.

"A Xeno is a Xeno to them, they'd rather build conventional atmospheric plants and wait two hundred years, then see the future now. I've drastically sped up the terraforming but they're still not happy." he says.

I open a side channel to Fisher. “Ziegler is being squirrelly with me. I don’t know what kind of welcome we might be receiving.”

“Roger that. I’m not a fan of these scientist types and that guy gives me the creeps.”

The elevator slows and opens into cavernous darkness.

I watch as the Marines creep out into the darkness.

"So, not a hero's welcome I take it?" I say.

"Yeah, no." he snickers.

I shift my optics to a wider bandwidth. Cold storage. Farm equipment, modular building panels and equipment, older large scale 3D printers, ingots of raw high grade metals. Stuff that would be hard to produce in situ and would be needed to kick start a colony.

"Who brings a tractor?" asks Janice into the channel.

The parts are starting to fit together to me. "Colonists thinking they're coming to a paradise." I reply.

"Why would they think that?" she asks.

To this I snicker into the comms channel.

"Because they were lured here," I reply.

"Hurgs, you're a bit more clever than you let on," Ziegler says into the channel.

"The constant whispers of a paradise, that WY was making it up to keep people away, that was you?" I ask.

"No, not me, but I didn't stop it either," he replies.

"These people came here to their deaths and you did nothing?" snarls Janice. Her rocky scuttles towards Ziegler.

Ziegler backs away from Janice, knocking a box off the top of a crate, the echo fills the store room.

"Stop, listen. When they got to orbit they figured out fast what the deal was. Some turned around and left, others decided to take their chances. We never made anyone do anything."

"What about those who decided to strike out on their own? Did you even warn them?" she hisses.

“Yes! We gave the food, weapons, maps, you name it. You’ve seen this place. It’s dangerous! But I’m not anybody’s keeper either,” he replies.

I've known Janice for a decade. The fact that Ziegler is alive is only because Janice doesn't want Elizabeth to see his death. The elevator doors open and the rest of the marines and gear spills out.

"You guys standing around having a party?" asks Erikson.

"Something like that," laughs Janice.

"Movement! Thirty meters and closing, at least five boggies." Erikson says into the tactical channel.

"Xenos?" I ask.

"I can't tell. Don’t think so though. Going too slow to be Xeno's, they’re trying for a tactical formation, but it’s not great." he replies.

"You can't say that anymore, we've seen Xeno's flank our positions today in formation," I reply.

The lights come on in the store room. Maybe Xenos know how to use light switches? It wouldn't be the weirdest shit I've seen today.

"Ziegler? What the fuck?" a voice says over an intercom.

"More of your friends I presume." I laugh.

At this I get a look from Ziegler that could possibly kill a Xeno.

"Rob, no need to be hasty. I'm here in a gesture of peace," he replies to the voice.

"Last I remember, you were told to take your freaks and leave and if we say you again we'd shoot you on site." Rob replies back.

Janice whispers into the side channel, "This is interesting."

No shit. This guy just keeps making friends. I'd yet to tell him Robinson was on the ship over his head and would likely shoot him on sight as well.

"Both the lab sites are gone, we have larger threats now." Ziegler says to the unseen voice.

"Threats you cultivated, threats you made worse, this whole shit show is your doing." spat the unseen voice.

"Let's keep calm and deal with the threats at hand, we can work together to fix all this."
I could hear him laying on the charm now.

"You bring marines, robots and you brought one of those things with you as well?" Rob, the disembodied voice says.

I could hear his frustration, armed marines weren't going to just let him carry out his justice, even if likely it was deserved.

"Her name is Elizabeth." Ziegler hisses back.

"Hi! Sorry we snuck in, it was raining outside," Elizabeth says with a cheery voice. It was clear she could see these people weren't happy with Ziegler so she is trying to help.

"It talks?" asks the voice.

"Yes, she talks." he replies with an edge to his voice.

"Do you control those robots?" Rob asks.

At this I decide to speak up.

"This is cyber specialist first class Hurgs of the Colonial Marines. I'm remotely controlling this unit from orbit on the USCM ship DeBraso." I replied to the question.

The doors open and four armed men come in, trying for a tight tactical formation, weapons drawn. Just looking at their formation it's clear these guys are amateurs. Too close together, but they're trying. I might be a cybertech, but I’m a Colonial Marine Cybertech and I know good a good tactical formation, this isn’t.

Fisher steps forward with is weapon pointed downward, but definitely easily swung back into a firing position.

"Marines, take a knee." he says loudly. The marines all take a knee and point their weapons down.

The four men pause for a moment, Rob nods to the other men and their weapons drift down. The lead man steps forward and extends his hand.

"Rob Deacon. Head of security for Hadley's Heart."

"Lieutenant Mike Fisher, Colonial Marines." replies Fisher.

"What's your total count?" asks Rob.

"Two civs, nine marines, four rockies as we call the robots." replies Mike.

"Looks like you guys brought lots of firepower as well." Rob notes pointing at the crates.

"Yes. We weren't sure what the situation is, so we packed for contingencies." replies Mike.

"Good. I'm not going to say I'm happy to see Ziegler, in fact there's a shoot on sight order that I'm temporarily rescinding in light of current events."

Hearing this didn't surprise me. Ziegler had unleashed monsters that are too clever by half on this planet and everybody is now reaping what this lunatic has sown.

"What's the sit rep?" Mike asks.

At this Rob looks down and shuffles a bit.

"Frankly, not great. We've got the Xeno's contained to the lower levels, but we've lost access to food production, weapons storage and medical." he replies.

"How many civilians are in this facility?" Mike asks.

"Currently, one hundred and ninety four. We had nearly two hundred and fifty but yeah.." at this his trails off. Taken by Xenos used as wombs or fodder, it wasn't a pretty prospect.

"We currently have a drop ship parked about thirty meters from that utility shaft. Is that going to be a problem?" I ask.

"Who knows these days. Expect xenos to start sniffing around soon though," he replies.

I realize the "who knows" is doing a lot in that sentence.

"What do you mean?" I ask.

Pointing at Ziegler, "He made the damn things smarter, but this is a different level of smarter. The first half dozen people that went missing we didn't realize for days, they went after the few loners and odd balls around here."

A marine listening butted in, "How would they know that?" she asks.

"She knows, she knows we're here now." Elizabeth says without anyone even asking.

Ziegler kneels next to Elizabeth, "Is she here now?" he asks.

The little hybrid girl just shakes her head, "I don't know, but I hear her whispers. She calls me a horror and failure, I.." at this she lets out a sob.

One of Robs companions let's out a sigh in response.

"The devourer, you hear her huh?" he asks.

Elizabeth looks up and locks eyes with him, "Yes."

"You can't sit a bar and have a drink that half this place is whispering about that bitch, she seems to be whispering into all of our ears.

"Not mine." replies Rob.

"Me either" mutters one of the other guys.

"Some people are more receptive to the transmissions than others." replies Ziegler.

"Why?" a marine asks.

"Currently unknown, there are promising hypothesis, but without actual experiments and lab work it's not proven." he replies.

Robs radio crackles to life, "Sec team two, what's your situation?"

Rob thumbs the radio, "Complicated. Ask Marshall to get his ass down to access room L16D5." he says.

"I think it best that you guys camp here. Nobody is going to be happy to see him or it, nor the robots." he says to the group.

"How safe is this location from Xeno's?" asks Mike.

"Honestly, Pretty safe. Only two ways in, the walls here are easily fifty meters of solid rock, still, I don't know. I'd keep your trackers on and guns loaded though." he replies.

Now with purpose the marines take a corner that lets them see both the elevator and the doors and and start moving equipment around, setting up fields of fire and generally complaining about all the hiding places the farm equipment affords hostiles. At this point I feel like dead weight. I can't imagine any base commander being fine with a five hundred kilogram armed robot wandering the base. I open the comms to Jason, "I'm going to eject, but will be reachable by comms."

"Honestly, I'm a bit envious of you cyber geeks. I hope your hot coffee scalds you," he laughs.

"I'm going to move my rocky to the center of the room and put it in sentry mode." I reply.

"Thanks." he says into the channel.

Janice and Ruvi meet me in the meeting room.

"I can't believe they have Xeno's in their facility but they're not going after them?" Janice says out lout.

"It's genius actually. They Xeno's went right for their weapons. They know a human against a xeno isn't a fight. First rule of combat, take your enemies advantages away." I reply.

Ruvi shakes his head "That dip shit had to go and make them smarter."
To this we all just nod.

"Alice, what's the status of the drop ship?" I ask.

"Currently all but essential systems are powered down, approximately three minutes of flight at full power." the AI replies.

Roxie wanders into the room, "I got the gist of what's going on down on the ground." At this we all nod.
She continues, "We've got issues up here as well."
I just shake my head, bullshit in every direction.

"The spar that was damaged when we killed the Xeno's, it's now a structural weak point, with every orbit the ship naturally flexes, with each flex more microcracks appear in the spar."
she explains.

"How long until it breaks?" I ask.

"Not this orbit, or the next one, but it will fail, that I'm certain of." she replies.

"Why can't we just eject that section?" I ask.

"Ironically if we were farther out in space it would be easier," she replies.

Janice has now decided to get in on the engineering action.

"How so?" I ask. "We wouldn't be orbiting this forsaken rock, detaching modules wouldn't subject them to drag for starters." she answers.

"What else is wrong" I ask.

"Oh, the xeno's spoiled a bunch of food, cut a bunch of fibre so deep space and internal comms are fucked up and we were leaking coolant until we noticed the haze around the ship. Once we figured out we had a leak we turned shit off until the flow stopped. We've narrowed it down to three radiator banks. I'm sure Edgar would have found in a moment, but instead we leaked out a couple hundred liters of refrigerant." she replies.

"I know I'm just a bit better than a grunt, but isn't coolant critical?" asks Jeremy.

"Yes. With a ship this big and with all the redundancy, one would think, the margins would be larger, but in fact it's going to force us to keep sections vented. We can't risk the heat." replies Roxie.

"What's the commander up to?" I ask.

"With inter ship comms down, last I knew he was in the engine room attempting to make a very long distance and I'm sure quite awkward phone call." she replies.

Needing to stretch my legs I get up and jog down the spar. I can feel the cold. Our patches are holding, but the cold is creeping in. The heat and thrum of the engine room is a positive change from the cold spar. The door to the comm section are open, a terminal is patched in. Hunched over the terminal I can see the outline of Robinson, his form silhouetted against the glow of the terminal.

I clear my throat, "Ah hum, sir." I say.

Nothing. Coming closer I see a stain on the floor. Fuck. Touching his shoulder, he slides out of the chair, the terminal tray acting as a prop for his limb body. Tumbling flat on his face, three clean holes in the back explain everything. Stupidly I'd come to the engine room without any comm device on me at all. The wall comm unit is dark. Either disabled by whoever did the deed to Robinson or a victim of our the ships encounter with the Xeno's. Feeling very vulnerable at this point I sprint back to our module. Normally I pace myself, but not this time. I'm sure if Edgar was up and running he'd have noted a PR for the run. Bursting into the module I immediately lock the door.

"What's going on?" asks Janice.

"Robinson's dead in the engine room, triple tap to the back!" I blurt out. Immediately the group starts peppering me with questions, none of which I had any answers for. I explain that after I found Robinson I wasn't sure if I was in danger, couldn't contact anybody so I hightailed it back to the

module. Knowing that the shit was about to hit the fan, I sat down at the conference table and opened a channel down to Fisher and the marines. As one would expect they took it as well as you'd expect. At least three names come up as suspects. Being out of the chain of command, it wasn't even clear to me who was next in command.

"This honestly doesn't surprise me, I'm just surprised someone had the balls to do it." he finally said into the channel.

After a moment he continued.

"There's a bunch of guys who when they found there were Xeno's thought the right answer was to just obliterate the planet. Any civvi's who'd come here had sealed their fate, better to die quick then the alternative. They were pissed that Robinson had decided to just follow orders, even more pissed that it appeared he was making common cause with this Ziegler guy, then even more pissed that he'd permitted those things on board. They blamed him for their escape, the ship getting tore up and the KIA's that had happened.

"So who's giving orders than?" I ask.

"Well, after the venting, Price, Sanchez and Albright were killed.

I'm down here so technically I'm a subordinate to the orbit commander, so maybe Wikowsky?" came the response.

"Lovely. I don't have a great working relationship with him in particular" I laughed back.

"Yeah, frankly, he hates you guys." Mike snickers back.

"Do you think he'd have the balls to pull the trigger?" I ask.

At this Mike let out a long breath, "Sir, we’re killers. We all have the balls to pull a trigger. He's a hot head for sure, but he's smart and also a NCO looking to become an officer. Yeah sure he could do it, any of us could, but in the years I've worked with him, he's more likely to throw a punch, as you're aware."

Turning to the people in the room, "Ruvi, is your rocky still by the vent?" I ask.

"After the last Xeno was done in, I brought her back to the hanger."

he replies.

I thought it was cute that Ruvi referred to his rocky as a her.

"Get her prepped, I'm going to make a call and see what people have to say."

I opened up the comms. "Calling MCM one on general comms."

"This is MCM one, what's up Hurgs?" comes a response.

"Bad news. I found Robinson in the engine room, looks like a triple tap to the back." I said into the channel.

"Come again? Commander Robinson is dead?" whoever this was on the line asks incredulously.

"Roger that. Please get a ranking officer on the line," I say pointedly into the channel.

"Wikowsky here, what's this shit I'm hearing?" the sneer and disdain come clear through the channel.

"Robinson's dead in the engine room, shot through the heart." I say plainly.

"Just fucking wonderful. I assume you think I did it?" he sneers into the channel.

Realizing I had an opening with the guy I take it.

"Talking to Mike dirt side, he calls you a straight shooter, I believe him, all the same, we've got a case of fragging." I reply.

"For what it's worth, except for two, none of my guys have gone anywhere. Your tech warned us about the spar fractures. We've been hunkered down in this module with the door shut." he responds.

"Whose in the CIC at this point?" I ask.

"Those two exceptions. Diego from first squad and Bells from second squad, why?" Wikowsky asks.

"When he left, he said he was going back to the CIC, without people to man it, it's not much." I replied.

"Robinson pounded on our door and asked for those two by name." Wikowsky replies. I can hear him taking deep breaths on the comms, keeping calm.

Turning to Jeremy, "Grab a pistol and get to the CIC and see what's going on, but don't let the cat out of the bag."

He nods and runs off.

Wikowsky and I are go through what we have for assets and food. We're both okay provided nobody decides to go hog wild for a while.

"What the --" came through the comm channel and it then cut out.

I felt the jolt under my feet. Immediately a cascade of alarms

start going off.

"Depressurization event in main spar." Alice calmly notes.

I hear a pounding on the door to the main spar.

"Alice, open the door!" I yell.

The door slides open and my ears pop, I can feel the air rushing out of our module. Jeremy tumbles in and the door slams behind him. Gasping on the floor he rolls onto his back. Everybody rushes him,

Janice clamps an oxygen mask on his face. Jeremy stares back up at us and just takes a couple deep breathes. His eyes are red from burst capillaries. Finally he takes the mask off, with a wheeze he says,

"Dead sir. CIC is trashed. Bells and Diego were both head shot."

"You functional?" I ask Jeremy.

He gives me a thumbs up and climbs to his feet, albeit shakily.

"Sir, it was cowardly. Bells and Diego where both head shot from behind. I was thirty meters from the module connection point, pistol drawn when I felt the jolt. It knocked me off my feet."

Ruvi just shook his head. "Damn! You ran thirty meters in partial vacuum? Good on you man!"

To this Jeremy just shrugged. "Guess it was time the cracks got big enough to start cause us problems" he replies.

Janice shakes her head "No. That was an explosion. Roxie and I are already trying to figure out where."

Alice spoke up at this point, "Sensors are picking up a class one escape pod forward port side to our module."

"Knocked loose from the explosion?" I ask.

"The escape pod is powered and maneuvering." Alice replies.

"Any idea from which module?" I ask.

This is where having Edgar would have been helpful, but Alice was showing herself to be wildly capable in this regard.

"Note, this is a low probability answer, but based on trajectory, CIC module." replies Alice.

"What's the state of this spaceship at this point?" I ask.

Janice and Roxie are both head down at terminals.

Janice speaks up. "Poor. Whatever that bomb did, based on what I can't see now from before It was in the primary maintenance spar. Sir, it broke the ships back. What little comms we did have are completely down. Based on the sensors in this module our flex is far more pronounced."

In a gesture I've now inherited from Robinson I puff out my cheeks.

"Are we still getting essentials from the ship?" I ask.

"Power is a trickle on a secondary, but not air or water." Roxie replies.

"Ah fuck, I think we're going to have to cut and run." I reply.

"I'm detecting a marine at our airlock" Alice says into the room.

"I'm on it." replies Jeremy.

"Sir, I agree with you. We're not fixing this ship in the current state. Sooner than later we're going to be part of an active break up, I'd rather we not be near that mess. But Janice and I have an idea." Roxie has configured the main screen to show off her idea of a much smaller DeBe.
Wikowsky and Jeremy climb back up to this level.

"You've got nice digs here Hurgs." snickers Wikowsky.

I nod and point to a chair, Wikowsky ignores the gesture, walks over and grabs a handful of snacks and then sits down.

"What did you see outside?" I ask.

"Outside of the utility spar is blown open. Some blue shit I presume is coolant is leaking everywhere." he replies.

Turning to Roxie, "Then we have no choice, how long will it take?"

"A couple hours, if Gunny Wikowsky approves." replies Roxie.

"What's the plan?" he asks.

Roxie points to the plan she’s created on the main screen.

"We both detach the engine module, our two modules and make a smaller ship." I reply.

"Can you even do that?" he asks.

Janice interjects at this point, "Yes. All the modules have universal docking adapters. I presume you pulled a tether with you?"

"Even better, I've turned on our modules comms." he notes.

"Yes. Though the only qualified pilot we had left was Bells," snarls Wikowsky.

"Alice, plot the landing spot of that escape pod." I ask.
Immediately the wall screen illuminated a spot on the planet right on the edge of the exclusion zone of the alien ship.

"Escape pod?" Wikowsky asks.

"Alice, can we shoot that pod down with the rail guns?" Wikowsky asks.

"Answer unknown" the AI replied curtly.

I snicker, "Based on what Jeremy told me, the CIC is pretty trashed, I think that was to keep up from doing exactly that."

"There are redundant controls in that module." he laughs.

"Look where he's landing, shooting him would be a mercy, I'm not one for mercy right now" I laugh.

"Can one of your people remote pilot our module?" he asks.

"Alice, can you do that?" I ask.

"Yes." comes the reply.

To accentuate the point, an audible sound like a gunshot rings through the module.

Wikowsky laughs, "I take it that's bad."

Roxie smoothes her hair back in a gesture I know to be her way of calming herself.

"That spar has now failed entirely and the ships load is being distributed across the other also damaged spars which are now starting to fail in cascade," Roxie says.

“Get back in rocky and get to the engine module we’ll need you to run a comm patch.”

Nodding she heads towards the pit.

Wikowsky speaks up, "Can I get a comm channel to my MCM?" he asks.

I nod. "Alice open a channel."

"Hawkins, this is Wiks, reply." he says.

"Hawkins here, Sir we just heard a very loud bang." he replies.

"We are aware. The plan is to detach our module and hook it up to the geeks module. Their AI is going to remote pilot our module." he says.

At this Alice speaks up into the channel.

"Private Hawkins, This is the Alice the cypertechs AI, please type the following sequence into the comm unit." The AI then proceeds to tell the Private a ten digit sequence. During this interlude I've tied our internal comms to the MCM comms.

"I now have executive access to the MCM module." notes Alice.

"No time like the present, detach modules and maneuver closer to MCM one." I order.

Everybody immediately buckles in. Without the DeBe and the gravity envelope it

provides quickly everything gets floaty. Inside the module I can hear the cold gas thrusters of the module firing in rhythmic pulses.

"Any chance we could also snag the armory module?" Wikowsky asks.

"Comms are down, unless we can mate with it or get a tether or a person to it, we can't command it to detach." I reply.

"Hard mate in approximately ten seconds." Alice notes.

Suspecting that Alice was trying to show off again, the two modules mated perfectly and softly.

"Hard mate complete. Equalizing now." At that I can hear various hisses and pumps as the space between our two doors is filled with atmosphere.

"Equalizing complete. Opening hatches."

Wilkowsky gets up and expertly maneuvers over to the door. I see a blond head poke through the door.

"Permission to come aboard?" he asks.

I laugh. “Son, we're now one ship, permission granted."

The marines float in one by one. Like wide eyed children they weren't normally permitted to come into our module. Nor were we permitted in theirs. Most of them marveled at the wall screen and seeing the trajectory of the escape pod openly muse about shooting down or landing on or around it and avenging their friends deaths. With everybody now roughly in our prep area, pressed against walls, laying flat against the ceiling, I asked Alice to sound the standard three pip general quarters sound. This got everybody's attention.

"As you're all aware, we're deep in the shit. Without the engine module LV426 is going to be home. Right now I've got a rocky trying to patch in, but we need to start thinking about contingencies." Hawkins speaks up "Sir, are you actually pitching the idea of landing this thing?"

"Currently no, but nothing is off the table." I reply.

I could see from the faces of the Marines, some had grins, they wanted to get ankle deep in the mud and fight Xeno's, but quite a few had the looks on their faces that I read as, "Ah shit."

"When we get more info, you'll get more info. Just so everybody is clear the current command structure is Wikowsky in command of the personal from MCM one and I'm in command of personnel from CRM one."

To punctuate this Wikowsky piped up, "To that point, squads one and two, I want you guys to rack and start working simulations based on the data sent up from squad three." To this the marines nod and skittered back into their module.

"Roxie, what's the deal with the engine module?" I ask into the comms.

"Fucked up. I'm on the module but it's not responding on hard line comms. Permission to breach?"

"Yeah do it. Just you know be careful that's our ride home" I reply.

"I'm well aware." she snickers back.

I brought up the feed on wall monitor as Roxie works

Wikowsky snickers, "It's weird to me she's in the next room and not breaching the airlock by hand." At this I shrug.

"I'm in sir" Roxie says over the comms.

From the other module I hear a cheer, they're watching on their hand tablets. Watching the screen I immediately see the problem. The drive coil modules are all missing. Without those we can't spin up to superluminal flight.

Wikowsky nudges me, "Please tell me as an uneducated space marine that drive coils are in fact not missing."

My estimation of Wikowsky at that moment went up by three whole notches.

Speaking in terms that Wikowsky would appreciate "When I get a hold of that fucking bio tech, I'm going to strangle him."

"Do you think he took him on that escape pod or hid them in the ship?" he muses out loud.

"They're too valuable to leave behind, he's got them." I reply.

"What can he do with them? There aren't any ships down there." he asks.

"There aren't any ships that we know about. Plus they've got piles of raw materials and printers.

I'd bet a credit there are plenty of people who now realize that they were sold a lie and would gladly cobble together a ship to get off this shit hole." I reply.

"Sir, the docking controls are inoperable, I've run a bypass."

"Roger that," I reply.

"Initiating undock from main spars." Roxie said onto the comms.

Chapter 14.

I wake up to alarms. My head is screeching. Wikowsky is next to me against the wall, his face a bloody mess, but breathing.

"Roxie, what happened?" I ask into the comms, nothing.

"Alice, status?" I ask.

"Thirty two seconds ago, when Roxie was initiating the undocking, a trap was triggered causing the engine segment to detonate. The engine modules water jacket was expelled outward slamming into our module, doing minor damage."

Wikowsky is now starting to come around, "The fucking hell" is all he has to say.

"Current status Roxie?" I ask Alice.

"Non responsive" is all Alice has to say.

I find Roxie in her cradle unconscious. This is a dangerous state to be in while still jacked in. I initiate a manual unjacking and check her stats. Steady pulse, but non responsive. In zero gee this can be very dangerous.

"All cyber tech members, report to the pit immediately" I say into the open comm channel.

At once there's a flood of activity in the pit. Ruvi and Jeremy pull out the wake equipment, strap her to a body board and plug in.

"Her implants are still in active mode, they didn't take the shutdown command." notes Ruvi.

She's in a limbo state, her implants aren't plugged in so they're essentially "making shit up."

"Forcing implant reboot" Ruvi says.

At once Roxie eyes fly open and she starts coughing and then let’s out a moan.

"You with us?" I ask.

"Barely." she meekly replies.

Jeremy shows me the portable scanner, her implants are all green, but she's sustained a concussion.

I take the scanner and plug it to my neural shunt, I'm all green but also show that they've recorded a high gee shock.

"I think you're going to find we've all taken a bump." I note.

He nods at this and starts going around the room. Sure enough by protocol we all should wait two hours before we can jack in again. I'm just fearful we won't have that luxury.

Wikowsky floats into the pit and finds me. "Your people okay?" he asks.

"Yeah, Roxie was jacked in when the module blew and she got tossed into limbo, but we pulled her out. Everybody got their bell rung. How are your guys?" I ask.

"Bumps and bruises, one broken nose. Otherwise okay."

I just shake my head. "I should have seen this coming. He used a bomb to compromise the spar, knowing we'd have to tinker toy ourselves a ship he knew we'd need the engine segment."

To this Wikowsky just shrugs.

"Alice, what's the state of what's left of the DeBe?" I ask.

"I'm mapping the expanding debris field and I've maneuvered the linked modules to avoid the the bigger chunks. I'm putting the data on the main screen." the AI replies.

Floating over to the screen, I could see that the explosion had sheared all the modules off and they were now moving in a variety of vectors.

"I'd really love to salvage that combat weapons module." notes Wikowsky.

Jeremy floating near by said it before I could, "What if it's rigged to blow. That little bastard was crawling all over the ship while we weren't looking."

"Alice, anyway we could try to get to that module?" I ask.

"Yes, however it will take a significant portion of our fuel. Our time in orbit will limited even if the module retrieve is successful." Alice replies.

I weigh the pros and cons. Wikowsky and I put our heads together and decided that it makes sense. It's risky but the module will gain us tremendous resources, not the least of which is a functional drop ship

"Describe limited?" I ask.

"Four days with careful use of our remaining fuel. The other modules will deorbit sooner." Alice replies.

We talk it over. We're screwed either way, without a drive module we're not going anywhere, long term we needed the parts and supplies from the module. Alice creeps our little ship close to the module. Jeremy volunteers to take a rocky in. Everybody straps in and buckles down. Creeping into the airlock he closes the door and equalizes the pressure. He shifts through the various spectrum’s, nothing. Tapping into the modules internal cameras he cycles through various views.

"Sneaky little fucker." is all Jeremy has to say.

"What did you find?" I ask.

"Right above the door, there's trigger. Standard colonial issue.
The wires go off somewhere. The moment I open the door, blamo."
he snickers.
Alice breaks in at this point, "I'm backing our ship away, please stand
by."
"I thought we used a ton of fuel to get over here?" asks Wikowsky.
"We did, but now that we've matched velocity, it won't take more than a couple puffs of cold gas to put a hundred meters between us and the module." I reply.
"You think that's enough?" he asks.
"Considering the ordnance in that module? No." I reply.
At this he snickers. "At least if a nuke goes off, it'll be over quick."
"Sir, permission to cut through the bulk head to access the wires." Jeremy asks.
"Granted." I reply.
We all watch holding our breath as Jeremy drills a small hole and inserts
a probe.
"There's current in the wires, but it doesn't look digital. I'm going to short the wires together."
With the wires shorted, he opens the door, the trigger still convinced the circuit is closed, does nothing. He reaches up with his pinchers and snips the trigger off the wall. It floats there in shattered pieces. Following the wires, Jeremy finds them stuck into a detonator rigged to a
series of charges against a bulk head.

"Drop ship fuel and oxidizer storage. Yup, that would have blown up nicely." Jeremy laughs and he pulls the wires off. Sending drones off through the module, no other little surprises are found.

"Sir, permission to find this little shit and riddle him with bullets?" Jeremy asks.

In unison both Wikowsky and I say, "Permission granted." look at each other and laugh. Two more hours of maneuver jet firing, closing and re opening hatches and reconfiguration and our little rag tag ship gets much larger and much better armed. Calling down to Mike and Ziegler they were rather unhappy to hear about our situation, even less so when I explained where the techs escape pod had landed with the coils.

Ziegler gets on the line, "Hurgs, even going in hot, you'll be swarmed in moments. The alien ship was marked as a no go zone a long time ago for good reason. The best way I could describe it is

that the queens in that region are known as faction one and they’re a special level of aggressive. On this planet as best as we can tell there are at least seven distinct factions." he replies.

"You cultivated Xeno society?" I ask.

"Oh no. We discovered it. It appears to be an emergent property. As the population of Xenos on this rock has grown, their group think has also grown, it appears there's some upper limit to what one queen can manage, but we've seen queens cooperate, then fight, then go back to cooperate. To us they all just look like Xeno's but to the Xeno's they're all part of distinct factions.”

"What faction would Elizabeth be part of then?" I ask.

"Technically, based on her base XNA, faction five." he replies.

"So she could command Xenos?" I ask.

"Eventually when she's fully grown I suspect they'll do her bidding without question." he replies.

"Just the Xeno's of faction five?" I ask.

"Oh, I think she'll be able to command them all," he laughs.

Considering the situation we’re all in, he’s the only one with any humor other than gallows at this point.

"Unfortunately we don't have how many years that'll take." I reply.

Chapter 15.

Our cobbled together spaceship is air tight, if somewhat cramped, but now well armed. Janice and Roxie are strapped into seats looking at terminals.

"You're looking better" I say to Roxie.

"Yes and no. I feel a bit better, but sir, when I hard looped it was weird." she replies.

"How so?" I ask.

"I can't say I heard or didn't hear voices, but I definitely felt stuff. A weird deep loathing. Overwhelming hatred and anger." she replies.

"We know the Xenos are communicating over subspace, maybe you got tuned into a couple of those superluminal threads?" I reply.

"That's what I'm thinking. I'm sad I never got to take a closer look at that weird module the DeBe had." replies Janice.

I nod. "So many secrets piled on secrets. Not that he would ever tell us, but I'm sure Robinson took quite a pile to his grave."

At that everybody else nods too.

"Knowing that we can tune into those frequencies, any chance we could use that to our advantage?" I ask.

"Janice and I have been poking around at that. The best that we can tell the Xenos are transmitting on literally hundreds of thousands of parallel superluminal threads. We're transmitting on less than a hundred." she replies.

"Are there ranges of luminal threads that are more active than others?" I ask.

In response to this, on the main screen Janice throws up a waterfall graph showing all the superluminal traffic. It was wild to see it on the screen.

"This is all of it?" I ask.

To this she laughs. "This is easily only a ten thousandth."

"Alice, what do you make of these transmissions?" I ask.

"Sir, I'm reaching the limits of my computing capacity with my current tasks. I would only be able to devote a couple percent to that task." the AI replies.

"Fair enough, please devote three percent to analyzing the data, lowest priority." I reply.

"Acknowledged." the AI curtly replies.

Immediately sequences of the waterfall begin to highlight as Alice spends some cpu cycles looking for patterns.

"I'll bet Ziegler has some clues on how to read this," notes Janice.

I nod. He'd mentioned they'd made headway. I open a channel to Ziegler.

"Interesting. Her cybernetics must help her brain to interpret the signals better than normal humans. As for your question, Unfortunately we've had little luck making heads or tails of the signals. On occasion we'll see patterns repeat in the signal, but we lack sophisticated enough gear to fully interpret it."

"How's it looking up there?" he asks.

"Not great, I've got to attend to that, I'll loop you in a bit" I say and close the channel.

With that, I chuckle and have Alice call the general quarters pips.

"Four days?" Hawkins scowls.

"That's what the calculations come out to." I shrug.

"But we've got all this fuel an oxidizer." he sputters.

"Yeah, and it's dragging us out of orbit." I laugh.

"And no engines to feed it into." Janice replies.

"What about the other drop ship?" A marine named Miller who was acting as Wikowsky second in command asks.

"We're going to need that ship to get to the surface and get the coils and refuel the other ship." I reply.

"Not to mention ferry massive engines up here," notes Roxie.

"What about your fancy printer I saw?" he asks.

"The printer is too small and without the raw alloys I can't do anything." she replies.

"So, we're going to land this cobbled together piece of shit?" laughs Miller.

"No. Here's the idea." I start.

I don't say my idea because I want to spread the blame somewhat. Wikowsky and I had talked it through, our options were all shit, this was the least. As I explain the details, the looks of shock spread across peoples faces. The most surprised were the cyber techs.

"Sir, I don't like the idea of landing half of us on the surface." Ruvi starts.

I knew his relationship was Roxie was going to complicate things.

"Janice and Roxie are the only engineers, and not even rocket engineers at that. But I need people who I trust and know how to run big printers." I reply.

To this he nods.

"So how are they going to make these engines then?" asks Wikowsky.

"That's the good news. That technology is well understood and the plans are loaded into the emergency memory banks on all the modules." replies Roxie.

Jeremy shakes his head. "Just so it's clear in my head. We're going to break up this functional space ship, push the armory module into a high circular orbit, leave this module in this orbit and land the other MCM right next to this underground hab. Then Roxie and Janice are going to build engines, use the jump ship on the ground to get them into orbit, put everything back together and also some how retrieve the super luminal coils?"

I nod and reply with, "Or we sit here and play cards for three and a half days until this spaceship breaks up in the atmosphere and we all die."

He snickers at this assessment, "Fair point, but I'd like to note your plan has a bunch of hopefuls. Couldn't they just run the printers from up here using rocky's?"

I'd thought about this, but it became a function of the facility and the state of their equipment.

"Their security people are already not happy with the rocky's." I note.

Janice also shrugs, "There's also the issue with the printers."

At this Wikowsky perks up, "What's wrong with them?" he says.

"They're at least six generations old and have hundreds of thousands of hours on them." she notes.

"So?" he replies.

I can see the great in pass between engineers and soldiers happening.

"What happens when you fire thousands of rounds from a rifle, but never change the barrel or clean it." she says.

He merely nods, "I get it."

"I'm likely going to have to overhaul their printers using parts from our onboard printer just to get it to print reasonable parts." Janice notes.

"How long is that going to take?" he asks.

"A couple more hours at least. Printing in zero gee is just slower."

Wikowsky shakes head, "No, to refurbish the printers down there."

"Honestly, I don't know. Days, weeks, I can only guess based on what scant data their base mainframe will let me see.” Janice replies.

Turning to me she sheepishly says, "Sir, requesting permission to bring our printer to the surface."

I really hate this idea, but I hate being on the surface even more. In the academy they drilled the idea into us to keep options open and that the printers were tools that can make tools. Here I was being asked to remove an asset that I might need later.

"Granted, on the caveat that we at least attempt to take it with us." I reply.

I knew once the colonists saw what the latest generation of printers could do, it would fall off the ship on the way back.

Marines and Cybertechs alike grumbled but there really isn't any other alternative. Lists were made and completed, parts were printed and secured.

The drop-ship is stripped down and loaded to the gills. Walking into the pit I’m distressed to see that the printer had been roughly cut out of its alcove. Apparently they expect it to be repaired in-situ. Packed in a converted weapons crate, I hope the printer will survive reentry.

The mantra "Trust your people" keeps rattling around in my head. Honestly at this point, pulling it apart would likely undo any careful packing they've engaged in. Two days of trying to pack everything you might possibly need, while in zero-g catches up with everybody, the exhaustion and frustration was painted on everybody's faces.

"This seemed like a shit idea when we both came up with two days ago, it still seems like a bad idea." I joke at Wikowsky.

Pointing at my boots, "You're finally going to get to break those in," he laughs.

“I prefer the standard issue Colonial Marines Cybertech lamb skin slippers thank you very much, but I guess grunt boots it is.” I laugh back.

We both giggle. Gallows humor as far as I could see it. I have Alice blow the whistle.

"Everybody hit the rack, in five hours we'll be in orbital position for the MCM drop." Nods and a chorus of "yups and yes sirs" go through our small ship.

Chapter 16.

Regular Colonial Marines have a quality that I envy. The capacity to sleep anywhere with a moments notice. Yet another way I'm built different. Sleep doesn’t come to me at moments like this. After an hour I unzip the sleeping bag and float out. Sleeping in zero gee is also weird. Microgravity tinkers with your inner ear. Ultimately you'll find some position where your head feels up and your feet feel "down". For me it was head down against the wall of my quarters right above bunk built into the wall. Floating out into the main area of the CRM I am surprised to see Wikowsky strapped into the chair working a tablet.

"Can't sleep?" I ask.

He nods. "I hate that we don't have any intel. Alice's sensors are okay, but nothing like what the DeBe had."

I nod back. Looking at the data, the storm seems to only have grown.

I watch as he works the tablet zooming in on spots. Again I find myself impressed with his technical capabilities. He’d leaned into the grunt schtick hard at our first meeting.

"I'm not sure which is worse, the MCM or the drop ship, it's going to be rough either way." I snicker.

I'd already eaten as much anti-nausea meds as Alice would dispense me.

"Which are you riding down in?" I ask.

"I'll be with my men in the MCM." he replies, his answer immediate. It seemed fitting as their commander. He looks at me serious for a moment.

"Hurgs, do you think we've got a chance?"

To this I blow out a breath emulating Robinson.

"This whole mission has been a fractal fuck up. Frankly, I think our chances are low. I'm a math guy and there are too many variables to this equation." I reply.

"In NCO school we call them the unknown unknowns." he replies.

"I know we've had our differences, but the fear I saw in the colonists eyes, it's going to be a pure shit show. Taking their raw materials to build engines, then leaving them to who know what fate?" I shake my head.

"You afraid they won't let us leave?" he asks.

To this I just shrug. There is a growing fear in my gut. This landing, the inevitable bargaining, whatever bullshit story Ziegler had told them, us, this hybrid and her unknown abilities, this devourer entity. I put my hands on my head and rub the various ports and subdermal interfaces that dot my skull.

Wikowsky looks over, "You frosty?" he asks.

I nod. "Variables, too many variables," I say.

He nods back, "unknown unknowns."

Alice whispers in my ear, "The debris that was the DeBe is beginning to reenter the atmosphere." I acknowledge this.

"Main screen." I say.

We watch as the CIC command module enters the atmosphere a tumbling wreck, one of the spars had completely skewered it. The blown open orbital railgun modules massive capacitors, each the size of a rocky and sled combined explode in a shower of small meteors. I can't help but just imagine how many credits worth of hardware is evaporating right now. Easily hundreds of millions.

"Alice, are any pieces likely to make it to the ground?" I ask out loud.

"Major rail gun assemblies and ammunition, reactor vessel." the AI replies.

"Will the reactor be intact?" I ask.

"High probability." the AI replies.

"You're not thinking of retrieving that thing?" Wikowsky asks.

To this I just snicker. "No, I just want to make sure the Xeno's aren't also radioactive."

At this Wikowsky starts giggling. "Then they really would be, well, big green men." to cap it off he giggles some at his own joke and then goes quiet.

“Alice, if possible, please plot the trajectories of the rail gun rounds.” I ask.

Wikowsky looks at me worried. “You afraid they’re going to hit something?”

“We’re not accelerating them, but they’re still 50kg chunks of tungsten coming in at orbital speeds.”

He nods. Alice plots dozens of objects with cones of probability. It makes a nice stripe across the planet, but they’re going to impact places we hadn’t even surveyed.

“Will we see the hits?” he asks.

Alice replies. “Yes. However optical resolution at this altitude is too low to resolve any details. The calculated percent that will hit what Prof. Zeigler refers to as the queens crown is 13%”

“Well, all I can hope for is that we get some lucky shots and a couple more hives get rat fucked.” he laughs.

Alice replies, “I agree. The destruction of more xeno’s would benefit our mission.”

To this I laugh. I’m imaging Alice’s neural matrix attempting to parse ‘rat fucked’ and then concluding it must be positive.

I bring up the specs on the reactor. It’s a big high energy, high output mil grade nuclear reactor. All one big ass self contained unit, just hook up the leads and you’re ready to go. Fueled up at the factory, good for years. I really hope it stays intact.

We continue to watch in silence. At last the show ends. I look over and he's out cold, strapped in.

Chapter 17.

"Forty five minutes until zulu point," Alice says over the general speakers.

This kicks everybody into gear. At zulu point, we will be in an orbital position to use the least fuel to get to the main hab. The last fifteen minutes are the most hectic. Checking of seals, last minute knicknack grabbing and passionate kisses.

At last the doors close. Sitting in the cockpit all I can do is watch as Janice flies. The last act before detaching the armory module was to fill the Cybertech Hab modules tanks with as much fuel as they could take, then detach.

Janice gently backs away from armory module, it's weight now massively reduced we watch as it's small RCS motors fire in rapid pulses. We could only hope it's limited onboard computer could keep it in orbit.

"MCM is orienting for deorbit." Alice says over the comms.

I've tie everybody's comms together.

"Roger that. Green across the board. Semper Fi." Hawkins' voice comes through.

"Come home safe." replies Marco.

The next thirty minutes are rough. Alice and Janice fly the ship together through the storm. I knew that Janice was a qualified pilot, but not on a Cheyenne dropship. Alarms blare to be immediately silenced as Janice flips switches. I hold on. We buck and twist. The engines roar and hum.

On the HUD I see a red triangle pop up, below it reads "DS1." Two sets of numbers give range and altitude and they're both growing smaller distressingly fast. Then the HUD switches and I now see a series of square boxes, Janice is flying through each square. I hear her mutter, “We’re in the chute.” We descend through cloud layers. The ship bucks and bounces as the storms wind sheers hit us from every angle imaginable. The engines gain three octaves and I watch the numbers slow. A dotted line has appeared an a blue square designated “LZ1” highlights.

I look at the radar screen and it’s a dozen shades of red and purple. The ship is pitched forward, then drops like a stone only to be slammed upwards. We pitch over enough she just goes with it and completes a barrel roll instead of trying to fight it. Dropping out of the clouds we see the other drop ship.

"Touch down in twenty seconds." Janice says over the radio. Feathering the engines, she tries to execute a soft landing.

As a parting gift a gust buries the drop ship into the landing gear for last meter. Immediately, Janice throws switches winding the engines down.

Janice lets out a deep breath. "Good on fuel, enough to get back to orbit if we're not too loaded."

"You flew great!" I try my hand a bit of a peep talk.

"Alice saved my ass a couple of times." she snickers.

In our ear pieces we hear Alice through static, "Janice was also vital, as you say, 'saved me ass' as well."

Janice and I both look at each other. "Alice, are you using subspace?" I ask.

"I'm having issues keeping in contact with the drop ship through the subspace module." the AI replies. I let out a deep breath, the fractal of fuck-ups continue.

"How did the MCM fair?" I ask.

"The storm altered its trajectory and it landed approximately one hundred and fifty meters from your present location." Alice replies, now clear as a bell.

"Hurgs calling Wikowsky. You guys alright?" I ask.

"We made it down, we were inverted for a good five minutes and did a half dozen flips at one point, but we landed right side up." he laughs.

"You realize your a football field and a half away, likely near nests." I note.

"Yeah, that has occurred to us. We're sitting quiet and evaluating our options." he replies.

We'd seen that a MCM could stand up against a fair number of Xeno's, but to a point. All the same, getting over there and getting them out of there along with all their gear was going to be a logistics headache. Sitting in the cockpit the rain streams down the canopy as a new round of thunder kicks up.

"This is going to suck." is all Janice says. I open the pouch on my lap and pull out my neural headset. Not nearly as good as the cradle up in orbit, It still gives me functional control of a rocky. Many of the functions that are usually neurally controlled are now are only accessible through a complex controller. Being the oldest of the bunch this was how I'd started out and it fells weird going old school.

"Hurgs to Ziegler. I'm going to bring my rocky online and help unload gear." I say into the comms channel.

"Roger that." is the only reply I get. Riding the freight elevator back up to the surface, I pull my vision out to see Janice has left the cockpit and is coordinating logistics in the main bay. In the cockpit I feel the cool air, smell ozone and the not earthy smells, but Acheron smells. They've dropped the back hatch and are rolling out the sled filled with gear. The sounds of pouring rain and thunder fills the cockpit. The elevator rises from the ground. I realize the design now. Flush against the ground, there's nothing for the Xeno's to dig at. The mountain is some mix of silicon rich granite ore. My lack of sleep is catching up to me as I muse about how hard it must have been to create the shaft, let alone install this elevator. My esteem for these colonists grows. I walk my rocky into the drop ship and gather crates and containers that aren't lashed to the sled. I tilt the optical sensors up and see myself,
it's strange. In a moment of hilarity, I give myself the bird. I dump them into the elevator. Out on this open plain, I feel wildly exposed and a sense of dread starts to fill me.

"How many more loads until we can get under cover?" I ask Janice.

"Three more, why?" she replies.

"Just getting the heeby jeebies, that's all." I reply.

"We've got drones up doing over watch, so far nothing." she replies.

"All the same, I think we should all head down with the next load. I can keep my rocky topside and keep loading." I reply.

"Yes twitchy, I mean sir." replies Roxie.

With the cockpit door open I can hear them talking and I hear a snicker.
Roxie realized at the last second we were on an open channel. Everybody in the group gets a nickname, mine is "twitchy." Like all nicknames, you can't pick your own, it has to be given to you. In my case it was given a dozen missions ago. A deep space station being used as a lab to experiment with Xeno's and something had gone wrong. We were sent in as a clean up crew. Creeping room to room in my rocky, twice I'd blasted holes in shadows. Janice had snickered into the comms, "chill it twitchy" and the name stuck..

Daydreaming again. I look and gear was being piled in the elevator, time to go. I pack up the portable neural kit into it's water proof bag. I run from the back of the drop ship into the driving rain. I feel the mud squelch under my feet. The rain has a metallic taste to it. The air reeks of ozone, Acheron

tones and smells my nose can't categorize. I watch as the back of the drop ship closes up and I realize it's our only way off this rock. The three of us look at each other, we're all soaked to the bone. Roxie has her arms crossed across her chest and turns around. Janice notices that I'm admiring her form through the soaked clothes and gives me a smirk and a wink and then lets me admire. Our complicated relationship and only grown more so over the years. Cyber corps doesn't lend itself to healthy work life balance. More than a couple of times I've had dreams that this will be my last tour and Janice and I will find a little slice of heaven somewhere and make each other happy. She's also hinted at this but the riggers of work always creep into our relationship. Six months ago we'd decided to take a break from each other. We're both complicated and we know it. The doors open and I find myself in an agriculture store room. My physical eyes map the room. The rocky makes you so much taller. I marvel at the farm equipment neatly mothballed that's so much bigger in real like.

"You must be Hurgs!" a familiar voice says. Ziegler strides over and shakes my hand. Again, the perspective of things has been skewed by the size of the rocky in comparison to other things. Ziegler is a decently tall guy, graying at the temples, with a firm handshake.

"Elizabeth, come meet Mr. Hurgs." he says in his rich baritone voice. I immediately sense that he is one of those magnetic people who can command a room and convince people to do things. The hybrid strides over, and extends her hand, I shake it and I can feel the ridges on her palms.

"Thank you for saving us." she says.

"Your welcome, but I recall you helping in that escape as well." I note.

She merely nods and turns to Ziegler, "I'm winning!" she laughs.

"The marines are teaching her poker!" he laughs.

"Yeah, well before you return to taking all their credits, help us unload the elevator please." he points out

She nods heads over to help unload gear.

"I heard on the radio you got a weird feeling topside?" he asks.

"Yeah. It was like I was being watched." I reply.

To this comment he nods.

"You think something is up?" I ask.

"Possibly. Elizabeth has confided in me that this entity has gone on the charm offensive, trying to coax information out of her." he replies.

"Anything we should worry about?" I ask.

"I don't believe so. Elizabeth is a smart girl. She knows that this devourer entity has hostile intentions." he replies. I nod.

The elevator heads back up to the surface for the next load.

"Wikowsky, get your gear and quietly make for the elevator." I say into the comms.

"What's up?" I get as a reply.

"It's too quiet. The faster we get everybody underground the happier I'll be." I reply.

"Roger that, we've been preparing for a fast march. We'd sure love a sled if you can spare it." he replies.

"Pile the gear where a rocky can get it, get your asses to the elevator" I reply. I setup my portable terminal and jack in. I watch as the marines fast march to the elevator. Thirty meters and closing when the attack comes. Boiling out of the nests at a full run dozens of drones stream towards the elevator.

"Contact!" I yell into the comms.

Immediately the MCM's automated point defense weapons open up on the drones as they stream around the MCM. I can see from the drone they've learned to fear these weapons. Tactics at play once again. The drones are more spread out and limited ammo manages to splat a few drones, but the guns are largely ineffective.

"Point defense guns didn't do much. You've got incoming in fifteen seconds!"

I say into the comms.

I immediately bring the rocky's weapons online and begin feeding targets to the weapons computer. Already I can feel my hands beginning to cramp on the controller. Drones are dropping fast but their numbers are just overwhelming. The marines engage with pulse rifles and a dozens more fall.

The elevator begins to rise out of the ground and it occurs to me. They don't care about the us, flush to the ground they can't get in, they want the elevator.

"Get in the elevator and get the hatch closed!" I say.

Out loud I yell "Stop the elevator!!"

"On it!" someone yells back.

The marines begin dumping themselves into the narrow slit of the elevator that's protruded above the ground. The drop ship that's out of fuel opens up on the drones. It's fusillade of fire adds to the volume. An entire swath of drones fall sizzling in the rain, but they still creep forward.

A roar pierces through the storm.

"Close it now!" I say to the marines. I can see that last of them has tumbled into the shaft.
The elevator descends and I see flush doors sliding closed.
A queen with a head like anvil stalks into the clearing. Even at this distance, it's the largest queen I've ever seen. The targeting software reports her at four point five meters. Two sets of massive arms protrude from her abdomen, each ending in curved black talons that are each a half meter long.
Like two gun slingers in the old west there we stand a hundred meters apart. Flanked by dozens of drones the queen looks resplendent. Tilting her head back she lets out a roar that vibrates the rain in the air. The queen steps back, turns and stomps back into the darkness of the driving rainstorm.
I hear cheers go through the comms.

"She fled!" I hear a happy marine say, "We pushed them back!"
To this I take a deep breath, "It was a tactical retreat. Once she saw the doors slide shut on the elevator, she knew it was over. We didn't push them back, she realized it was a pointless waste of resources.

"Which means what?" another unnamed Marine asks into the chat.

Ziegler finishes my thought before I can even say it into the comms.

"They'll be waiting. The moment the armored doors open, they'll be ready to pounce." It was my tactical analysis as well.

"Can't we put sentry guns up then?" Wikowsky asks.

"We could, but they'll just bring so much force we'll run out of ammo." I reply.

"What about the gear that's up there?" he asks.

I see ammo canisters, food packs and other equipment scattered around.

" Is any of this equipment fragile?" I ask.

I have give the marines credit, their shit is tough. I pile their gear on the platform and gave the word, it slides back and then slides closed. Even though Wikowsky didn't have any concerns about the ammo, I still piled it on top of the pile. The idea of a case of forty millimeter grenades breaking open and going off after a hundred and fifty meter fall would be the icing on this shit cake as far as I was concerned.

"All intact," replies Fisher. He'd been tasked with inventorying and organizing all the marines gear. Frankly, I was impressed with what they were all carrying. Each marine had grabbed a spare pulse rifle and a full load out of ammo. It still didn't seem like enough. I put the rocky into sentry mode and take the neural headset off to see both Roxie and Janice staring down at me. This is never good.

"What now?" I ask jokingly.

Both woman look at each other, then look at me, I can see a debate going on who is going to give me the bad news first. I break the stalemate and point at Roxie. "Go." I say.

She takes a breath. "Their printers are beyond trashed. Their large caches of refined metals are only refined in the strictest of terms. Their data systems are at least thirty years out of date, I could go on."

I nod. Fractal shit show, as usual.

I point at Janice. "Sir, we're here taking resources that they feel they're going to need for their future. I don't blame them, but to say that our reception has been friendly would be a major misconception. They also hate Ziegler with a burning passion. I don't blame them in that regard. So I had to cut some deals."

To this I cock my head. "Describe deals?" I ask.

As Janice gets into the details, I felt myself breaking a cold sweat. The colonists are fantastic bargainers and we are at a disadvantage. I call Wikowsky over and the four of us powwow as Janice fills him in on the deal.

"Fuck me. On whose authority did you start making deals to trade classified technology and seats on the ride home?" he asks. The frustration and resignation in voice hangs in the air like smoke.

"You asked me to build you engines, I'm doing what I have to do. We need their cooperation and materials. Even if you were to go in guns blazing, you'd run out of bullets before you ran out of colonists.

"How are they choosing the five that'll go?" I ask.

"It's actually three. Two are spoken for" she replies and points over at Ziegler and Elizabeth.

Roxie swoops in at this point to Janice's defense.

"Honestly, most of the colonists came here eyes open. A few got duped, but the ones I've talked to knew this was a generational operation. They've been cut off for more than twenty years. We're helping them get a leap forward technology wise."

I looked at both of them, "You made it clear our printer is going with us?" I ask.

"Yes sir, we started by pointing out that was not negotiable, but our plan is to get their printers at least to a generation behind ours." Janice replies.

"You all realize we'll likely all get court marshaled for this and end up on some ice hauler."

Wikowsky simply shrugs.

To this, Roxie just laughs. "Sign me up!"

Realizing that there was going back and the die had been cast, he stands up to his full height, looks at the three of us and says, "Carry on." then holds up a finger.

"In the future, please ensure that Hurgs and myself are included in future negotiations."

Turning heal, he strides over to where Elizabeth is clearly winning at cards and sits down to get dealt in.

"You heard him, full throttle ahead." I say.

Chapter 18.

Log Entry #118.

Janice and Roxie have made good progress over the last two weeks, essentially building two new printers and then getting those printers to produce something better than crumbles of dust. Elizabeth has also demonstrated a level of brilliance when working with the CAD models for the engines that has impressed both Roxie and Janice. They've taken her under their wing and the three of them are inseparable. I'm glad to see that they'd stopped seeing her merely as a science experiment but a living creature with emotions. Negotiations with the settlers continue. As the reality that we're actually going to be building engines and attempting to get back to Earth, There's been renewed interest in expanding the pool of people who can return. Already I've seen the plans for what we're going to be doing and it's going to be very bare bones.

Apparently in the stored plans are schematics for a very simple ship. True to form they're taking those plans and making it more complicated with the inclusion of the CRM and the ordnance module. I've kept checking in with Ruvi and Marco. They're bored out of their minds, but generally in good spirits. We continue to have sporadic times where subspace comms get really sketchy. My hypothesis, which Dr. Ziegler shares is that the xeno's are sensitive enough in those bands they've realized we're using them as well and are essentially jamming us. What was an advantage, might likely now be an achillies heel.

End Log Entry #118

Sitting at my makeshift desk, looking at the terminal, the reality is that without the coils, we're fucked. However, the storms have continued to rage outside. Stronger than ever. Sustained winds in the hundred and ninety kilometer per hour with gusts into the two hundred and fifty plus range are common at this point. According to the settlers, we're in the thick of it now and in a couple more weeks it'll start to settle down. On the surface, the jump ships have partially retracted their landing gear to sit lower to the ground and fold up their winds in an effort to make their aerodynamic cross section lower. Thankfully the shape of the rocky makes it pretty tough to tip over, but all the same I've spread the large gripper arms out and pressed them into the mud in a hope to keep the rocky from tipping. We've been using the optics on the CRM module to image the storm, however from space it just appears as if the upper half of the planet is swirling broiling mess. I've looked at the specs for the coils and as long as they haven't been dinged up took much, even sitting in the mud they'll be usable. Part of me wonders if it was bad luck that the guy ended were he did or if he planned it. An open argument has been long brewing if he was going to try to cut a deal with the colonists and use the coils as collateral or if he committed suicide and taking the coils was a final pyrrhic act? A steady stream of inscrutable parts like some insane 3D jigsaw puzzle have been making their way up to our area and piled on pallets. Some

parts are obvious to me, engine bells, piping. Other stuff looks like weird geometric shapes. I've taken to asking Elizabeth what each part does and listening as she gets into the details of hyperspace field coil condensers, field driver harmonic focusers, combustion chambers and fusion stackers. I've asked if she keeps hearing the voices and she nods. I think having something to do helps let her focus on other stuff.

Ziegler for his part has burrowed in like a tick in one of the corners. The colonists leader came up and made it very clear he'd be shot if he left this room. That guy sure knows how to make friends. Once the colonists could see what a rocky could do and the person operating it was in the room, their fears of faceless robots running amok in their settlement are quelled. After all the weeks of clearing nests, it only took a couple of hours to clear the lower levels and labs. Unfortunately, the devourer queen as she'd taken to calling herself wasn't among the dead. I'd openly wondered if the queen we'd seen in the clearing was the devourer. To this hypothesis, Ziegler only shrugged. Cagey as ever, I think he knows more than he's letting on, but seems ambivalent to the whole situation. After clearing the storerooms and lower labs, he asked to have some of his lab equipment moved into our area and had been roughly denied. The security people we spoke with hint that they think he'd let the xeno's loose as a parting shot after being exiled. This sends him into a reclusive funk. He's clearly a genius, but like so many other brilliant men, he's clearly haunted by his own internal demons. Days go by when he doesn't speak to a soul, just bangs away at his terminal. He also seems to have a jealous streak openly lementing that his daughter was spending more time with her new friends then him.

At last, we begin to see the winds subside somewhat. The piles of parts grow ever larger. I watch as the three of them do test fits, bolting sub-assemblies together and testing tolerances.

"Alice, any chance we could get some focused imaging of the site we think that escape pod went down?" I ask.

"Unfortunately, the optical systems are incapable of resolving enough detail to give you more accurate results." the AI replies back.

"Does it at least look the same as before?" I ask.

"No. It appears that the site has been disturbed, however, as noted I lack resolution to determine the cause or give any details about the site." Alice replies.

It's cute that the AI is being really polite about saying "I can't see shit."

I get everybody together, including Ruvi and Marco who've at this point are bored and looking for tasks. I openly ask for ideas. Fisher's XO Erikson proposes that we have Alice or Janice fly one of

the drop ships and get better visuals on the crash site. Upon mentioning it, everybody nods in agreement. As the idea that a topside operation is starting to take shape, the marines start agitating to get involved. Due to Alice having continued interference on the subspace bands and agrees that having a human pilot on board will be prudent. I'm personally not excited at the idea of having one of my chief engineers so exposed. Unfortunately nobody else is even close to being qualified to fly a Cheyenne. The marines see this as an opportunity. If subspace is unreliable, then so are the rockies, so a detachment of marines should go as well, just in case. The snowbal effect is comes into play.

Wikowsky and I agreed that a full detachment is too much, this is just a snatch mission. Get in, get out quick. Six marines, a pilot and as close to a co-pilot as we can get, plus a rocky, nothing more. The next problem is going to be getting to the drop ship. The moment we even warmed up the engines, I'm sure our friends topside are going to try and pounce. Second by second procedures are drawn up and the military planning geekery comes out in full display. Hours of drilling and prepping start.

Jeremy volunteers to go. He argues that he was the only fully trained marine, a semi-trained pilot and a fully trained cybertech in the squad. While is argument is sound, it also makes him one of my more valuable members. He argues that Janice and Roxie are the most valuable since they were building the engines and other components. Once again, I'm faced with a fractal of bad choices. In the end I agree. Janice and Jeremy will go. I pull the big mud encrusted large arms of my rocky out of the mud and advance off the top of the elevator. I can see that the weeks of relentless rain and wind have piled up mud around the drop ships that had hunkered down. This worries me.

“Is there any fear when we start these engines up they’re going to ingest dirt?” I ask.

“We thought of that. We’re going to water flush the inlets before we start.” Janice replies.

“Alright, send up the first load.” I call out.

The seismic sensors in my rocky notice the elevator moving. I miss not being in my cradle, I would have felt it as well. Weeks of my rocky being stationary haven’t been good to the servos or the reactor. I silence a couple maintenance alarms that the articulated joints need cleaning. A quick scan shows the lower half of this rocky is just caked with mud.

“Twenty seconds.” Wikowsky says sitting next to me.

“Roger that.” I reply.

Still nothing. I turn up the gain on the microphones on my rocky and all I hear is just silence. Frankly, it’s eerie as hell.

“Alice, you watching as well?” I ask.

“Currently, subspace radios are operating within limits.” the AI replies.

During the weeks we’d been in our storage room, and wandering the station, Alice and I had talked at length about the strange sub space inference issues. The best we could come up with is that the Xenos have realized we’re using subspace as well and are capable of just jamming it by essentially hissing across broad wavelengths. We talked about strategies to mitigate this, but it would require fundamental reworking of our subspace hardware. The good news is that with Alice in orbit, provided the CRM is directly above us, the time delay is pretty short. We’d had the common sense to turn the radios on the armory module and use it to bounce signals over the horizon. We shift to using UHF instead of subspace to minimize our use. The thinking was the less info we give our enemies the better. Instead we use that subspace bandwidth to listen. With Janice and Roxie occupied, their rocky’s are able to just sit and shift systematically through the subspace bands. While none of it really made any sense to us, we can see odd bursts of traffic.

The elevator rises and on it are two more rockies, each with sentry guns already armed. Walking outwards the guns are placed thirty meters out around the elevator providing covering arches of fire.

“Drop ship two is coming online,” Janice calls over the regular radio.

“Roger that” I reply. Through my rocky I see the ship rise up un-caking itself from the mud.

“Flushing inlets,” she calls out.

I see muck and dirt fly from the front of the drop ship

“Looks good to me,” I reply.

“Drones are up high, nothing on the horizon,” Wikowsky calls out.

With my head in my gear I give him a thumbs up.

“Squad One, topside!” Wikowsky calls out.

I lift my head out of the googles to see Janice nose to nose with me. She kisses me on the lips.

“Come back,” I say quietly. She nods.

In the weeks we’d spent underground, our relationship had rekindled. It was the bright spot in this whole disaster.

Jeremy is standing in the elevator, looking at us he taps his watch. Back to business, she gives me a long stare.

I ping them both through normal data links and open a channel.

“Don’t do anything stupid. This is a recon mission only. No risks!” I say.

She joins the marines as they file into the elevator, decked out in battle rattle.

The doors slide shut, “Engines are spooling up and ready to go,” Janice calls out.

“Movement, twelve o’clock one kilometer out!” Roxie calls out.

Immediately, on my HUD a contact point is highlighted.

“I knew the engines would wake them up,” Janice hisses.

“Movement, one kilometer out six o’clock,” Roxie calls out.

Fuck, behind us. Tactics, more tactics.

“They’re going to pinch us,” Wikowsky snarls.

The elevator that was designed specifically to be unbreakable is now turning into a liability, it’s just taking too long.

“You guys are going to have to run for it.” I say, no one in particular. Everybody is on comms.

We move our rockies out to screen the elevator and make a path to the drop ship.
The rocky going on the mission moves to the back of the drop ship to provide goal keeping duties.

“Why aren’t they running at us?” Wikowsky asks.

“They know we’re bristling, the fuckers are smarter. They’re massing their numbers, we can pick them off ones and twos, but a wall of them, we can’t.” I snarl back.

“Fifteen seconds until the elevator tops out,” Wikowsky calls out.

“Contact, nine o’clock, two hundred meters,” Roxie calls out.

“For fucks sake,” is all Wikowsky says.

The elevator tops out and the marines run for it. The back of the drop ship drops open with a thud, the six marines dive in. I can see that Jeremy has Janice in a firemans carry. I’m glad.

“Engagement!” Roxie yells. Immediately the sentry guns and our rockies unload. Set to kill anything moving within a arc, no AI or humans are needed, the guns do their work.
The rocky backs its way onto the gunship.

“Get off the ground!” I yell.

“Dust off in two seconds!” Janice yells back.

The downwash knocks down two of the sentry guns. The Xeno’s see their opportunity and pounce. We run out of ammo, finally reduced to vibrablades we hack and slash, but it isn’t enough. The drones drag down the rockies and rip them to pieces.

I take off my headset and let out a sigh.

“That could have gone better.” I note.

“We got them safe to the ship.” Wikowsky notes back.

“Yeah, but it cost us three rockies and four sentries. At best a pyrrhic victory. They’ll be making more drones, rockies are a bit harder to come by.”

Wikowsky nods at this. Tactics inside of tactics.

I turn to Roxie, “How easily can those printers churn out rockies” I ask.

To this, she purses her lips, “Quantity, if not quality. The rockies use some rather exotic materials, but I could likely make something close. The problem is the nuclear reactor, printing fissionable’s is dodgy at best.”

“Did the xenos drag off the reactors?” Wikowsky asks.

Looking at the drones we still have flying, no. I look over at our remaining intact rocky.

“Where are the xeno’s now?” I ask Roxie.

“While we were blinded by the crazy storm they were building closer nests. But right now two masses of them are moving back from where they came from.

“It was the engines that drew them in, your rocky was up there for a long time and they didn’t get near it.” Wikowsky points out.

I go over to that rocky and start stripping it down.

“Need a hand?” Wikowsky asks.

I nod. He walks over grabs a drill and starts unscrewing weapons.

In the end it was a non event. Driving the rocky I dumped the wreckage of the three rockies into the elevator and hopped on top of it leaving a couple sentry guns topside.

“Damn, they really went after the soft spots, but otherwise, the critical stuff is intact!” Roxie notes.

Finally a bit of good news.

“So repairable?” I ask.

She merely shrugs. “Not leaking radioactive coolant is a good start.” she laughs.

Chapter 19.

“Left engine is running a bit hot,” Jeremy points out.

The hellacious storms of the last two months have subsided, but that in no way meant it was sunny days. To punctuate this, the drop ship hits a good pocket of turbulence and bucks.

“I’m conserving fuel so I’m keeping it under supersonic,” she says to everybody and nobody in particular.

“You concerned about that engine?” Jeremy asks.

“Yes. We can fly on one if we need to, but it’s still in the black. We flushed for as long as we could, but with the weather we had even with the vents closed, I’m sure some dirt did get in.”

Jeremy rolls his eyes at this.

“Any idea what getting ourselves into?” One of marines asks into the comms channel.

“Nope. I plan on doing a high pass over the whole site with optics on and then we’ll evaluate from there. ETA is forty minutes from now. Get comfy.”

To this Jeremy snickers, half the marines are stretched out asleep.

“Drop ship two, calling CRM, you copy?” Janice says into the radio.

A moment goes by.

“Copy, direct line of sight for twenty minutes then bounce for sixty.”

“What’s the bounce delay?” Jeremy asks.

“A couple hundred milliseconds, not terrible.” Janice replies.

“Hurgs, you copy?” she asks.

“Roger, loud and clear on bounce.” I say.

The next forty minutes feel like three hours.

“Flyover in five minutes. Optics online, transmitting now.”

In deference to Wikowsky I’ve setup my terminal so he can watch as well.

The data flows in in stripes filling in the map.

“Seems like a lot of activity down there.” Wikowsky notes.

I agree.

Jeremy pipes up, “Escape pod in view, torn open, looks empty.”

I scrutinize the video, nothing that looks like drive coils, fuck.

Wikowsky and I have a bit of a mind meld going on, “I don’t see drive coils,” he says.

I nod. “But I do see lots of tracks around the escape pod.” I note.

“It’ll be a shame if they killed that fucker before we get a chance to,” one of the marines says in the chat.

I’m in full agreement. We’ve had time to debate his actions and it’s clear the death of one of the the people in the science module caused him to go bug nuts. The problem is when people crack they don’t do rational things to outside observers. Who knows, maybe he was covering up other misdeeds. In any case the evidence is now atomized in the atmosphere of this forsaken rock.

“Hurgs you reading this?” Janice asks into the channel.

Pulled out of my introspection I look closer at the video. The derelict alien ship is looking decidedly less derelict. Drones are scurrying like ants across the surface.

“Thermals are hotter around the alien ship” Jeremy notes.

I notice Ziegler standing over our shoulder, “Interesting.” he says in a professorial way.

“Yeah, I’m seeing it and not liking it.” I grumble.

“Did give them explicit instructions on how to build an atmospheric processor or did you give them the vague notion of what you wanted?” I ask.

“Again, you can’t really ‘explain’ stuff to them, you can only nudge them. With this last batch of controllers you could convey broad ideas. I think if I had more time I could have helped them evolve much farther” he trails off. He knows this is a sore subject.

“What are you going at?” Wikowsky asks.

I blow my cheeks out in a mannerism I’d picked up from Robinson.

“Atmosphere processors require some serious engineering and shit tons of energy. We know these fuckers are smart, really smart. Smart enough that the queens apparently don’t like them. There’s a ship out there built out of vaguely the same tech *they’re made out of*. Tech they’d readily recognize and likely be able to modify.” I reply.

Wikowsky nods taking this in, I can see him starting to process the situation more fully.

“You’re thinking they took the drive coils to the alien ship?” Ziegler asks.

To this I turn and throw my hands up.

“I don’t see them piled around the escape pod and I see tracks leading from the escape pod towards the alien ship.” I reply.

To this revelation, he merely strokes his chin. Over the radio I hear a tone goes off in the cockpit, then alarms start blaring.

“Engine two, main shaft bearing overheat.” Jeremy calls out.

“Down to one engine. We can bring it back online in a pinch but we’ll need to get on the ground and clean it out.” she says into the channel.

I feel my arm twitch as my blood pressure goes up about ten points.

Next to me Wikowsky mutters, “fuck me” under his breath too low for the mic to pickup.

“How would they even power such a thing, that ships has been there for how long?” he asks.

I sit back and think about that as well. By size, the ship is far smaller than the DeBe. You’d still need shit tons of power.

“Alice. Did you plot the location that the rail gun reactor landed?” I ask.

At this point we’re out of good radio range and I’m resisting turning on the subspace radios so the response takes a couple seconds.

“Yes. It’s highlighted on the map.” replies Alice.

“Since it made landfall, has the site been disturbed?” I ask.

“Unknown. Because of my limited optics it wasn’t prioritized.” Alice replies.

“What are the possibility of getting it imaged?” I ask.

“It landed approximately one hundred and fifty kilometers from the alien crash site.” the AI replies.

To this, I open the channel back up to the drop ship.

“Any chance you guys could make an excursion?” I ask.

“Depends, what’s the destination?” Janice asks.

“Sending data now.” I reply and I upload the map into to Jeremy's station.

“We can do it, but it’ll cut into our margins a bit.” Janice replies.

I look at Wikowsky who is nodding vigorously.

“Roger that. Please take a low pass over that grid section and verify the state of the rail gun reactor.” I ask.

Watching the topo map, I see the drop ship slowly turning right. I’ve seen plenty of drop ship tracks and it’s clear she’s preserving every drop of fuel. It’s also clear the drop ship is handling poorly.

“Negative on reactor core.” I hear over the radio.

Wikowsky shakes his head again turns to the doctor and says, “You had to go make these fuckers smart.”

“Tracks heading towards the ship” Jeremy calls out. I start to think about how many drones it would take to move a reactor like that and all my cybernetics comes back with is, “a lot.”

I’m in dark agreement with him. This changes everything.

I clear my throat. “Abort the mission and get your asses back here.”

“Roger that. It’s going to be tight.” Janice replies.

I bring up the vitals on the ship, she isn’t kidding. They’ll be getting here with ten minutes of fuel remaining.. so we’ll now have two totally unfueled drop ships.

“Please tell me you guys can build something with those printers that’ll create fuel?” I ask.

Roxie looks over at me and nods. “Actually, that’s pretty easy, we’ve got the materials, it was just a matter of priorities.” She replies.

“Consider this a reallocation of priorities then. I’ve now got two entirely empty drop ships.” I point out.

Both Elizabeth and Roxie nod at this and I see them going into a corner and start plotting.

“Where are we going to store the fuel they plan on making?” Wikowsky asks.

“One problem at a time, speaking of which” I say.

Looking at Wikowsky and the other marines. “We’ve got a drop ship coming in pretty hot, I suspect our friends topside will want to give us a welcoming party.” I note.

To this he starts barking orders.

“I’m going to land the drop ship a meter from the elevator” Janice replies.

I don’t love this plan as it’s going to blind us in one direction, but it’s also going to make it much harder for the Xenos to jump us.

“Drones are in the air, so far, things look clear.” Roxie calls out.

We all know this means nothing.

“Sure wish we hadn’t unloaded all the ordnance to save weight on the drop ships.” Wikowsky snickers.

At this I shrug and say, “Physics is a bitch.”

“Drop Ship two to home base we are five minutes out.” Janice calls.

The marines muster up the elevator, but it’s a non event. The xenos, if they’re out there don’t bother.

The two sentry guns that were knocked over are stood back up, in the drones fury at the rockies, they’d been missed. The two guns sweep back in forth. I suspect their batteries will run out before they shoot another xeno. They’ve seen how we operate.

They unload and get back down the elevator, the worst of it is that everybody manages to get soaked.

Janice throws herself down on a cot, “Well, that fucking sucked.” she laughs.

Never were more understated words muttered.

Yeah, that fucking sucked. The xeno's have a nuclear reactor, a self contained mil spec wonder of engineering.

"Any idea how long it'll take them to repair that ship?" Wikowsky asks.

"Let's imagine for a moment they're even successful, it doesn't matter. A week, a year, we're fucked all the same. Without drive coils it's game over." Jeremy laughs.

"Too bad those fancy printers of yours can't print missiles." snorts Wikowsky.

We all turn and look at him.

"Seriously?" he laughs.

"Unguided would be dead easy. Guided would be slightly more complicated," Janice replies.

"Warheads?" Fisher asks.

"Also easy. We're about to start making fuel. Though I have to admit in both cases, the colonists are going to have hard feelings about this," Roxie replies.

I'd been thinking about this. Safely stored explosives are generally safe. Large quantities of fuel and oxidizer, not so much.

"In any case, we need to get Rob involved. We can't go making bombs without telling him."

To this, everybody just nods.

Chapter 20.

Rob rubs his chin thinking it over. “Ha, I knew you guys were crazy, but this is on a whole other level.”

“We figured it was rude of us to just start making bombs and not talk to you guys first,” I laugh.

“Frankly, the management is grateful for the printer upgrades, but less so on how much of our raw materials you’ve managed to use.” he nods back.

Ivan Jacobson was a guy we’d heard about, but never seen. Walking into our storeroom piled with parts and weapons and have disassembled robots, marines, hybrids and worst of all, Ziegler, the sneer on his face spoke volumes.

We’d constructed a long table from pallettes and other equipment. Several of the marines had taken it upon themselves to pull the seats out of the various pieces of farming equipment. Looking at the seats and then us, he plops himself down in one.

“This entire shit show was foisted on me and it just keeps getting worse. I’m grateful that you helped us clean out the lower levels, I’m also grateful for the printer upgrades, granted we haven’t seen anything but rocket engine parts coming out of them, mind you.” he huffs.

Ziegler had filled me in before he made the trek down her that Ivan was somewhat aloof and had been hired by the colonists as a professional administrator. He’d come here with grand plans only to discover things weren’t nearly as rosy as the glossy brochure he’d been shown. He walked into a mess and by all accounts his bureaucratic mind had sorted things out. All the same, he was a guy with a head for spreadsheets and meetings, less suited for dealing with messy off the cuff situations.

“Janice, what is the status on the engines?” I ask.

“Four engines completed, but untested” she replies.

“What’s the hold up?” he asks.

Janice and Roxie who both had dealt with Ivan before explain that we need both the drive coils and the fuel.

“I thought those coils were with some crashed escape pod?” he asks.

Wikowsky decides now to explain how we’d gone to retrieve them to discover that the coils were gone, the ship looked like it was being repaired and they’d dragged a pretty big nuclear reactor to the ship. To be fair he did a good job of just laying out what we’d seen and what of that was speculation.

Sitting in silence, it started with his hands shaking. In that moment he cracks.

“What will Brianna think? Rogers gonna got the hogs!” he muttered. Head in hands, the yell/crying/mumbling/grumbling began.

Roxie at this point eased closer, “Sir, we’re safe here and we’ll figure it out,” she said with a soft voice.

At this his head flies up, “You fuckers did this to all of us!” he howls, pointing his finger at Ziegler and spinning in the chair.

“He’ll feed you to them, you know it! Watch your back with this liar! I know you did it, you let them in here, who else?” he howls.

The accusations, recriminations, crying and grumbling continue.

Sitting there we didn’t really know what to do. We are watching a calm and collected man come apart at the seams, realizing his situation is far more dire than he’d come to understand. At once he stops. Getting up, he straightens his collar and takes a deep breath.

“Build nukes for all I care. It doesn’t matter, everything is lost.” he says with an air of resignation.

At this he walks out the door. His security detail now confused, runs after him.

“Tango Hotel Charlie,” one of the marines asks.

“Yup.” replies Wikowsky.

The rest of us look at Wikowsky.

“Total head case, Nervous breakdown.” Wikowsky replies.

“Think he’ll do something rash?” Roxie asks.

I’d been thinking about this. “Who knows. Let’s get the security guys on the horn. They should at least yank his admin access. No need having him popping all the doors on us.”

To this Janice puts her head in her hands, “Fuck, I hadn’t thought about that.”

“Rob, this is Hurgs. This is any chance Ivan will do something rash?” I ask on the radio.

To this I get no reply. Minutes stretch on as we get nothing back on the radio.

“Rob, this is Hurgs? Copy?” I ask into the radio.

“Copy, this is Rob. Ivan won’t be a problem.” his voice and intonation tells me everything.

“Fuck, I’m sorry” I say.

Through the radio comes a heavy sigh. “Thanks. The council is meeting in a half hour, you’ll probably want to be there.” he says.

“I can do that.” I reply.

“Don’t bring Elizabeth or Ziegler, people are pretty raw and upset right now.” he replies.

Honestly, I hadn’t planned on that. Looking at the lot of us, we looked pretty rough. In a half hour Wikowsky, myself, Roxie and Janice manage to clean up as best as we can.

Chapter 21.

The meeting starts off as shit show and is descends from there. We are roundly blamed for Ivan's death. Our presence and in particular the presence of Ziegler and his pet "monster" are the cause, We're xeno magnets as far as everybody was concerned. Things had been peaceable before we showed up it was argued. I laugh at that and ask how peaceable having xeno's in their facility had been? Rob yells at everybody a couple times, people propose throwing us out to the xeno's on more than a couple of occasions. The accusations that Ziegler had let them loose is thrown about. The council members demanded we give a full accounting of what was going on outside. This was surprising to the four of us.

Ivan had apparently been keeping them in the dark or hadn't known either. This wasn't clear to us. Janice and Roxie explain the nests and the terraforming that was taking place. When the sheer numbers of xeno's is fully realized people begin to freak out. Many people found it preposterous that the xeno's had been terraforming. Thankfully our rockies have been recording petabytes of video at this point. We show them the video along with the evidence of how quickly the planets atmosphere is changing. Wikowsky then tops off the shit sandwich by explaining what we'd seen around the alien ship that includes a slideshow. Alice had helpfully highlighted the dozens and dozens of xeno's. This opens the floodgates at this point. Ivan had been telling everybody that while there were xeno's and they were around the issue was being "handled." The reality that not only were they outnumbered, but that the xeno's were breeding quickly brought about more recriminations and accusations. To pile onto all of this was the revelation that there were smart xeno's as well. These are hardly people who have shown their grit and they were seeing their hard fought planet being given over to aliens. The yelling went to a fever pitch pretty quickly.

The anger that had initially been pointed at us is quickly turned to the council and Ivan. Watching people lose hope in real time is ugly. Hopeless people are dangerous people. Hopeless people will do stupid shit. Then a group of people put their fists in the air, followed by more. I learned later this meant that they'd lost faith in the council. It was a sign that they wanted to call for a vote. Realizing this situation was going to get uglier the lead council woman stood up and raised her hand as well. I'll give her credit, she could speak. She was also a classic politician.

"Fellow settlers, I too am shocked and dismayed by these revelations. Blaming our saviors or insinuating that they are to blame is both foolish and short sighted. Yes, we've got a big xeno problem,

we've tackled big problems before. Yes, Ziegler that fiend is to blame for much of this, however it would appear he once again is both a blessing and a curse. IF what these people say is true, this planet is far more along to becoming a paradise than we anticipated. Yes, we're going to have to deal with this alien scourge, but we've already seen the means to do so. Let our new friends as payment for so generously using our resources help us purge this threat from our planet."

At this point in her speech it dawns on me that we'd be building lots of robots for them. Frankly, it was the obvious logical solution to the problem.

"Let us strike a bargain with our new friends to benefit us all. Many of you I suspect will be quite interested in this, fifty volunteers will be needed to train."

At once more than fifty people step forward. Once again these people are showing that when presented with a problem, they'll tackle it head on.

We were then presented with an ultimatum, help them fight the xeno scourge or get out. To his credit Wikowsky steps forward and drags me with him, I knew the guy could speak, but damn. He thanked the council and the assembled people and said there was no ultimatum needed. Marines don't run, and then promised as the highest ranking colonial marine present that he would designate personal and resources to help train all willing. At this, the meeting went from a bunch of people without purpose, to a meeting where everybody suddenly had a purpose, namely killing xenos.

This was when we were politely kicked out so they could privately discuss matters. Knowing when to walk away is a good skill, we nodded thanked everybody and beat a hasty retreat.

I laugh as we walk back to our store room, "I guess the fact we're not face down in the mud right now is a good sign."

At this Wikowsky shakes his head, "These fuckers literally have no idea how ugly it's going to get."

I agreed with this. "How long until you think they come for this place en mass?" I think out loud.

"How many xeno's do you think are on this planet?" he asks me.

This was a question that had been keeping the cybernetic parts of my brain extra warm at night. The problem was the number I kept coming up with was scary.

"Please be honest. I can see that augmented wiz-kid brain of yours churning." he snorts.

“Okay, based on the data I’ve extrapolated, nest, nest size and density, something north of a two hundred and fifty thousand drones” I reply.

Furrowing his brow and scratching his chin, he looks down and shakes his head at this, “I was guessing fifty thousand, which is still a scary number.”

Walking back, Janice and Roxie start up a private comm channel using just their implants and rope me in. Immediately I can see that the two of them have a half dozen designs already cooked up.

As soon as we enter the storeroom, their designs are uploaded to a terminal and they wave Elizabeth over.

“What’s got those three so stirred up?” asks Fisher.

“Designs for new simpler robots we can mass produce based on the materials we’ve got on hand” I reply.

He walks over and looks at the screen and starts nodding along and giving suggestions. Before long other marines also get involved and a holo pad gets moved to the big table. Ideas are thrown around. Wheels vs treads, autonomous vs remote control, weaponry we could build easily, vs the complicated stuff.

With a knock, the councilwoman appears in our storeroom.

“Getting to the problem at hand I see.” she laughs.

The marines nod. I see her take a look at Elizabeth.

She gestures at both Wikowsky and me, “got a second to talk?” she asked.

“Always” I reply.

We pulled up some makeshift chairs and get talking. She’s clearly one of these no nonsense gets to the business types. When I tell her the huge number of xeno’s I thought were on the planet her eyes go dark.

“I was afraid the number was something like that.” she replies.

I’d been expecting her and already had some canned talking points in my head. I tick off the problems I thinking we had. It all came down to destroying nests. I thought back to Robinson hitting nests from orbit with the rail gun, the guy had been right, and the right thing to have been doing, we should have kept it up. At last she got to our plans to get off the planet. I conceded that while those were still in the works, we weren’t going to be going anywhere until we deal with the problem at hand. I didn’t think the universe was ready for space faring smart xeno’s.

“Couldn’t we just outfit one of these ships you have with missiles and just blast the ship?” she asks.

“We could but we’d likely crack open that nuclear reactor and destroy the jump coils.” I reply.

Janice turns around and comes over, “If only it was that bad.”

The councilwoman cocks her head. “How?” she asks.

Janice puts her hands on her hips. “If they’ve installed those coils and are running any amount of power through them, blowing them up could be very very bad.”

Turning to Wikowsky she says, “You guys call them planet crackers.”

At this Wikowsky turns whiter than a sheet of paper. “Oh shit,” is all he says.

Roxie has now joined the conversation, “Now you understand why we want those coils so bad. I’m fearful these smart xeno’s have no idea what they’re dealing with.”

Learning that the threat is even more dire than she first anticipated, she takes a breath and says,

“I’m going to keep that detail to myself. However, I am going to bang the drum on the number of drones we have to deal with, this will get people good and wound up to fight.” she says.

“Wouldn’t that just scare people?” asks Wikowsky.

“Sure, some Earthers might get scared, we’re made of sterner stuff. We need something that take out nests, fast and hard. Remote controlled would be good so people can feel like they’re doing something.”

We all nod in agreement.

Standing up she nods and says, “I’ll leave you to it.”

Chapter 22.

Six wheels, a camera, a simple unguided rocket with a hyperbaric warhead. Boxy, ugly, functional.

A control room is setup in the hall where the meeting had been held. The first group of people trained to drive the new robots were those who already had qualifications as remote heavy equipment operators. Others were under going training. Chairs were setup against a wall and people spectate.

“Easy does it. Get to the mouth of the nest so the robot is facing down into the nest, then fire,” Roxie coaches the driver.

The camera shows a gaping maw of a cave, the biomechanical nature of the cave is evident. People watching gasp.

“Now good?” the operator asks.

An alarm sounds, the camera has sensed motion.

“Yes!” hoots Roxie.

The operator slams her hand down on the fire button. Switching to the drone view flying above the entrance, the shockwave launches the robot backwards, it tumbles end of end, landing upright. Everybody lets out a cheer. Soon it becomes routine. Days turn into weeks, the printers run nonstop churning out robots, long range drones, warheads and equipment.

Nests are cleared twenty kilometers in each direction from the main habitat. People begin to tentatively venture out with the marines and scout. Seismic sensors and early warning systems are setup. The marines use modified robots to build emplacements. Everybody knows that it’s an if, not when the big attack will come. The xeno’s tactics start to change as well. More and more, the entrances to caves are now blocked. Xeno’s are observed leaving from smaller manhole sized entrances. It is literally a game of wack-a-drone. We change our tactics. Robots are reequipped with downward facing sensors and drills. The xenos respond by creating false tunnels and dead ends. However, it all comes down to heat. The heat plumes give them away. We go after their organic atmospheric processors. We notice that there are less and less nests with them, just more and more drones. Some days we manage to clear twenty nests, other days we strike out. Elizabeth let’s us know that she senses anger, frustration and furious whispering from the devourer. She’s learning more and more to block her out and to tune in on specific groups. One morning I’m awoken to Elizabeth standing over me,

“Something big is happening!” she says.

"What?" I ask.

"A big fight. Two big groups. I can sense it," she says.

That day we observe our first xeno on xeno battle. According to Ziegler and Elizabeth, it's factions three and five. We're to blame according to what the devourer is saying to Elizabeth. We're squeezing their territory and now faction three thinks it can take faction five nests. Marco spots it first and radio's down coordinates. Long range drones launch to get good video of the action and relay it to the control room. Quickly word spreads and every video device in the habitat is watching the fight.

Thousands of xeno's tear into each other, there's at least five queens on each side. A feature of human nature as old as time immortal comes to the foreground as bets start being placed on queens. Quickly names are thought up and each queen is tagged. Sitting in our store room we watch as the queens tear into each other. It's a brutal and ugly fight. In the end faction three is victorious, faction five's drones, fight to the last xeno. As the drone banks around to get a better view of the group of victorious queens I see the display has switched to target mode. It hits me, this drone is armed. A trio of missiles arc out from the drone and slams into the group of queens. The blast wave obliterates the queens and the shockwave flattens drones, causing them to burst at the seams. Through the compound cheers are heard. A bets a bet, but watching xeno's get splatted has become the real past time. There's a leader board with kills on it. A couple of the colonists have become absolutely maniacs. I know this is only going to cause the remaining xeno's to finally realize who their collective enemy truly is. With the improving weather Marco and Ruvi make good use of the limited optics and Alice's computing power to watch for changes on the ground. Xeno's are seen coming and going from the ship, which is now fully dug out.

Two months into our campaign to wipe out the xeno's, Marco radios down.

"Something just changed at the alien craft site!" Immediately imagery is fed down to our terminals.

A large cloud of dust has been thrown out behind the ship.

"Our guess is they gave the engines a test start." Ruvi butts in.

Alice then pips in over UHF as well, "South of you, 100km out, a very large contingent of xenos is marching in your direction. It appears all the nests in that region have emptied out."

Wikowsky orders long range drones into the air, in twenty minutes we begin to see the scope of this force. Counting software puts the count at north of twenty thousand drones. This sends us into full

alert. We've got serious infrastructure above ground, in particular our rocket fuel facility. Everybody thought it safer to have it a hundred meters above us. Along with all of this is our robot facilities, including one of the refurbished printers. This is positioned near the elevator in the event of such an attack, word comes down it's on its way down the elevator.

Joann, the councilwoman strides into our warren. "I hear there's a large contingent of xeno's coming?" she asks.

Jeez, word gets around fast! "Yes. Twenty thousand to the south. ETA at their current pace is in about two hours," I reply.

"A ruse?" she asks.

"Possible," replies Wikowsky

"One hell of a ruse," Ziegler pipes in.

His joining of this conversation clearly pisses off Joann.

"Seismic sensors picking up anything?" I ask.

"The engine test managed to mask the sensors" replies Roxie.

Fuck, I think, this is more coordinated than I thought.

"Get the Cheyenne's off the ground and launch the drones!" I yell.

"Really?" asks Wikowsky.

I tap my head, "Tactics, tactics, tactics." I say.

Nodding, he starts typing.

"Get everybody and everything we can get in the elevator down her ASAP. If it can survive being tossed down, do it!" I say.

The marines jump up and get in the elevator.

I try to ping Alice but all I get is "Subspace link unavailable."

Dumb, deaf and blind and now without my AI.

I switch over to regular radio, I'm getting massive packet loss as well.

"Looks like they figured out we're using regular radio," I laugh.

Elizabeth joins the conversation. "I hear nothing. Just distant whispers," she says.

Joann looks at the hybrid girl with a frown.

I shake my head at Zielger, "You had to make these fuckers smart."

A complaint he's heard endlessly, he shrugs and heads back to his corner.

I rack my brain, what am I missing. Finally I get Ruvi on old school analog UHF. It's spotty and raspy at best.

"We're blind up here. All our data channels are being jammed." Ruvi tells us.

"Same at this end. I wonder if it's the ship, it might have really powerful radio gear?" I muse out loud.

"Everything started with a long haul freighter getting a powerful signal all those years ago," notes Roxie.

"I'll bet they've turned on lots of stuff including all the radios, who knows what else."

"I still argue we should have blow it up when we got the chance." Wikowsky notes.

"I know, peace through superior firepower." laughs Janice.

"Now we risk setting off the coils, however this problem would just takes care of itself," I snicker.

Ruvi listening in laughs, "To be fair, if the coils are fully energized, a teraton explosion would actually fix this entire situation."

Wikowsky just shakes his head. "Just saying we should have, now let's focus on the problem here."

We look at the feeds coming in from the drones. It's even worse. A new force is forming to the west. They're going to try to overwhelm us with numbers. The computers update their estimates to something now north of fifty thousand.

"I thought we were reducing their numbers?" Joann asks.

Janice sits back In her chair, "Sure, and in response they upped production. Give up on atmosphere processors and focus on drones. Plus with Ziegler not giving orders anymore, it's not such a priority for them." she replies.

Joann sits back as well. "Like every war then, production verses attrition," she replies.

"Can't we just hunker down and wait them out?" she asks.

Wikowsky shakes his head. "These aren't mindless drones. You've see it on the monitors, they're smart. They know about this elevator, they must know that you have other entrances as well. Even if it dulls the claws of ten thousand drones, they'll dig until they get to something. Any seam on a surface opening will be chewed at, dug at or they'll sacrifice drones to use the blood to make openings."

I see at once the reality setting in to Joann that maybe having the top job isn't so great.

"What's our options then?" she asks.

"We aren't without defenses in depth. We knew this attack would come eventually," he says. "What about the drones?"

Janice perks up. "The software is configured for hunter killer mode. Once a drone loses contact with us, it starts looking for xenos to kill. Since we sent them south, in about twenty minutes, they'll go on the offensive.

"Armament?" she asks.

Janice nods knowing she'd get these questions. "five hundred ten mil case less high explosive, plus twenty 40mm grenades. The software is wildly good and the ground it's flying over is barren and flat. I expect the drones are doing grim work."

Joann nods, she'd been in and out of the "control room" as people had started calling it.

"So we just wait here until thousands of xeno drones descend on us?" she asks.

"Yes and no." laughs Wikowsky.

To this she looks perplexed.

"We knew this day was coming and the marines have been preparing for it. Well entrenched positions with huge amounts of ammunition, and we know they guys don't love fire."

I'm watching this entire exchange, Wikowsky is in his element. I'd like to think if he lived three thousand years ago, I'd have learned about him in history class. The atmosphere of LV426 is really heavy on carbon dioxide. Power plus water, oxygen and carbon dioxide and presto, rocket fuel. Before long we literally had more of the stuff then we knew what to do with. Realizing the danger of having so much of the stuff in one place, depots of the stuff had been spread out as well as earth works and emplacements that could use the fuel as a weapon. Equipment continued to be shifted down the elevator until it was deemed too dangerous to be on the surface. The last of the robots that couldn't be brought down was loaded up with explosives and send trundling off. At last the elevator was sealed and a heavy concrete lid was pushed over it by one of the robots. Video from cameras connected via hard line was shocking. The drones in autonomous mode had been making strafing runs until their ammo ran out, but it was like shooting fireworks at an avalanche.

"Five kilometers out," one of the marines working a terminal announces.

"Estimated numbers?" Wikowsky asked.

“Too numerous to count. Computers still saying fifty thousands plus. They’re literally shoulder to shoulder out there.” the marine replies.

“A best guess then?” I ask.

“I’d estimate more than fifty thousand.” he laughs.

“Arm the outer edges then,” Wikowsky orders.

I’d been so focused on what I needed to do, I’d only heard snippets of their battle plan.

“Done.” the marine replies.

“What’s your plan?” Joanne asks.

Wikowsky motioned to have Joanne come to the holotable. It has been expensive in terms of materials and printing time, but he’d argued the sensor integration and view of battle had been worth it.

“I don’t know who chose this spot, but it was chosen really well. The ground is made out of whatever this silicon impregnated granite shit is, so they can’t tunnel under us, well at least not easily. Because of Hadley’s chin, to hit this point, they have to focus on us from these to directions.” as he spoke he gestured at the table.

A rumble went through the floor. Joann’s eyes went wide.

“They’ve hit the first defenses.” the marine notes.

“Those would be?” she asks.

“Modeled after a german mine called a Bouncing Betty. Except ours is a large canister of rocket fuel sitting on top of a small charge and delay fuse. After a xeno triggers it, it springs out of the ground and showers everything in a thirty meter radius with flaming jet fuel.”

This explained where all our jet fuel stores had gone when the depots were filled. We’d discussed spreading out the stock even more so we didn’t have a couple of giant tanks. More shocks shutter through the tunnels.

“How many of these things did you plant?” she asks. The concern on her face apparent. On earth, even hundreds of years after conflicts people were still stepping on land mines that had been buried two generations ago.

“Oh, easily hundreds. No worries, we took careful note of where they all are,” he replies.

“Famous last words of every army,” she snickers.

“Well, right now they’re very effectively killing xeno’s,” Wikowsky notes.

On the monitor on the wall, can see that the advance is slowed. The bouncing bombs have the controllers spooked.

“It’s not like them to just break off an attack,” Fisher, one of the marines from the first MCM notes.

“These aren’t stupid xeno’s. The controllers took unexpected losses and are trying to figure it out,” I reply.

In real time, we see the xeno’s form into single file lines and start advancing.

“Clever fuckers. I was hoping we’d kill more of them, but we knew they’d catch on.”

Joann is confused by all this.

“So it didn’t work?” she asks.

“Oh, it worked and it didn’t. They’ve just been presented with a new weapon they’ve never seen and troops were just killed. They figured out it was something in the ground and they’re now adapting with tactics any good commander would employ.”

On the monitor we see a flash as a column leader steps near a bouncing bomb. We see the shadow of several xeno’s wreathed in fire before disappearing entirely. Just as quickly, the xeno’s keep walking forward over the corpses. More explosions come and then we watch as the xeno’s begin to crouch down close to the ground. At once the xeno side steps and continues on head down. The other xeon’s pick up on it and before long the explosions stop.

“And now they’ve figured out the triggers.” Fisher growls.

“Can you detonate them remotely?” Joanne asks.

“Yes, but I’d rather not show our hand quite yet.” Wikowsky replies.

The look on her face makes me think she’s disagrees with this.

At once the screen illuminates as several bunkers pop up and unleash streams of flaming jet fuel.

Entire columns of xeno’s go up in flames, several flee running into the mine field triggering more explosions. Everybody giggles at the chaos.

Joanne nods realizing that maybe this guy might know what he’s doing.

“Release the first salvo.” he says.

“Roger that.” replies a marine.

We feel a vibration shutter through the ground. Wikowsky says, “We printed so many hyperbaric missiles, we staged them in launch canisters.

“Stalin would be proud.” I laugh.

Indeed the canisters look much like the Soviet era racked rocket launchers known as “Stalins pipe organs”

“Literally zero guidance, but with them being shoulder to shoulder, not much needed,” he laughs.

On the holotable dotted arcs appear. It looks impressive but I know the reality. We can kill tens, even hundreds at a time, but there’s just too many of them.

“What I wouldn’t give for a tactical nuke right now” I note.

Wikowsky nods. Joanne looks at both of us horrified.

He waves his hand, “Low yield, literally zero radiation, it would wipe them out in a single shot.”

On the holotable we can see the next phase of the defense denoted as “kill boxes” to trap and kill xeno’s light up.

Joanne inquires and Wikowsky points at Fisher, “those were his idea!”

“Hardly my original idea, but all the same we want to funnel them into places where we can hit them from all sides.”

“This is all just a delaying action though,” I note.

Everybody but Joanne nods.

“What do you mean?” she asks.

“They’ll adapt this this as well.” Wikowsky replies.

Dozens upon dozens of hyperbaric missiles fired in volleys liquidate hundreds of xeno’s. Realizing it’s a race to the finish, the xeno’s surge forward into the teeth of the kill boxes. Turrets pop up and spew 10 mil caseless HE rounds until the mass of numbers overwhelm them and they’re ripped out of the ground.

“Two kilometers now.” Fisher notes.

The ground rumbles more.

“Not us” yells Fisher.

“The ship?” Janice asks.

We all look at each other. I get back on the UHF radio to Marco. It's spotty at best and they're out of position in any case. They're as confused as we are.

The xeno's are now converging on our position. More turrets open up in intersecting arcs of fire but they're less effective. Like all our defenses, they adapt, they overcome.

The UHF radio lights up, "Cheyenne's have found a safe spot and are parked out of the way." Fisher calls out.

We all let out a sigh of relief. As fucked as our position currently is, without drop ships we're entirely fucked.

"Where are they?" I ask.

"Five hundred clicks south, parked on a quiet grassy knoll. Sensors hot and engines on cold stand by to bail if need b," he replies.

My implants do the math, at max speed, twenty three minutes and thirty seconds out.

Marco calls down on analog FM, it appears UHF is now being spotty.

Ruvi's wispy raspy voice calls out, "Alien craft is airborne, I repeat, craft is airborne. Location unknown."

I immediately go to the holotable and link my implants to it and start running scenario's. I've got basic data about the ship's shape and estimated weight. The numbers don't seem to add up. All of my scenario's have the ship crashing on the planet or energizing their coils and attempting to jump in atmosphere, also catastrophic.

Everybody comes over to the table and watches as I demonstrate the full power of my implants and analysis.

"Fuck me, you guys are cool," laughs Wikowsky.

"I'm so cool, all I can show off is how fucked we are," I laugh.

Joanne stands next to me. "What's the most probable?" she asks me.

I nod at her and it simplifies. "Let's imagine they figured out the reactor and the engines are near hundred percent efficient. Best scenario, they manage to reach low orbit, but they'll have trouble maintaining it. That reactor is designed to deliver bursts of power for a rail gun, not sustained power.

They don't know that. I suspect they plugged in and hit the throttles.

"These guys are clever, they figured out the engineering of that ship, the reactor isn't that complicated." replies Janice.

“Maybe they juiced it?” notes Roxie.

“Juiced it?” asks Joanne.

“Those reactors can run at over a hundred percent rated power. It’ll burn out all the relays and the reactor will eventually slag itself, but you can do it.” she notes.

Looking at Joanne’s face, it’s clear she’s not used to how military hardware is designed.

I step in to explain. “You never know when you’ll need shit tons of power short term, in some cases, you just have to go like hell and worry about the consequences later.”

“Okay, so where’s the ship going to come down?” she asks.

To this I just laugh. “I don’t know. This is just a cybertech screwing around on a holotable. We need data.”

“Got it!” yells Fisher.

Immediately the table lights up with a track. It’s even worse. “Well, guess those engines are more like ninety three percent efficient,” I snicker.

“Which means what?” she asks.

I pan the table back to where the planet is now a curve. “Unless something changes, impact will be here.” I note.

The track updates and the impact point changes. “Huh?” people around the table ask.

“They must have realized that reactor isn’t as grand at they thought and they’re mucking with it.” laughs Janice.

“I hope they have luck, at least out into high orbit.” I laugh.

We watch at the track continues to change and improve until Fisher calls out, “They’ve achieved orbit!” Wikowsky laughs, “We noticed.”

Ruvi pops up on the radio. “Visual on the ship, I wish I could send you guys video. It’s rough, really rough. They’re leaking atmosphere, but I’m not sure that matters to xeno’s. Also the lights on the ship keep pulsing on and off. Also, there’s something.”

At this the channel cuts out. We roll through the various channels and get nothing.

“I guess they upped their jamming game.” I note.

“Guys, I know this is interesting, but we’ve got an immediate problem about a hundred meters above us.” Fisher notes.

This brings me back to the present. Too much going on all at the same time. The Xeno's had made it to the elevator, but weren't quite sure what to do. The ground here was too hard to put in any kind of emplacements. Even adding lag bolts had been frustrating. Asking Ziegler, he'd explained they needed to use a high power laser to make the shaft and the tunnels.

Hundreds of drones rip up and smash everything. As a parting gift Fisher detonates the charge under the fuel processor, vaporizing a couple dozen drones. Soon they found the stone and began dragging it from off the top of the elevator shaft, only to be presented with the same impossibly hard material covering the opening.

"Ziegler, can they get into the shaft?" I ask.

"The material is incredibly hard and the gap is perfectly machined, so under ordinary circumstances, I'd say no, but these aren't ordinary circumstances.

"What can they do at this point?" asks Joanne.

Ziegler, despite the clear disdain both him and Joanne have for each other comes over to the holotable.

"They lack the tunneling equipment we have. Their claws aren't strong enough to dig into it. I haven't tested their acid blood against it, but based on it's properties, I'll guess it's rather resistant. Maybe they've got other aces up their sleeves, but I think the answer is to look for other ways in."

"Which are?" I ask.

Joanne manipulates the holotable. "We are here. There's another elevator to the north, but it hasn't been used in a couple years and is likely covered in several meters of dirt. The bigger entrance is to the east, a standard five meter by five meter entrance that leads down to a main junction point. It's a large durasteel door with a plug of this material on the outside, the whole thing weighs nearly a hundred tons and takes more than ten minutes to open."

Wikowsky nods as she goes through her spiel. "How else can they get in? How did they get in before?"

To this, she looks at Ziegler.

He opens in hands, "I'm at fault for that. My experiments got away from me." he replies.

"So what then? We're onto siege warfare then?" asks Roxie.

"Well the xeno's just dug up and destroyed another camera. At this rate we're going to be reduced to whisker camera's." he grumbles.

The plan was starting to form in my head. They knew we're here, but they can't get to us. Blind us and box us in. What's time to xeno's? How long had those eggs sat dormant in that ship? How many planets had Wayland Yutani landed on to discover xeno drones dormant, just waiting. They don't age, they just exist.

I link all our existing whisker cameras together and get a somewhat splotchy cohesive view of what's going on topside. The xeno's are indeed attempting to dig at the elevator but they're not getting anywhere. Others are missing around head down.

"What are those weirdos doing?" Wikowsky asks.

I know immediately. They're "sniffing" around for signals.

"Us being down here must drive them crazy," I laugh.

Elizabeth perks up, "I can sense their anger. They know we're here."

"Is there a queen near by controlling them?" I ask.

"I don't sense one, but there's so much static I can barely make anything out. Why?" she asks.

"Oh, I thought it would be interesting if you decided to try to tell them you were a queen and then command them to attack the other xenos as being on your turf. But I know how you feel about that." I reply.

Ziegler comes over and sits down next to Elizabeth. "We've talked about this idea, but it has its drawbacks." he replies.

"Namely what? We're getting swarmed." I note.

"We might draw more queens and more drones." he replies.

Wikowsky decides to get into the conversation. "What's come of this devowerer bitch?" he asks.

"I think she's the one generating all the noise. It's like being in a room when you guys are standing over the holotable and you start arguing." she replies.

"Loudest person in the room." Roxie laughs.

"I could try using the helmet." she says.

At this we all perk up. "The what?" I ask.

Elizabeth then takes out quite an interesting helmet. Frankly, it looks like the head of a queen. "These crenelations on the edges help focus the energy. I got the idea studying the subspace drivers." she notes.

“Think it’ll work?” I ask.

Janice comes over and helps put the helmet on Elizabeth’s elongated head, “One way to find out.”

The change is immediate. The xeno drones heads all pop up. With video only whisker cameras, I swear I can hear them hissing.

A group breaks off and runs east away from our position.

“What caused that?” I ask.

“I pushed the emotions of danger and I visualized one of the nests. I felt their anger and fear. I’m hoping they think one of their nests is under attack” she replies.

The other drones continue to poke and probe.

Abruptly she takes the helmet off her head.

“She whispered at me. She knows about Ruvi and Marco.”

“How the fuck would she know about that?” snarls Wikowsky. He’s now moving towards Elizabeth with is clearly a snarl growing on his face.

“It’s this devourer bitch. She’s using you to spy on us, isn’t she.” he growls.

“No. it’s not me, I swear,” she pleads.

Elizabeth might be a hybrid that can swing above her weight, but she’s no match for Wikowsky. I can see this going sideways.

“Then how?” he growls. Janice and Roxie are now getting between him and Elizabeth.

“She’s on the ship. I felt it. She can whisper to me, but I’m not that strong to transmit without the helmet. She says she has a helper, a pet, it was weird,” she cries.

Wikowsky steps back. “A pet?”

“Her special worker she called him. It’s thought and words and emotions. Please.” she pleads.

Wikowsky sits back a bit more and looks at me.

I put my head in my hands and let out a low guttural “*fuuucccckkk*” under my breath.

At this everybody stops and looks at me.

“The ship suddenly turning on all its radio’s blinding us? The reactor that magically can work with alien tech? Then in orbit suddenly adjusting it’s power levels? Aliens suddenly understanding space flight and orbital mechanics? The escape pod ripped open, missing drive coils. Elizabeth isn’t the spy.”

“I don’t believe it.” Roxie replies.

“You’re telling me they didn’t kill that traitorous fragging fucking scientist?” Wikowsky asks.

“Yeah. It fits the evidence” I reply.

To this Ziegler joins the conversation, “It does make the most sense honestly.”

“So now what?” Roxie asks.

“I think we try to establish contact.” I reply.

Fisher throws his hands up, “I’m getting Marco on UHF.”

The connection is terrible and fads in and out. The ship is now on the far side of the planet, but it looks like it might be in an intersection course with the CRM. I bring it on the holo table and plot the locations of the alien ship, the CRM and the armory module.

I fill him in on our hypothesis about who might be on the ship and Marco laughs. It’s a flying heap leaking atmosphere and having major power issues as far as they could tell. Even after stabilizing it’s orbit, the CRM module has a spike in radiation, the reactor is likely running full out and starting to leak. The alien ship is now coming back into range and its orbit has decayed a bit, Marco sends down the best pictures they can get with the small two meter scope the CRM has. He isn’t kidding. I’m impressed with whoever built the ship. The fact it managed to get to orbit intact is impressive, but it’s clear it was somewhat of a shaky ride. On the halo table, the tracks correct, sure as shit it’s adjusting to intersect with the CRM, but struggling. He manages to send down a couple seconds of video and we watch as its brilliant white running lights fade and flicker. I try to bring up Alice on UHF but it’s not great. I’m also not excited speaking on an open channel now knowing someone might be listening.

I quickly encode and encrypt a single packet and send it over UHF. It reads, “Climb.”

Watching on the holotable, the lag is horrible but I can see the module starting to slowly increase it’s altitude.

“Looks like it’s going to be a near miss.” Wikowsky says.

I nod.

“What’s the play here?” he asks.

I quickly explain the message I sent. “That module is in far better shape then that ship.” I note. Wikowsky nods back.

At this point Joanne speaks up, “I don’t understand.”

“Tactics,” Roxie replies.

Joanne nods along. It's clear she's a bit out of her depth, but she's a quick learner.

Wikowsky moves over next to Joanne. "Hurgs is employing a tactic best described as 'Dilemmas, not decisions.'"

"Force them to chose between bad options?" Joanne asks.

"Exactly. Now they get to chose. Push their very dodgy ship to climb to the module now or make another pass. What's the plan here?" Wikowsky nudges me.

"Taking it as it comes. Right now hoping they take the bait and burn their engines out," I laugh.

"Won't they fall out of orbit then?" Joanne asks.

"Hard to say what'll happen. I do know them seizing or destroying the CRM would be very bad." I note.

We watch the plots and get sporadic packets from Marco and Alice. He's taken the hint to stop speaking openly on the radio.

Elizabeth lets out a low hiss. We all turn to see a scowl on her face.

"The bitch is suddenly whispering at me again. Her toy, or pet or slave has failed or betrayed her? She's mad at me or at least trying to cuss me out like when I was younger."
Elizabeth dawns the helmet and takes a sharp inhale. She grunts and grits her teeth. With a deep exhale she puts the helmet down. "That should be fun."

"What?" Joanne asks.

"I projected the vision of the ship failing and her pet being at fault. I hinted he was unclean and a traitor. That he was my pet," she laughs.

"Nice." Wikowsky laughs.

In our time on Acheron, I've seen Elizabeth grown from a young girl into what could best be described as a feisty teenager. During that time she'd grown nearly a half meter and put on nearly forty kilos of muscle. I asked Ziegler about what her lifespan might be or when she might come to maturity and he just shrugs. It's clear he loves her, but she's also an experiment, like everything else, I suspect he'd vivisect her in a moment if he thought there might be benefit in it for himself. Though seeing her move gear around, I think he'd have to ambush her at this point. The marines had been sparing with her and teaching her. While unable to hold her own against the bigger marines like Wikowsky, her and I were a pretty even match. I suspect if her and Ziegler ever got into a physical fight, the training plus her biomechanical muscles would make short work of him.

“Think she’s convinced?” I ask.

To this Elizabeth merely shrugs.

“There are other clearer voices I hear when I put the helmet on. Not just emotions but complex conversations.”

This is surprising to me. “I thought this was all sending the essentially emotion engrams via subspace?”

Elizabeth sits down in a chair. “The worker drones are very simple minded. Their minds are a bit of a empty room with a single thought suspended in it. They’re reactive, but essentially their motivations are to do a task until completion. In some cases I’ve sensed drones that are a bit more clever than the rest, but they do what they must for the hive. There’s no fear, only singular purpose. Queens on the other hand are a whole other thing. They’re quite the opposite of single minded, but it’s a maelstrom of competing desires. Expand the hive, keep the hive safe, find more hosts, lay more eggs. Make more workers, But all those urges competing as well as a true loathing for everything not them. They’re larger understanding of the universe is limited. Time isn’t even a concept in their minds. A queen is merely an empire builder of her own small empire.”

“So how does the devourer fit into this?” I ask.

“It’s not a maelstrom but one of cold purpose. She’s an empire builder that understands her empire can scale up. A queen doesn’t get space and hyperspace travel, she does. She doesn’t get the technical details, she’s leaving that to the controllers.” she replies.

“I wondered when the controller’s would fit into this.” I note.

“They’re using the queens as their brood mares. The devourer has become aware of how smart the controller’s are and she hates it, but she needs them, so there’s a bit of a power struggle going on.” As Elizabeth is explaining all of this, I’m watching the holotable. She’s cagey, I’ll give her that. I see the alien ship push it’s engines a bit and then back off, closing the distance, not quite willing to fully commit.

I receive a packet from Marco. “Witnessed debris from left engine during last burn.”
I throw the text up on the holotable. Now the caginess makes more sense. The engines are in rougher shape than I though.

Wikowsky muses out loud that it’s too bad the CRM doesn’t have any external weapons.

Janice looks at Roxie, then both of them look at me. I've seen that look before. It's the same look I give them when a terrible idea is forming.

Joanne is watching all of this. "I know you three have radio's built into your heads. I've lived long enough with scheming colonists to know when a thought is brewing. At this revelation, the rest of the gang gathers around.

Janice speaks first, "We've got the space suits in the airlock and we've got rocky spare parts, including a couple ten mil cannons."

"That would be a really hard shot for the best of our marines to make, let alone, one of you guys, no offense." Wikowsky notes.

Roxie nods and interjects. "Fair enough, but the person only has to hold the gun, Alice has her scope and can do the firing."

To this, Wikowsky rocks back on his heels, "I'm digging it."

Continuing, "Plus, the gun has a standard data port on it, and there's at least two in the air lock."

I can now see where this is going. "Plus with a drum of ammo, we can lay down quite a pattern."

"Exactly" replies Janice.

Wikowsky points out something obvious. "We don't know if that alien ship has offensive weapons. Once we start shooting, they might start shooting back."

I'd looked at the images of the ship and I didn't see anything that looks obviously like a gun port, but then again, the engine ports didn't look like engine ports to me either.

"Good point. Now that Alice has had a good look at the ship, it might be worth seeing what she thinks" replies Roxie.

I write a quick message to Alice and wait. Finally what seem like a long time, I get a reply.

"After collecting more image data, high probability of offense weapons, type, center line rail gun."

Well shit.

"Do you think their hack wiring job has the rail gun even powered up?" Wikowsky asks.

"Would you be willing to risk our ride home though?" asks Ziegler.

"Then you've got to wonder how long it would take for them to wire it up." asks Elizabeth.

"Let alone aim and fire it." replies Roxie.

I could see them all engaging in a dangerous thing, namely wishful thinking. I write Alice another note and wait, the result comes back quickly.

"The ship is using radar in the high gigahertz range for imaging, though sporadically" I note.
"So, more flakey systems." notes Janice.
We look closer at the tracks of the various things in orbit.

"If we can hold out for three orbits, we'd be in a spot where the CRM could climb and meet up with the armory," Elizabeth points out.

To this I shake my head. "I've already been running these sims in my head and it sadly doesn't work unless they blow all their fuel." To emphasize this point, I put the tracks up on the screen.
"In the long run it does work. They could refuel from the armory, but right now in two more orbits the alien ship will be on top of the CRM." replies Janice.

She's not wrong. This is a cat and mouse game, but we don't know what the cat wants to do.

"Or a third option." Ziegler goes over the holotable and starts working the controls. Quickly a serious of new plot lines appear.

Chapter 23.

Ziegler is a genius, granted an evil one, but one none the less.

“I don’t think they’re going to be fooled,” Ruvi writes.

“Don’t jinx it,” replies Roxie.

Over the radio I hear, “I can’t believe the tether snapped!” in Marco’s voice.

“You’ll be okay, The ship is too far away, I’ll grab on you the next orbit. Take some close ups.”

Ruvi laughs. He’s really trying to sell it.

“I don’t know, it seems pretty close,” Marco hams it up.

Turning to the people around the table, “Think they’ll take the bait?” I wonder out loud.

“As long at they play it cool,” replies Ziegler.

“As long at that alien ship can’t detect tight beam” notes Janice.

The plan was a simple as it was elegant. Stick an drum fed rocky weapon into a space suit with the barrel down a leg and the drum in the chest cavity. Then push it out the air lock with a length of snapped tether, then have it transmit on the standard frequencies the chitter chatter as if someone is in the space suit. Then see what the alien ship does.

Worse case we can just have the space suit shoot wildly pushing itself off into space, hoping some of those shots pepper the alien ship and not the CRM.

“Ship changing course,” notes Elizabeth.

Wikowsky high fives Fisher.

“I’m going to give her a kick so I’m in the right spot to pick you up,” Ruvi says over the radio.

“Roger that. I’m saving oxygen, I’ll be here.” laughs Marco.

“Where else would you be?” Laughs Ruvi.

The tracks change as the CRM climbs just a bit. Too much and the ruse would be up.

“Burn complete. Pick up in eighty six minutes, just hang out,” Ruvi laughs.

“I’m glad you’re finding this funny,” replies Marco.

“Alien ship is altering course to incept,” Elizabeth notes.

We watch the tracks at the space between the CRM and the alien ship grows.

“I think they’re going for it!” Wikowsky yells.

“Ruvi, is the ship closer to me?” Marco says over the radio.

“Fucking shit man, I’m sorry, I’ll see if I can go faster!” Ruvi replies.

Immediately the CRM's thrusters kick in and the module climbs.

"You fucker," is all Marco says.

"I'm sorry, mission first." Ruvi replies.

Fisher comes over from his console "Come get a tasty human!" he quips.

Elizabeth gives him a look.

A single packet shows up on my console. "Bingo."

I send it to the holotable and Joanne says, "What the hell does that mean?"

Soon over what little bandwidth we have a video stream starts buffering. It shows the tumbling space suit floating along side the alien ship as a door slides open and a long biomechanical arm reaches out and pulls the suit in and the door slides shut.

Immediately we see piece of ship flying outwards from the vicinity of the door. Out gassing of atmosphere vents from a strip of evenly placed holes along the hull. Then a detonation that blows out a large chunk of the ship. Atmosphere jets from the gaping hole as well several gutted drones and at least one controller tumble.

"Holy shit." Wikowsky yells.

"Well, they won't be picking up any hitchhikers anytime soon," I laugh.

Elizabeth puts her head in her hands. "She's very angry. She's calling me a liar and a cheater." A message pops up on my console, it's from Marco.

I wave everybody over to my console. "Hey guys, our rogue bio tech wants to talk."

"Now he wants to talk." laughs Wikowsky.

"We did just blow a real big hole in the ship he's on," laughs Roxie.

"Alien ship, this is acting commander Wikowsky, state your business." Wikowsky goes into formal military mode.

"You fucking idiots. You've doomed us all," the voice says.

"This is coming from the guy who's decided he's going to get in cahoots with a queen?" I reply back.

"Your simple minds can't comprehend what I've achieved. Where Ziegler failed, I succeeded." the voice replies back.

At this Ziegler steps forward, his ego too fragile to hear he's been upstaged by some bio punk on a colonial marines ship. Knowing he's going to want to say his piece, I unmute his headset and sit back.

"I highly doubt that claim, however, I'm quite interested in your story," Ziegler replies to the obvious challenge.

"I've melded minds with the queen. She speaks to me and I to her. She's perfection in thought and deed. With her I shall achieve immortality and explore the universe," he replies, his voice of reverence and love. I turn to the people in the room and make the screwball motion next to my head, everybody nods.

Elizabeth speaks up, "Shit. He's a devotee. There was a bunch of people like this in the colonies. They hear the queens whispering and become willing supplicants. Though it always ends badly for them."

To this comment, Ziegler starts laughing. We all look at him confused.

"He's a chip head. All the devotees that we had in the colonies all had black market cybernetics." he laughs.

Even as a young man I knew plenty of guys and gals who had gone to back alley surgeons to get augmentations. Like everything else, the amount of money you paid out was directly proportional to what kind of hardware you could get installed. Rich kids went to private hospitals and got near mil grade cybernetics. However, for every rich kid with an air car there are thousands of kids from the slums who will take any advance, including augmentations that might not be perfectly compatible or cause neurological disorders.

"How did a chip head get into the bio corps?" Janice asks.

Wikowsky laughs at this and shakes his head. We all knew the answer. Cronyism and patronage are rife in corps in non combat rolls. You know a guy who knows a guy who can make sure your scans come through clean and what do you know, you ace the entrance exams, the memory augmentation chip sure does help. It's even whispered quietly that augmentations were something they'll be giving everybody. The cybercorps was a first test to see how well it worked. Guinea pigs to get the kinks ironed out of the hardware.

"What's not clear to me is how he didn't end up a host?" asks Elizabeth.

To this the marines all turn and look at her. In this situation surrounded by bog standard humans her biomechanicalism stands out. “Look, I’m not blind to my complicated biology. I’m neither you or them, but something other. I’m just stating the fact that every person who has gone running into a nest yelling their devotions to a queen, doesn’t *actually* end up being a queens consort.”

It was left unsaid what the rest of that sentence ended with what everybody *knew.*

Ziegler nods to this, “It points to him not being special as much as this queen being special.”

I nod with him, “Yeah, what he has is knowledge. They seem to have the biomechanical stuff figured out, but they found themselves with some alien tech and needed a humans help.”

I open the channel back up, “Okay, spell it out for me. You helped this queen hook up a pretty large nuclear reactor to that ancient ships engines so you could escape? I don’t get it, didn’t these guys kill your girl?”

To this there’s a pause over the radio. “She’s not a mindless killer. She has plans inside of plans. Her and the wise ones, with my help will purify the universe.”

“You’re talking to her? Not just feelings and emotions?” Ziegler asks.

“She sings to me, we talk for hours.” he replies.

The looks on everybody’s faces clarified what we were dealing with here.

“Wise ones?” Jeremy asks.

“The controllers.” Elizabeth replies.

“So I thought the controllers and the queens hated each other?” asks Jeremy.

Elizabeth cocks her long biomechanical head at him, “She’s a younger different queen. With the helmet on I can perceive a bit more about her. She’s a queen from the tribe of the controllers.”

“This changes everything!” shouts Ziegler. We watch at Ziegler starts freaking out. Honestly, the guy is calm when all kinds of crazy shit is going down, so him freaking out causes all of us to take pause.

“Tribe of controllers? What?” he shouts at Elizabeth.

“Tribe of them, tribe of. It’s what they’re saying. They’re a collective.” she shrugs back. Seeing her not even flinch at him going bonkers is impressive.

“Tribe, you mean hive. They’re a hive. They created a queen with the intelligence of a controller.” he shouts.

“Well, shit on a stick. You really did fuck us, didn’t you.” laughs Wikowsky.

“The controllers are a focused strain. Their XNA is entirely focused on enhancing their intelligence, nothing more. I suppressed everything else. I never created another royal.” huffs Ziegler. He’s now pacing the floor.

“A what?” Joanne asks.

Elizabeth speaks up. “Queen XNA. It is and I guess I should say how my XNA/DNA are different. To create a queen you need a royal egg. From that larval stage the resulting entity grows into a queen.”

“Larval stage? Jesus Christ.” mutters Fisher.

“What do you want me to say here? The life cycle is the life cycle. Horrible as it may look to others, it’s how I was partially created.” With those words she sits down. Everybody just stops. We’ve all seen the aftermath and horror of the xenomorph life cycle. The reality that a creature, walking and talking sitting among us. Holsters are clutched. Eyes go wide.

“This is true? How, who?” snarls Joanne. Pointing her finger at Ziegler.

Ziegler now has returned to his composure. “Yes, she’s a hybrid born of my DNA, royal XNA and Cynthia’s DNA.”

Before anybody can stop her, Joanne’s over the holotable and pouncing on Ziegler, her voice now a screeching howl.

“Your own fucking wife!” she slams her fist into his face.
Ziegler tries to block the blows but she’s driven by fury. She manages to land a few more before the marines wrestler her off of him.

Holding his bloody nose, “Yes, my fucking wife. She was dying of cancer on this god forsaken rock. No, I didn’t happen like that as well. Jesus!”

Wikowsky pulls up a chair. “I think it’s time you sit down and tell us all how it happened then.”

Realizing that he was surrounded by trained killers as well as those capable of killing, he takes a seat. The marines let go of Joanne but give her the *don’t try shit* look.

“We don’t have time for the full story, we’ve got to deal with the alien ship.” he huffs.

“Then give us the short version.” snarls Wikowsky.

Letting out a breath, he rubs his nose. “Fine. We cleaned out a nest, killed a queen and found a royal egg. We then extracted it’s XNA, and mixed with with my DNA and my wife’s DNA and tried produce a viable zygote. Something that could bridge the gap. It took years of experimentation. A

dozen different failures until we produced Elizabeth and her sibling. Elizabeth was born via c-section, her mother dying of cancer." Those last words ringing in the room.

At this Joanne puts her hand on Elizabeth's shoulder. "This makes me your aunt I guess."

With that it's clear now why Joanne wanted to smash his face.

Janice looks at everybody, "We done here? Because shit's going down."

Everybody returns to the holotable, though Ziegler has put himself about as far from Joanne as he can.

Zooming in on a grainy still, "We clearly fucked up their ship. It's losing altitude, albeit slowly."

"If they had enough power could they jump?" asks Fisher.

"Maybe they can now? In two more orbits they'll be too low." Joanne plays with the controls and a a half sphere of the planet with the alien ship and a terminus line below it.

"What happens if they try to jump below that?" asks Wikowsky.

Joanne nods at Wikowsky. "Who knows how that ship works. Our engines energize the coils in sequence. So if they 'spin up' or go 'prompt' as it's called. In any case, ramming into atmosphere at some percentage of the speed of light is very bad."

"Fuck." is all I can say to this. The very bad is a very big explosion which may or may not cause the coils to go kaboom. Everybody nods with me.

I pick up the mic. "Alien ship. Please state your intentions. We're fearful your attempt to superluminal flight might be catastrophic."

"Your distractions can't stop us from our goal of a pure universe. This ship is far beyond anything that mankind has ever created. The creators left it for us to find and to use. We will." is as far as he gets before I mute.

"Bat shit crazy." I mutter.

Elizabeth takes off the helmet and looks at un and frowns. "They're going to try it."

I unmute the channel. "The glory of the universe will be ours!" I hear over the radio.

"That ship is going to fly apart when you try to go superluminal if you're lucky. If you're we're not lucky, it's going to slam into the atmosphere and explode taking half the planet with it." I say into the radio.

"You are the unbelievers that must be cleansed." he says before the channel closes.

Our holotable suddenly updates in real time.

“Holy shit, we’ve got sublight!” yells Fisher.

“Alice, are you appraised of the situation?” I ask.

“Yes. Your advice is sound. I am as you would say, ‘burning like hell’ to catch up to the armory, mate with it and use it as shielding.” We watch at the rather small engines on the CRM burn, their fuel and oxidizer go into the red. Finally, the numbers stop.

The looks on Janice and Roxie’s face go sourer and they both let out a breath.

The video of the alien ship is now quite clear, we can see the aft section of the ship beginning to glow as it charges up the coils.

“Alice, how long can they run that reactor at that power level?” I ask.

“The state of the reactor is unknown, but likely enough to energize the coils for a single jump.” the AI replies.

We watch as the gap between the ships widens. The alien ship fires it’s engines, the right most sputters and restarts.

“Now oddly, I want them to succeed,” I laugh.

Everybody nods with me.

At once the ship is gone.

“Holy shit! Holy shit! Holy shit!” Ruvi yells into the radio.

The ship cameras pivot to show an expanding gas cloud.

“Alice? How far out did they get?”

“Approximately .75 AU before complete failure.”

Immediately the cybernetic elements of my brain go into overdrive. Eighteen minutes before the outer shockwave hits them with lots of plasma and lots of hard radiation. Ruvi’s response had been right on.

“Can they get behind the planet?” Janice asks.

Roxie has her head in her hands.

On the holotable, the plot lines and the expanding ball of superheated gas that was the alien ship are all in full display. The CRM and the armory module are on a convergence point fifteen minutes out. Three minutes. To dock, to equalize, to get cover.

“What’s the plan up there?” I ask.

“The module and it’s dense ordnance should provide sufficient protection against the radiation.” Alice replies.

“What about us?” Joanne asks.

Ziegler speaks up and waves his hand, “We’re under a couple hundred meters of very dense rock. We’ll be fine.”

All we can do now is watch and provide impotent suggestions. Now that we have subspace, I get on the radio and ping the module and query it’s internal temps and pressures. The pressure is low by a bit and it’s cold, but survivable. I link to the table and start running the numbers. It’s a teraton explosion, that much I know. I wash the variable through my cranial computers a couple times. They’re going to take a massive dose of radiation, even in the armory.

Alice docks perfectly and just blows the seals. Both of them on camera have their mouths open and heads back to equalize the pressure. I look at the timer, two minutes and thirty seconds.

Marco floats into the armory hand over hand and starts going at one of the mark 37 weapons. Panels come off. Genius, I realize. He’s going to use weapons dense shielding for Alice.
He looks at the camera, “Alice is going offline!”

We watch as Ruvi slides open the main computer dock and pulls the lattice cube.

Alarms start blaring. Radiation alarms. The lights flicker in the modules. “Take it!” we hear as Ruvi tosses the cube through the open door. Marco snatches it out of the air and stashes it in the mark 37 and tapes the panel on.

“Get your ass in here!” we hear him yell. We watch has he squeezes himself under the large weapon. Ruvi is making his way towards the hatch. “Oh fuck.” is all Ruvi says.

We watch on the holotable as the shockwave of hard radiation and plasma hit the CRM. More alarms start blaring. The radiation causes the cameras to go offline, their sensors overwhelmed with gamma particles. Then it’s over.

Roxie is first on the radio, “What’s going on?” the edge her voice says everything.

Marco responds first. “I taste metal. Let me find Ruvi.” He opens the compartment and takes the cube out. “I think Alice is okay.” he says.

The cameras come back online, though it’s clear they’ve all taken damage from the radiation.

Working the cameras, we find Ruvi, he’s pinned up above the display. His skin is a dozen different colors. “Oh no,” is all Marco says.

Marco moves Ruvi down and into one of the cradles and hooks leads up to him.

“That could have gone better,” Ruvi whispers.

“Yeah, we got pretty fucked,” he replies.

We see Marco put the cube back into the cradle and slide the door shut.

“Alice should be online in a few,” he says to nobody in particular.

Marco climbs into his cradle and hooks the medical cuff up to himself.

Alice comes back online. “Processing systems 96 percent online. Minor ship damage. Extreme radiation event detected.”

Vitals start flowing into our terminals. It’s bad. Marco was able to mitigate the worst of the rads but Ruvi took the full hit. The auto-doc is estimating three hours at most. The system prompts me to authorize it to go into hospice mode. I punch in my override and press my thumb to the biometric sensor. Marco is in slightly better shape. The auto-doc is pumping him with a cocktail of meds. It’s still filtering his blood, prognosis unknown.

Roxie is in the corner with a comm unit. We all give her space. Janice hugs me and cries.

We watch as the radiation wave ripples across the planet. The upper atmosphere turns a dozen colors as the plasma ripples against it.

“Holy shit guys, look at this!” Fisher yells from another console.

We look at the monitor and see xenos on the ground convulsing and dying. I wonder out loud how many xenos were out in the open. We only have a couple of the whisker cameras left.

Elizabeth puts on her helmet. “It’s very quiet. Many xeno’s and queens died today.” She takes it off and sets it down. It’s clear this is complicated to her. The marines recognize this, but all the same I see a couple pats and fist bumps. With nothing more to say, everybody goes back to their tasks.

Wikowsky gets a couple marines organizing. I get on the comms and check on our two Cheyenne’s. They check out okay. Our quickly printed drones and robots all got cooked, they weren’t mil hardened. I task Janice and Elizabeth with getting some air assets printed and flying. They both nod solemnly.

“Is the surface now radioactive?” asks Joanne.

“In spots possibly, neutron flux can make certain metals become radioactive. Everybody is going to need to wear gieger counters going forward, just in case we hit any hot spots.” I note.

Chapter 24.

Ruvi passes quietly a couple hours later. Apparently his last words to Roxie was “Be safe my love.”

Janice, Roxie and Elizabeth have been in a huddle for a while. I give them a wide berth. Processing grief is hard. I get on the comms to Marco. He’s doing better, though the auto-doc is warning him that he’ll need to be on meds indefinitely. I encourage him to take another twelve hours in the pod and let the auto-doc keep filtering his blood. He agrees, but only after taking care of Ruvi.

Moving him into the airlock, he’s retrieved a body bag and wrapped him tightly in it. Wikowsky at once starts barking orders surprising everybody.

“Marines at the ready!” he shouts. At once the remaining small group of marines line up. Confused he shouts at me. “On the ready line!” I join the line. Roxie’s face is tear streaked.

“We commit Colonial Marine Cybertech second class Ruvi Bera to the universe. His sacrifice will not be forgotten!”

From the speakers on the terminals taps plays. At once the holotable shows video of airlock. The outer door pops open and Ruvi’s body glides into space.

Wikowsky then does something I didn’t expect him to do. He marches up to Roxie and gives her a bear hug and says, “I’m sorry for your loss. I was honored to serve with him.”
Roxie manages a “Thank you.” and a sniff.

Janice pulls me close. “Hey, you okay?” she asks. I nod. This whole enterprise is risky business.

“I guess you and I are going to make something of it here?” I ask. I realize as the words come out of my mouth that the timing is poor. To this, she cocks an eyebrow, “We want to show you something.”

We gather around the holotable.

Janice brings up an overview of the planet. “We launched long range drones a couple hours ago, loaded up with optics and radiological detectors. More out of morbid curiosity than anything else, we wanted to fly over where the alien ship was.” At this she zooms in the map and we can see the clear where the ship and torn a huge furrow in the ground taking off.

“So far there’s the usual hot spots that we were expecting from such a huge blast, but not here.” and she points at the map. “These are different.” The map zooms in on two hot spots. “Nothing on this planet could possibly shine that brightly, but drive coils.” she notes.

“They look deep underground.” Wikowsky points out, zooming the map in closer.

“Yeah, we’d have never found them if that not for that explosion emitting such a strong neutron pulse.” Janice notes finally. Roxie just stands there solemnly.

My cybernetic brain does the math, “Twelve years of travel time.”

“Fuck.” is all Wikowsky says. We agree.

“Get the coils, get to orbit, build a ship out of parts, hope like hell we don’t end up like those jackasses. What could possibly go wrong!” I laugh.

With a renewed sense of purpose, everybody gets to work.

“This is going to be gross.” Janice mutters as we ascend in the elevator. We’ve got our pulse rifles cocked and ready.

“Just thirty centimeters so we can see.” I say. She nods. The top of the elevator slides back, we both heard a thud and then nothing. We stop at thirty and look out. There are dozens of xeno’s dead in heaps.

“Fuck me.” a Marine behind me says. I can hear him kissing some medallion.

“Short controlled bursts.” Fisher says quietly. We’d rigged up a simulator using my neural goggles so the three of us with not nearly enough weapons training could get a feel for how it felt to handle a pulse rifle. Still the thing is heavy.

“Cheyenne one incoming, time to arrive, thirty seconds.” Wikowsky says over the radio.

We bring the elevator up to full height and look around. Sprawled on the ground, the dead xeno’s still look menacing.

“I hate all of this,” one of the other marines mutters, I can’t disagree.

We look for movement but see nothing. The whine of the engines announces the Cheyenne’s arrival. We move in tactical formation towards the open ramp. The Cheyenne takes off with a jolt and we’re airborne. Janice and I move up into the cockpit. Both our Geiger counters click a bit.

“Fuels good. I suspect all this metal and ceramics are a bit radioactive.” she says. All I can do is shrug. It’s not like we have any other options.

“Flying okay?” I ask.

To this she merely shrugs. “This one has the two functioning engines, so we’ve got that going for us.”

We fly on into the morning twilight, the upper atmosphere still streaked from the explosion.

I point at the colors, Janice replies, “Heavy metals and nucleotides.”

“Dangerous?” I ask.

“Maybe? That’s the first teraton explosion in nearly a century not under controlled circumstances.” she laughs.

The morning light shows the destruction the ship made taking off. As Janice makes a couple passes over the site, I measure the massive furrow in the ground. Five hundred and sixty meters before they got airborne. No wonder they were leaking atmosphere. Behind the furrow, the ground the engines have turned large swaths of the ground into what looks like shattered volcanic basalt.

Over the radio we have Roxie’s voice,

“Scans show nothing. Anything here got blasted to hell when that ship took off.” We all know better. Even with all the radiation, we know how tough xeno’s are. In my head my trainers words keep ringing, ‘Assume it’s a trap, be pleasantly surprised when it’s not.’ That, ‘This is a bad idea’ feeling keeps creeping up.

“You okay?” Janice asks.

“No. I’m getting the willies.” I reply. At this she frowns. While it’s true that I can be twitchy, my instincts are also good.

“Get those coils and get the fuck out of there.” Roxie’s voice comes over our comms.

With the return of subspace it was much easier for us to link up, along with all the bandwidth came some of the internal emotions as well.

Landing on the blasted ground, the back of the Cheyenne drops with a crunch. Not only is the ground been literally boiled into glass, it’s been shattered. Before us is a razor sharp jumble hellscape. As if on cue a harsh wind blows across the plain, all of our Geiger counters spike. Grit hits our face.

“Goggles and breathers on,” I say into the channel.

“This just keeps getting better,” one of the marines laughs. I’ve come to known this woman. Her name is Talia Benko. Below rank to Fisher I can see why the two of them are thick at thieves. Smart, capable and witty, I’m glad she’s on the mission. Fisher has confided in me that Wikowsky is likely to give her a field promotion at some point.

“We get the coils and get the fuck out.” I reply.

To that I get a bunch of nods.

“About seventy five yards over and about fifteen down if this thing is right.” Janice reads the display.

“Why didn’t we land closer?” the Benko asks.

“Too unstable. Too many subterranean pockets.” she replies.

She just shakes her head.

“One of which has the coils?” asks another Marine.

Janice nods, head down looking at the display.

The marines form a moving parameter, weapons up facing outwards.

“Here,” Janice announces.

I come forward with one of the salvaged robots equipped with a drill.

“Get up wind of this,” I announce.

The robot squats and its drill kicks in. Atomized glass like smoke sprays from under the robot. I check and everybody still has their googles and face masks.

“Movement, 12’clock!” a marine yells.

In the distance we see a four xenos rise from the ground slowly. One has deep scars across it’s head. Another is missing an arm entirely. It’s clear the ship took off with out much care in the world for them or their safety.

“They’re not looking too hot.” Janice notes.

“But they likely *are hot.”* I laugh. At this Janice shoots me glance.

“Fair game all the same.” Benko notes and drops the xeno with a head shot.

Fisher nods as well and picks his targets. Two more drop. The last is dropped by the quietest of the group. Woolnick is his last name buy everybody calls him “Wooly”. The trio keep scanning outwards looking for more movement, but in the blowing dust, nothing.

The pitch of the robots drill suddenly changes and the ground shifts under our feet.

“Holy Shi—” is all I get out before we drop, onto a heap of desiccated xeno’s and broken glass. Their exoskeletons crumble under us, filling the air with a mist of powdered xeno.

“Comms check. Sound off.” Wikowsky says into our ears.

A chorus of voices fill my ears.

“What a nasty way to break a fall,” Fisher says.

“The ship must have boiled them alive even in this nest.” Janice says as she climbs out of the heap.

I hate all of this. My sense of dread has gone from a nagging in the back of my mind to something I can physically feel. Under the body armor I can feel the sweat trickle and every hair I have standing on end.

I whisper into the comm channel that just Janice and I have going, “I fucking hate all of this.”

Back at me I just get an acknowledgment. I can feel her dread as well.

“Coils?” I whisper into the general chat.

“According to the sensors five meters that way” as Janice gestures with her hand pointing to an antechamber.

Now we’ve fully formed back into a fire team, pulse rifles pointing out in every direction.

In the darkness our eyes adjust. We see the glow of the coils. They’ve been cemented into the wall with the alien resin. A special room has been created just for them. We creep into the room with Wooly covering our “six.”

“Quietly.” I whisper into the channel.

Fisher nods his head and steps forward.

From the walls, the massive hands of the queen snap closed on Fishers head and torso in one clean motion tears his head off. The Queens head breaks loose from the resin in the wall and snarls. We at once unleash on the queen. We realize that the wall, coils and the queen are a single thing. The floor around us shifts as her massive articulated tails begins to uncoil. Even weakened by the radiation she’s still a formidable foe.

“Back up and bottle neck her in the door!” Wikowsky yells into our ears.

We provide a wall of rippling fire as we back into the main room our backs now up against the the heap of dead powdery xeno’s.

“Careful of the coils!” Janice yells into the comm channel.

The Queen busts through the wall using her massive head like a battering ram. The four of us unload at point blank range into her head and she drops face first in front of us, her arms splayed out on either side of us ready to give us all the death hug she gave Fisher.

Benko, now our lead marine kicks the queen in the head and her massive dome shatters. We can see her large yellow brain spotted with black tumors.

Janice and I undertake the grizzly task of digging the coils out of her abdomen. We encounter little blood if any. The coils are a little rough for wear but Janice looks each of them over and gives me a thumbs up. We load them into our backpacks. I immediately feel the extra thirty kilos.

“We’re alive because she was on the verge of death.” I note.

Benko retrieves Fisher’s tags. “Not fair to come this far and to die like that,” she says.

I agree.

The other two marines speak up in the channel. “Motion ahead, but slow.” they note.

“More sickly xeno’s I imagine” Miller says.

“Still dangerous and we’re still ten meters into a hole.” Janice notes. As she says this she unpacks a triangular drone from her backpack and tosses it into the air. The drones lasers start mapping the walls. Immediately the rough data starts flowing into my neuralinks.

“Let’s find a way out.” she whispers.

Benko distributes Fisher’s spare mags and grenades among the group.

The drone flies ahead and we discover more sickly xeno’s crawling in our direction. A group of five. One tries to swat the drone but feebly misses.

We meet and it’s over quick. We conserve ammo and drop them in rapid succession.

The concussion of the pulse rifles causes the tunnel to shift around us.

Looking them over, their bodies are covered in deep lesions.

“The ship must have walloped them with hard radiation taking off.” Benko notes.

Janice nods, “Yeah, they weren’t out on open ground and this deep they would have been somewhat protected.

“I’ll fucking take it.” I laugh.

Behind us we hear a section of the tunnel shift and collapse. This spurs us to haul ass. We can see light ahead. Bursting out of the mouth of the tunnel we find ourselves in the midst of dying xeno’s flushed out of another tunnels as it collapsed.

“Alice!” I yell into the comms.

“Pick up in twenty seconds.” she calls back.

We can hear the engines of the Cheyenne cycle up.

“You can’t land, everything around here is too unstable.”

“Roger that. I’ll drop the ramp and go into hover mode.

The xeno's scrabble up as Miller, Janice, Wolly and myself fire outwards.

We hear noises from behind us in the tunnel entrance.

Benko fires a grenade down the entrance. We all flee away from the entrance as the drop ship swoops over our heads. Behind us the ground buckles as the grenade causes cascade failure of tunnel system.

Alice flies the dropship backwards and scoops us up as the ground disappears under our feet. Benko stands on the back of the ramp and fires three more grenades into the dust cloud below us. We look at her and she says, "For Fisher."

Janice gets to the controls and we climb, though it's not sounding great.

She calls back on the radio, "It can't be avoided by the engines sucked in some of that volcanic like glass. It's going to be a rough ride."

I climb into the cockpit to see an impressive number of red lights.

"Can't we flush them with water?" I ask.

"Not while flying," she says through gritted teeth.

"Alice, give me some options!" I say.

Immediately the HUDs in the cockpit start showing possible landing locations. We need to keep this ship flying for at least an hour to get back to Hadley's chin.

"Twenty minutes out, climb now and glide." Alice calls back.

"Buckle up!" Janice yells and she fires the afterburners putting us into a steep climb and then nothing.

"Both engines are shut down and vents closed," Janice announces.

We coast in silence. It's unsettling. Dropships are supposed to make noise. Without it, the creaks and groans of the airframe are audible. In the distance we can see an escarpment of rock. I watch as the numbers go down steadily. Finally Janice flips the engines nacelle's around and we fire a single burst to touch down.

Everybody climbs up and start opening panels. Janice immediately shares with me all the maintenance manuals.

She commands the ship to flush the engines from the onboard water stores. Steam and sand shoot from the VTOL nozzles. Opening a panel she pulls out a dipstick and looks at it.

"Here's our problem" she notes showing me the stick. I can see black spots on it.

Pulling out an oil filter, it's absolutely clogged. She starts banging it on the edge of the engine cowling and a thick tar like junk starts dripping out. At this I start laughing. Here we are thirty nine light years from earth and we're banging sand out of an oil filter. I help out and we clean the other three filters. "Will we make it back to base?" I ask.

To this she turns and kisses me. I pull her into a hug and kiss back. She smiles. "Just in case we don't."

Powering up the pumps we cycle the oil a couple of times through all the bearings and start the engines. Still a cockpit full of angry red lights, but that can't be helped.

The flight back is a nervous one. At any second I just expect both engines to fail catastrophically and the ship to auger into the ground. I made it a point of quickly reviewing the cheyenne's ejection seat manual. Leaving Janice and Alice to doing the flying, I start to contemplate about how many healthy xeno's there's still on Acheron. Running some simulations, I think we've culled the populated by something north of forty percent. That still leaves thousands of the little shits, but they're on the far side of the planet hundreds of km away.

We land to Wikowsky, Elizabeth Roxie standing at the elevator.

J anice and I put the backpacks down. "Two superluminal tachyon jump coils."

Wikowsky pats me on the shoulder, "Great job. Sorry you lost Fisher, he was a good marine."

"The whole op went tits up on landing. We did what we had to do." I reply.

"How's everybody holding up?" I ask.

"Parts are coming of the printers. Apparently we're all going to get to help do a couple engine overhauls. Roxie is busy building another fuel and oxy plant." Wikowsky laughs.

Clean shaven and showered, I fall onto my cot and into a deep sleep.

Chapter 25.

I'm sure if a *real* Cheyenne power plant technician was here, he'd be aghast at our field repairs. These ships are hardy and designed to be field patched, not so much *torn down.* To tear down a power plant you'd need a crane and specialized equipment, instead we've got Elizabeth.

Elizabeth has demonstrated as she's grown into adulthood she's got the strength of a small power loader. Now a head taller than Wikowsky and wider at the shoulder, more of her queen genes are starting to express. Heavy maintenance is much easier when you've got someone technical who can also easily pick up three hundred kilogram parts. It takes two weeks but we manage to get both ships fully repaired. On start up, we get green lights across the board.

Sadly, Marco is struggling. Even with the regiment of meds, being in zero gee is not good for healing. The auto-doc is delaying the inevitable. Our hope is that we can get him into a hypersleep pod before we start our journey home. Roxie's fuel plant has started cranking out tons of fuel.

Joanne, who had been so present before during our last crisis has been coming in and out to see our progress and asking questions. Now that we have the coils, word has gotten out that the proposed trip back to Earth is becoming a reality. More than a couple of people have approached her inquiring about how many seats, etc. As our numbers have dwindled, the number of open seats keeps increasing, leading to more interest. Janice and I make the first trip up with trusses and equipment to start putting the ship together and get our eyes on Marco. What we find is distressing. Alice had warned us that he was downplaying how ill he was, but to see him in person is ghastly. I open a side channel to Alice and ask if she thinks he'll likely survive hypersleep. She's cagey but ultimately I force her to give me a true, false answer and she answers with false. I bring this to Marco and he just nods.

"I thought as much. I did some reading on the drugs they pump into you in the sleep chamber and when I entered them into the auto-doc just about every warning about drug interaction popped up."

"What's the plan then?" I ask.

"I'll keep going until I can't, I guess." he replies.

Frankly, I'm surprised he made it this far. We chit chat a bit but looking at the logs, he's sleeping more than sixteen hours a day just to function. Janice and I use the remaining space suit to get the spars in place. Marco watches and provides color commentary. He's sick, but he's still got his wry humor.

Climbing out of the space suit, he floats into the airlock and helps me get my helmet off.

"I need you to um, *you know.*" he says.

I nod. "Alice. Override Theta three omega five for Marco Alverez" I say out loud.

Marco shakes my hand and I shake back and then it turns into an awkward hug.

Alice replies back. "Override accepted."

Janice hugs me as I float into the cockpit seat of the drop ship.

"You did the right thing you know." she says.

I nod.

"How long do you think he's got?" she asks.

I shrug. "He's got options now. But I think a bit longer."

We fly back down in silence. I wonder what the colonial marines will think of this whole mess. Roxie and Jeremy make the next trip with the engines and coils.

Jeremy pings me through subspace. "Man, he's in a rough way."

"Yeah" I respond.

"I see you've unlocked all the meds for him." he notes.

I acknowledge it through the channel.

A couple more hours pass as we watch them mount the engines and additional tanks. I wander over to the palettes of equipment start to see that hypersleep chamber parts are now coming out of the printers. One chamber is a bit larger than the others.

"Coming with us?" I ask Elizabeth.

"I think staying here is going to be hazardous to my health," she notes.

"I don't think you're going to get a warm welcome on Earth either," I reply.

"Certain death vs the unknown, I'll take my chances," she laughs.

I wish I had her optimism. The Colonial Marines are likely going to have hard feelings about Elizabeth. Through this whole thing I've kept a journal of our ordeals and I've taken special note of her contributions. I doubt it'll be enough.

Nine sleep chambers. That's what our little rage tag ship can support. Two of the marines decide to stay. I don't blame them. They'd been spending more and more time with the colonists. With two coils and an eighteen month ramp up to super luminal, we're looking at spending more than eleven years in hyper sleep. The two remaining pods are filled by Ivan's wife and their kid. He told them he was going off to govern a paradise and she found herself underground eating mushrooms, fighting for

scraps surrounded by monsters. Honestly, I thought Joanne might want one of the spots, but she's a second generation settler. When I mentioned she had first pick she just laughed. She'd only every known Acheron. The idea of a dirty crowded Earth sounded entirely unappealing to her. She does inquire about the printer and I laugh. Their little fledging outpost is going to need it. I mentally add it to the list of things I'm likely going to get court marshaled for.

Acheron claims it's last victim in the early morning before we depart. Marco having given more than was asked of him, even in his weakened state had been busy bolting down hypersleep chambers and running cables. With his last task done he sends a simple message.

"Goodbye and Safe travels."

Janice sees it first and opens a channel to Marco but it's too late. It's totally his style. Looking at the logs he rigged the message to send at his time of death.

Alice pings me on a side channel. "Marco has expired. I've sealed the pod."

I acknowledge. We have one last meal with Joanne and Rob and the two marines. Hugs and hardy handshakes and tears.

Wikowsky opens up a terminal and marks the two marines as 'Extended Deployment.'

I pull him aside and ask how he feels about the two marines technically going AWOL.

He just laughs. "Nobody here signed up for any of this shit. Those two were on short time anyway. They'd have slept for eleven years to find themselves walking a piece fence for a couple of months. Instead they'll likely get to teach a bunch of kids how to be marines."

We ferry everybody up to our nameless ragtag ship. Our first order of business is to give Marco a proper burial in space. Alice plays taps. We all have tears. Then like that, we have to continue on. Looking at the sleep chambers, it's clear these are rough and ready affairs.

The first asleep is Vicky and Charles, Ivan's wife and son. Both of them were less than excited when they saw the state of things. Wikowsky, Miller and Jeremy are next into their pods.

"Little rough around the edges," laughs Wikowsky.

"But tested and working," notes Elizabeth.

"I trust your engineering skills. See you guys on the flip side!" with that he hits the button and the lid closes with a big goofy grin on his face. The display shows his vitals frozen. Jeremy and Benko are already fast asleep.

We see Ziegler climbing into his. “I don’t love zero gee. I’d rather get this over with.” I can see he’s a bit green around the gills. Elizabeth watches with wonder as her father closes the lid and triggers the controls. His vitals slowly fade to stable and freeze. Not even a hug or a goodbye. That’s Ziegler for you.

“Alice, are your calculations complete for the jump?” I ask.

“Yes. My navigation data is limited compared to what the DeBe contained, but will be sufficient.” Alice replies.

The four of us start the sequence and strap in, the ship starts accelerating. It’s smooth but steady 1.2g’s. Every second we pile on the speed. The coils start stacking energy for their first superluminal push.

We set the controls and climb into our pods.

Elizabeth’s super sized pod look out of place. Climbing in, she smiles as the cover closes.

I’m the last to trigger the sleep controls. My fear of losing control causes me to pause at pressing the button.

I wonder if I’m doing the right thing. Too late, but maybe Janice and I could have made something on this planet? I let out a deep breath and say to nobody in particular “Here goes nothing” and I press the button. I feel the cold creep into my arm through the auto-doc cuff. Then I feel nothing.

#####

Thanks for reading! I hope you’ve enjoyed my bit of fanfic! It was a joy to write. I definitely feel there might be more story here. Let me know what directions you’d like it to take?

You can find me at turbofx@gmail.com and at https://timkellerauthor.com

Thanks,

Tim Keller

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